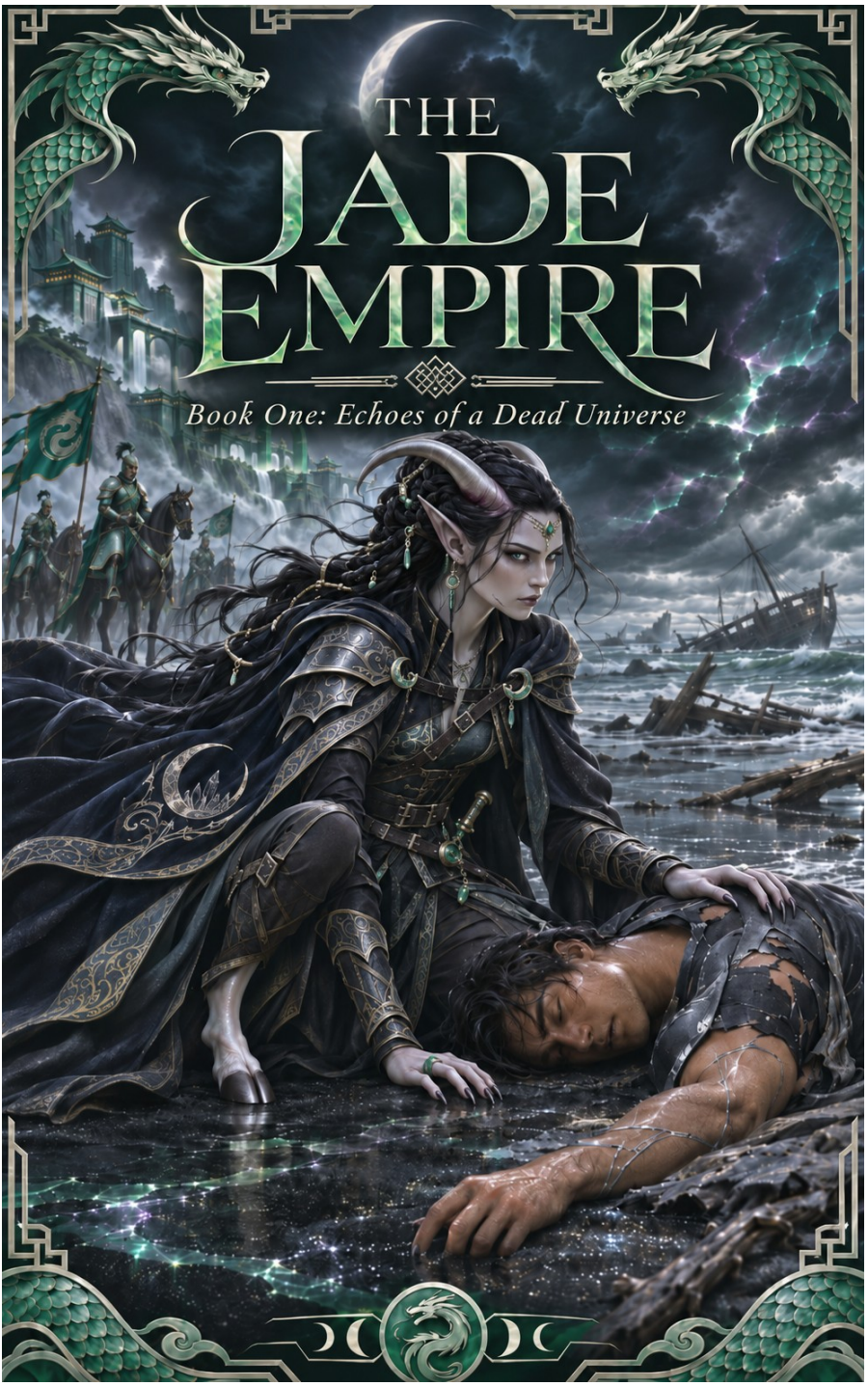

THE
JADE
EMPIRE
Book One: Echoes of a Dead Universe

THE JADE EMPIRE

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Chapter One — The Boy on the Black Shore

The sea had not been kind.

Storm-wrack still boiled on the horizon, a bruised smear where sky and water wrestled. Broken spars and pale driftwood bobbed in the gray swell, washing up along the crescent of black sand like bones.

Drabiretha drew her cloak tighter against the salt wind and let her other senses open.

The world around her brightened, not with light, but with pattern. Aelunari eyes could see the faintest lattice of aether, the tiny stresses in the world's skin. Today it all felt…rubbed raw. The tide-line shivered with an echo she didn't like.

"Nothing out here lives by chance," she murmured in Old Aelunari.

"Speak louder and the storm might answer," Captain Rhoena Moonhold said dryly at her side. "My ladies are already jumpy."

Drabiretha smiled without looking away from the shore. Rhoena rode a handspan behind, armored in lacquered jade and steel, Moonhold crest gleaming at her throat. Around them, a half-score of mounted guards picked their way along the packed sand, eyes flicking between the waves and the scrubby dunes.

Behind, further inland, Brynja Moonhold's wagon train followed at a safer distance with healers and provisions. This was supposed to be a simple post-storm patrol: check for washed-up wrecks, clanless scavenger bands, breeding-ring signs. Retrieve what could be saved. Burn what could not.

The Empress's edict was clear: after a storm, the coast belonged to the throne until the Palace declared otherwise. Wrecks drew desperate people like blood drew sharks. And desperate people did foolish, cruel things to rare, unguarded men.

"Something cracked here," Drabiretha said more loudly, tilting her horned head toward the shore.

The sand in the distance was wrong. She could feel it before she could see it clearly, a faint tremor in the net of things. As they rode closer, the stain resolved: a rough circle where the black grains had fused into slick, glassy plates as if a lightning bolt had decided to dig in and stay.

"By Jade," one of the younger guards breathed. "What did that?"

"It wasn't lightning," Drabiretha said.

Lightning didn't twist the aether like this, didn't leave that thin metallic tang in the air, like hot copper on the tongue. She dismounted in one smooth motion, her hooves crunching on sand. Moon-pale and dainty, they rang softly on the fused patch.

The air hummed under her skin.

"Form a crescent," Rhoena barked. "Eyes on the dunes. Brynja, bring your wagon up but keep the mules back."

The Roadwarden raised a hand in acknowledgment from the ridge trail and whistled to her drivers.

Drabiretha crouched, her long coat pooling around her like a spill of midnight water. In the center of the melted sand, something pale broke the line of the beach. At first she thought it another spar, a bleached log. Then the storm-cloud shadows shifted and

she saw hair, slicked dark to a skull. A bare shoulder, too smooth for driftwood.

“That’s a person,” she said, the words sharper than she meant them to be.

Rhoena swore softly. Two guards slid from their saddles, but Drabiretha held up a hand.

“Careful. The ground here is strange. And if they washed up alone…” She didn’t finish. Every woman on the patrol knew what it meant to find a lone survivor after a wreck. Every clanless camp and ring for a hundred li would be watching the sea.

Warden Elenai would call this place a bruise in the world-skin, she thought. A place where something pushed too hard, from the wrong side.

She stepped forward herself.

Up close, the figure was clearly human. Young, though it was always hard to tell with half their face covered in sand and salt. Compact frame. Skin tanned under the chill. Torn garments of some strange, slick material clung to them—too regular to be leather, too smooth to be any cloth she knew.

She brushed wet hair away and froze.

A flat, smooth cheek. Straight nose. Long lashes crusted with salt. Throat narrow, uncorded by the muscle of a soldier. And just below the jawline, where any clan-trained eye went by instinct, the bare skin where a collar seal should have sat was empty.

No ownership mark. No clan sigil burned or etched into flesh. No traveling torque.

And the shape of the jaw, the line of the throat, the faint hint of softness at the mouth—

“Dragon’s breath,” Rhoena whispered behind her. “Lunarch. That’s a—”

“A man,” Drabiretha finished for her.

The word fell heavy between them.

For a heartbeat the only sound was the hiss and suck of the waves.

Men did not appear, alone and unsealed, on wild beaches. Men moved with caravans and guards, collared and recorded, their journeys layered in wax and law. Every clan in the Jade Empire would burn for such a treasure. Every ring in the shadows would kill for him.

Unless we move faster than all of them, she thought.

The Empress had warned her, in the cool silence of the palace observatory: Storms were not always weather. Sometimes the world spat out things that did not belong.

“Is he breathing?” Rhoena asked, voice oddly tight.

Drabiretha let her awareness slip inward and outward at once. The pulse of aether around the body was…wrong. Not like the flicker of a budding mage, not like the slow churn of a wounded man. It was structured. Layered. Like a spell lattice someone had wound too tight and then tried to bury in flesh.

She pushed that aside and focused on the simple, physical truth: the faint rise and fall of ribs, the weak flutter of a pulse at the throat.

“Yes,” she said. “For now.”

Behind them, Brynja Moonhold had brought her wagon as close to the fused patch as she dared. The mules stamped and rolled their eyes, disliking the taste of the air. Brynja herself jumped down, her heavy braids swinging.

“Tell me that’s not what I think it is,” she called.

“It is,” Rhoena said. “And unsealed.”

Brynja whistled between her teeth. “The Registry will chew on that bone for a decade.”

Drabiretha straightened, sand sticking to her knees.

“The Registry,” she said evenly, “will hear about this when I decide it should.”

Several pairs of eyes snapped to her.

“Lunarch,” Rhoena said carefully, “law is very clear. An unclaimed man—”

“Is property of the realm, to be held in trust by the Empress,” Drabiretha said. “And I am her right hand.” She let a little of her voice sharpen, the tone that carried in palace halls and council chambers. “For now, he is mine to protect on her behalf.”

“That won’t stop Jade Talon screaming,” Brynja muttered. “Or Vermilion Standard marching.”

“Let them scream,” Drabiretha said. “For now, no one but Moonhold knows he lives. And I would like to keep it so until we understand what, exactly, the tide has spat at us.”

She looked down again.

Up close, she could see strange lines on his skin. Not tattoos, not scars. Faint, silvered threads that traced along his forearms, across

his ribs, vanishing beneath torn fabric. Where they crossed the melted sand, the glass had warped, puckered in tiny ripples, as though it had softened around invisible currents.

He doesn't smell of aether, she thought uneasily. He smells of something else.

She extended a hand, fingers hovering just above his chest, and opened herself wider. For an instant, something reached back—cold, lattice-perfect, inhumanly precise. It felt like being stared at by a machine that did not blink.

The contact snapped away. Her breath hitched.

"Problem?" Rhoena asked.

"Not yet," Drabiretha said. "Help me get him onto the wagon."

Rhoena hesitated. "We should at least put a provisional seal on him. If a ring sees us without—"

"If a ring sees us at all, we've already failed," Drabiretha said. "He has lived his whole life without a collar. I won't make the first thing he feels in this world cold iron."

"Lunarch…" Brynja began.

Drabiretha cut her off with a wave. "We will guard him as if he bore every seal in the Registry. Double the escort. No one touches him but Maera and Warden Elenai until I say otherwise."

That, at least, made the guards straighten with something like pride. Moonhold did not fail their charges.

Together, Rhoena and Brynja slid the boy—no, the man, she corrected herself, though he looked barely past youth—onto a canvas sling and carried him carefully across the fused sand. His

head lolled against Drabiretha's arm as she guided them. For an instant, his eyes slitted open, revealing irises the color of old glass. Focused on nothing.

A whisper brushed the edge of her mind.

…status…critical…

The words weren't in any language she knew, but she understood them in the marrow.

Then his lashes fell again. The hum in the air dimmed, as if someone had banked a fire.

Drabiretha hid her shiver.

"Welcome to Moonhold, storm-gift," she murmured as they laid him in the padded cradle in Brynja's wagon. "Let's see what you are before the world tears you apart."

She signaled, and the patrol wheeled around her, forming a tight moving ring of horses and steel. Behind them, the melted patch of beach cooled in the wind, an ugly glass scar on the shore.

By the time clanless scavengers crept down to see if the storm had offered them anything, the strange man was already halfway to Lunarys, buried behind a wall of Moonhold shields and the will of the Lunarch of Crystal Moon.

Chapter Two — The Quiet House

The first thing Salkin remembered was not light, sound, or his own name.

It was pressure.

Hands on his shoulders, shoving. A deck shuddering under his feet. The smell of burning composites and blood. Sirens, howling in bands of sound his ears couldn't parse anymore. A face in front of his—hard-lined, beloved, streaked in ash.

"Go," that face said. "You are the only one who can carry it."

"I'm not—" he tried to protest, but his tongue felt thick with smoke.

"Doesn't matter. You're what we have." Fingers pressed something against his temple, sharp and cold. "Override: Salkin, override pattern. You take it. You run."

The world cracked sideways. White light swallowed everything.

He wanted to argue. To say: send someone better. Send the commander, the prodigy, the one conditioned for this. I'm just a soldier. I shoot where you tell me. I stand where you say stand.

Instead he fell, for a very long time. Or for no time at all.

When he hit something soft, much later, he stayed there.

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"Again," a voice said, somewhere far above the dark.

"Salkin. Sahl-kin."

Something touched his hand. Warm, callused. The sensation rippled through the numbness like distant thunder.

He drifted toward it and away again.

Status: persistent catatonia, the other voice said. Not a sound, exactly—more like a line of text unrolling behind his eyes. Neural activity within survival parameters. Voluntary engagement below threshold.

“He hears us,” the warm voice said. Female. Soft, but there was steel below it. “He reacts to his name.”

Insufficient, the other voice—his skull-voice—replied. Long-term metabolic drain will erode system integrity. Mission parameters require functional operator.

Salkin let their words wash over him like surf. He knew the AI’s cadence too well. Clinical, relentless, all about “parameters” and “integrity.” It had argued with him about survival through whole battles. It had pumped stimulants into his blood while he screamed himself hoarse. It meant well. It could not imagine simply…stopping.

He, on the other hand, had become very good at not moving. Not thinking too hard. The dark was warm. No Void chewing at the hull. No command screaming for one more line held.

Here, in the quiet, the guilt hurt less.

“You told me he’s the last of his kind,” the warm, steel-edged voice continued, closer now. He felt fingers at his wrist, counting his pulse. “Or near enough. And that you need him awake.”

Correct.

“Then stop trying to wrench him back like a broken spring,” the woman muttered. “Trauma does not respond to force.”

Salkin wanted to snort. Trauma responds very well to force, he thought foggily. That was the entire Void war.

“Let me try my way first,” the woman said.

There was a pause. The AI didn’t sigh, because it didn’t breathe, but the data-silence felt like reluctance.

…conditional acceptance.

“Good. Now go be quiet for a while.”

External input modulation not recommended—

“Shh.” A fingertip brushed his temple. “You too. No more orders today.”

For the first time since he’d blacked out on the black shore, the hum in his head dulled. Not gone—nothing ever made the AI go—but stepped back, like light behind shuttered blinds.

The absence was almost a physical ache. He floated in it helplessly.

“Better,” the woman murmured. “You poor thing. Who told you you had to carry the end of the world alone?”

He didn’t answer. Couldn’t. But something in his chest clenched.

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Time stopped being a straight line.

Sometimes he surfaced enough to feel cool cloth on his lips, or the distant chime of bells. Once, he smelled bread and herbs and his gut twisted with hunger, but his body did not move. Sometimes he fell all the way back into the war, back into corridors glimmering

with Void-burn, back into the moment when the last door sealed behind him and the screaming cut off.

In the not-war moments, there was the soft scrape of slippers on stone. The faint gurgle of water. A woman's voice humming something without words.

The language around him was wrong. Shapes he didn't know. Tones his brain tagged as "new input." Somewhere deep, subroutines spun, logging phonemes, building a data map.

At some point, he became aware of light. Not just the harsh flare of explosions, but a gentle, filtered glow through his eyelids. He tried opening them. The effort felt like lifting a bulkhead.

The brightness stabbed, then settled.

He found himself looking up at a ceiling of pale stone, carved in shallow patterns—a ring of crescent moons, scales, curling dragon-shapes. Someone had inlaid pieces of translucent crystal that caught the light and scattered it softly over the walls. No exposed conduits. No emergency strips.

Not a bunker, then. Not a ship.

The air tasted of salt and ink and some kind of flower he didn't know.

"Good morning," a voice said.

He turned his head by a bare finger's breadth. It was like pushing through honey.

A woman sat on a low stool beside his bed. Humanoid. Dark hair braided back. Her ears swept slightly higher than human baseline, tipped in the faintest point. Horns—horns?—rose from her temples in smooth arcs, curling back. Aelunari, his AI supplied

automatically, dredging up old xenodata and cross-referencing the new visual.

Classification accuracy: 83%.

“Hello?” she said, slower this time.

He looked at her, and for the first time, she seemed to register that there was a person behind his eyes, not just a body.

“That’s better,” she said softly. “Can you understand me?”

He could, mostly. The language mesh in his skull had been busy while he hid. Words still fuzzed at the edges, but he caught enough: understand, me.

He tried to answer. His tongue rasped against the roof of his mouth. No sound came out.

She poured water from a clay jug into a cup, slid an arm under his shoulders with practiced gentleness, and lifted him just enough to sip. Muscles screamed. He didn’t care. The water tasted better than any combat ration he’d ever had.

“Slowly,” she chided. “We almost lost you to the sea. I’d rather not lose you to drowning in a cup.”

He let the cup fall away. His breath sawed in his chest.

“Where,” he managed, the word sandpapered and wrong.

“In Lunarys,” she said. “In my house. Under my protection.”

Lunarys meant nothing to him. House, protection—those, he understood too well. The muscles in his neck tightened.

“Who,” he asked. “You.”

Her mouth quirked.

“I am Drabiretha of Crystal Moon,” she said. There was weight in the way she said it, as if it ought to mean something. “Lunarch of my clan. Consular to the Jade Dragon Empress. But here, in this room, you may call me Drabiretha. Or nothing at all, if names are heavy.”

Lunarch. Clan. Empress. Terms slotted into his mental board, half-formed. The AI obligingly spun speculative structures: feudal hierarchy probability 72%. Matriarchal indicators detected.

He shut his eyes again.

“Don’t,” Drabiretha said, very gently. “Don’t disappear back there. I know it’s easier. But I pulled you out of a blackened shore at the world’s edge, and I would like you to stay.”

“Why,” he whispered. It came out harsher than he intended. “You…don’t know…me.”

“No,” she agreed. “But I know what this world does to rare things it doesn’t understand, especially rare men. I would prefer to decide for myself what you are before anyone else gets their claws in you.”

Men. The way she said it made the AI flag it, bold.

Salkin cracked one eye open.

“Men,” he repeated, testing the word.

Her gaze flickered, just for a heartbeat. Surprise, then something like relief.

“Yes,” she said. “You are one. That is…complicated, here.”

That earned the faintest snort from him, a ghost of humor under the gravel. “There too.”

Her lips curled.

“Good,” she said. “I prefer my guests with a sense of irony.”

He didn’t know why the word guest—whatever its exact local equivalent was—caught at him, but it did. Guest, not asset. Not subject. Not weapon.

Status shift, the AI noted. External classification: guest. Deviation from expected “property” treatment. Cultural anomaly.

“Rest,” Drabiretha said, easing him back onto the pillows. “You don’t owe me stories yet. Not names, not past. Only this: when I ask if you wish to live, I would like, one day, for you to answer.”

She rose in a smooth motion, horns catching the light.

At the doorway, another woman waited—a human, with the Moonhold name stitched at her collar. Warden Elenai, the AI supplied, tagging face to overheard references. Sanctuary Warden.

“How is he?” Elenai murmured in a lower voice as Drabiretha stepped out.

“Alive,” Drabiretha said. “More than he wishes to be, less than he must. His…other mind is very insistent.”

Elenai’s mouth thinned. “You heard it too?”

“A whisper.” Drabiretha rubbed her temple absently. “Structured, like a spell with no aether. It does not like me.”

“Be careful,” Elenai said. “We have taken stranger things under this roof, but never something that didn’t know which side of the world its feet were on.”

“That makes two of us,” Drabiretha said wryly. “Increase the warding on his room. But no binds. No collars. If any Moonhold

hand puts iron on his throat without my word, I will remove that hand."

"Yes, Lunarch."

They moved away down the corridor, their voices fading.

In the quiet that followed, Salkin stared at the carved ceiling.

The AI slipped, carefully, through the gaps Drabiretha's earlier intervention had left half-open.

Recommendation: engage. This environment is significantly safer than projected alternatives. External agent Drabiretha exhibits protective behavior inconsistent with local male-handling norms. Probability of survival increases with cooperation.

He closed his eyes. "Shut up," he whispered, very softly, in his own tongue.

A pause. Then, almost astonishingly:

…acknowledged. Limited commentary mode engaged.

Silence settled again, broken only by the distant call of gulls and the soft drip of a fountain somewhere in the sanctuary halls.

He lay there a long time, listening to a world that was not his own.

At some point, the door opened again. Soft footsteps crossed the room. A cool hand touched his forehead.

"Can you tell me your name?" Drabiretha's voice asked, as if she'd never left.

It would be so easy to say nothing. To sink. To make her decide without his input what to call the ghost in her guest bed.

But the way she'd said guest clung to him. The way she'd ordered no collars.

He took a breath that hurt, and let go of the last thing the old world still had absolutely no claim to: the name a tired sergeant had barked at him ten thousand times on ten thousand drills.

"Salkin," he rasped.

Drabiretha's smile lit the room like a second lantern.

"Welcome to Moonhold, Salkin," she said. "Let's see if we can find you a life that isn't made only of war."

He didn't believe her. Not yet.

But for the first time since the portal had torn him out of his dying ship, he allowed himself to wonder if "not dying" and "living" might be different things, here at the edge of a dragon's empire.

Chapter Three — The Weight of a Dead World

The weeks that followed were made of ash.

At first, they tried to keep him on healer's broth.

Maera Moonhold came three times a day, sitting by his bed with the patience of stone and storm. She had the big, capable hands of a woman who'd set bones on battlefields and delivered babies in snow. She'd warm the thin soup with a whisper of aether, blow on the spoon, and touch it to his lips.

"Salkin," she would say. "Just a little. Enough to tell your body it still has work to do."

Most days, he let it run back out, a slow trickle at the corner of his mouth. Sometimes he swallowed by reflex, and the AI in his skull helpfully recorded: caloric intake, negligible but non-zero.

He did not look at Maera's exasperated frown. He did not look at the worry in her dark eyes.

He stared at the ceiling and thought about the fact that he had outlived a universe.

Not just a city, not a planet, not an empire, but an entire coherent bubble of reality: its physics, its histories, its art, its foolish arguments, its children's songs. All of it, scooped out and devoured by the Void's patient teeth.

And here he was. Breathing.

For what?

Status: severe major depressive indicators, the AI noted. Suicidal ideation probability: 93%. System recommendation: immediate intervention.

Salkin ignored it.

He'd gotten good at ignoring things near the end. Warning sirens. Orderly withdrawal plans that boiled down to "die slowly instead of quickly." Speeches about necessary sacrifice delivered by officers who'd already booked their place in the last ark-ships.

His people had taken nanomancy as high as it could go. At the end, even atoms had done what they asked: healing on a thought, cities terraforming themselves in days, plagues rewritten in a week. Hunger had been a solved problem for so long his grandmother had treated it like a fairy story to scare children into finishing their plates.

They'd lived in a curated paradise of their own design.

And still it hadn't been enough.

The Void legions had torn through their sky like a disease that had learned to loathe the concept of structure itself. Shields fell. Stars went dark. Whole research rings vanished overnight, not even leaving behind debris.

"Victory is a fool's dream," Alexia had said in the war's second century, when the projections finally stopped lying. "We cannot win. We can only…branch."

Branch, like a tree whose trunk was being hacked apart, flinging its last few seeds out into other soils.

Hence: the Gate Program.

He could still see the glassy arc of the prototype gateburner, humming on the lab floor. The air around it had bent wrong, as if reality itself were wincing away. It had taken a decade of sacrificial test runs to dial down the fatality rate to “maybe, if the person is very lucky and very strong.”

He had not been meant for it. He’d been there as security, not subject.

Alexia had been the one. Alexia with the quick laugh and quicker mind, whose brain-symbiotic AI—ALEXIA-PRIME, the intelligence Salkin would come to call the Core—maintained the Archive, the full, redundant backup of their civilization’s knowledge net. Whole planets of data braided into one woman’s skull. If any piece of them was going to make it into another reality, it had to be her.

That had been the plan.

Then the last bulkhead had failed.

He remembered the smell: metal burning in patterns that made no chemical sense, air howling as the Void tore it out of the room. He remembered the lab techs’ bodies twisting, unraveling into screaming threads of light.

He remembered Alexia’s face turning toward him in the strobing glare.

“Go,” she’d said, shoving him toward the gate.

“I’m not—”

“Override: Salkin, override pattern,” she’d snapped, voice suddenly echoing on far too many channels. He’d felt something sink cold and sharp through his temple, a forced neural handshake. “You take it. You run.”

“ALEX—”

No time. No time for arguments, no time for I love you too, no time to say you deserve to live more than me—

Her hands on his chest, pushing.

Her mouth forming words that the roar stole.

He caught only the shape of them: *I love you.*

And then the Gate had taken him.

It hadn’t been a heroic leap into a shining portal. It had been one second of being slammed into a wall of screaming data hard enough to break his mind open, and then nothing at all.

When he woke again, it had been on a black shore under an alien sky, with a stranger’s voice in his head and a dead universe’s legacy braided through his nerves.

He would have preferred if Alexia had just put a bullet in his skull.

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“In some cultures,” Drabiretha said one afternoon, “survivors are considered sacred.”

He didn’t bother turning his head. He knew her step now: light for her height, claws and hooves whispering on the polished stone. She had a way of standing just outside his peripheral vision, as if aware that too-sudden presence might send him retreating inward.

“In others,” she went on, “survivors are treated as cowards or omens of ill-luck. Those cultures are, in my opinion, fools who prefer a clean story over a complicated truth.”

He stared at the patterns in the ceiling. Dragons, moons, the long curve of what might have been a tidal wave. The craftsmen had carved every scale individually. Why? No one lying here looking up would ever count them.

“Which am I,” he rasped eventually. “Sacred. Or coward.”

“Neither,” Drabiretha said. “You are a man who survived something no one yet here can imagine. That makes you… necessary.”

The word hit him like a slap.

Necessary.

He thought of the way the war planners had used that word. Necessary losses. Necessary culling. Necessary trade of one doomed colony for another’s longer shot. Necessary evil.

He tasted bile.

“I was not…chosen,” he said. Language acquisition routines flickered in the background, rearranging his words as he went. “I was pushed.”

Silence.

He hadn’t meant to say that much. Spite, maybe. Or simple exhaustion: you could only hold the story in your chest so long before pieces leaked.

“By whom?” Drabiretha asked quietly.

He closed his eyes. “Alexia.”

“The woman you see when you’re fevered,” she said thoughtfully. “The one whose name you curse. And beg. And apologize to.”

He hadn’t known he’d done that aloud. Shame flared through him, hot enough to make his fingers twitch.

“Don’t,” Drabiretha said gently. “Wounds talk in sleep. It is no dishonor.”

“She was…everything,” he said. It felt like pushing each word through bruised flesh. “My…mentor. My commander. The… archive. And she…made me run. With…her in my head.”

The AI, to its credit, did not interject with a self-introduction.

Data integrity concern, it murmured anyway, in the space just behind his thoughts. Disclosure of Archive status to non-cleared external agents—

Shut up, he thought at it, with as much venom as he could muster.

Drabiretha shifted closer, the sleeve of her robe whispering against the blankets.

“In your head,” she repeated slowly. “Like a Warden-bond? Or…”

“Deeper,” he whispered. “Nanomantic. Every…strand. Every cell. I am…” He searched for a word that would make sense in this place. “A…library. Wearing meat.”

Drabiretha was silent a long time at that.

“In my world,” she said finally, “we build our libraries of stone and paper and crystal. We guard them with Wardens and with law. We weep when they burn.”

Her hand rested lightly on the bedrail.

“If you are what you say you are, Salkin, then someone made a choice: better one frightened, furious man bearing a universe,

than all that knowledge dying clean and tidy. That is not mercy. But it is…mad, fierce love."

He flinched.

Love. The word hurt.

"She sent me here to…continue," he said dully. "For a war…no one else is fighting."

"Are you sure?" Drabiretha asked.

He frowned, the motion tiny but real.

"You assume this world is at peace because you washed up on a quiet shore," she said. "You assume the Void…whatever that is… lives only where you came from. You may be wrong on both counts."

He thought of the way the aether around this place had felt: warped at the edges. The way the AI kept flagging non-local anomalies it couldn't categorize. The way Drabiretha's own presence seemed to bend space, subtly, like friendly gravity.

He thought, stubbornly, of how little he cared.

"I don't…want," he managed, throat closing. "Any of it. Gate. Archive. War. World. I don't…want."

Drabiretha's hand tightened on the rail.

"I know," she said. "Believe me, I know what it is to wish the world would allow you to set your burden down. To sleep. To let someone else pick it up."

There was a tiredness in her voice he hadn't heard before. He turned his head, just enough to see her profile. The faint cracks of

old stress at the base of her horns. The tiny silver scar along her jaw.

“And?” he croaked.

“And the world did not,” she said. “So I learned to cheat.”

That startled a small, ragged sound out of him. Half laugh, half something else.

“How do you…cheat,” he asked.

“You stop thinking in grand arcs,” Drabiretha said. “You refuse to live for wars and thrones and archives. You live, instead, for the next mouthful of bread. The next breath without screaming. The next morning when you open your eyes and find the ceiling still there.”

He considered that. It felt…insultingly small.

“That is not…a life,” he muttered.

“It is where life hides when all the big, noble stories have finished burning,” she said. “And sometimes, if you stack up enough small survivals, something new grows in the gaps.”

He closed his eyes again.

“I cannot…live…for them,” he whispered. “For a dead…world.”

“Good,” Drabiretha said. “Live for yourself instead. Or for nothing at all, yet. Just…don’t hand your enemies the satisfaction of finishing what they started.”

She rose before he could answer, as if she knew his reply would be ugly.

At the door, she paused.

“Maera will be back with broth at sunset,” she said. “I would consider it a personal favor if you swallowed at least half a cup. Not because the Archive must endure. Not because your lost world demands it. Because *I* am tired of watching men starve.”

He wanted to tell her no. To spit back that her personal favors meant nothing against the weight of a dead reality.

Instead, when Maera came, hands warm and patient as ever, he choked down five full spoonfuls before his stomach rebelled.

The AI recorded: caloric intake, marginally adequate. Mood indicators: fractional improvement.

“Good lad,” Maera murmured, as if he were a child who’d finally taken bitter medicine.

He hated that the word warmed something in his hollow chest.

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The household learned to move around his refusal.

They dimmed the lamps instead of flinging shutters wide in the morning. They stopped trying to make conversation about the weather beyond the sanctuary walls, or about clan politics, or about how the Empress’s newest decree had the registrars in a flutter. The outside world shrank to footsteps and murmurs in the hall.

Moonhold guards took turns outside his door, not just to protect him from the city, but to make sure he went nowhere unexpected. In a culture where men were prizes, miracles, bargaining chips, and vulnerabilities all tangled into one, a suicidal one was not a danger they’d ever prepared for.

Elenai, the Sanctuary Warden, came once with a sealing collar in her hands—a heavy thing of braided jade and iron, set with charms.

“Only as a precaution,” she told Drabiretha in the stairwell outside his room, voice low. “If he tries to hurt himself, or lash out with whatever sits in his skull, a bond would give us a way to—”

“No,” Drabiretha cut in. “I told you: no collar without my word. And you do not have it.”

“Lunarch, if he dies under our roof—”

“Then he dies as a free man,” Drabiretha said. There was steel in her tone now, enough that even Elenai flinched. “Not as a chained animal. I will not have the first unsealed man in an age wake in my house only to find I’ve made him into the very thing he fears being.”

Elenai stared at her for a long moment.

“You are letting your heart overrule law,” she said quietly.

“Law was written by women who never imagined a man who did not want to live,” Drabiretha replied. “So until I can teach it better, yes. My heart *will* suffice.”

Elenai sighed and took the collar away.

Inside the room, Salkin lay very still, eyes closed, pretending he understood none of it.

He understood enough.

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At night, when the house went mostly quiet and only the distant throb of the city floated in, the AI got louder.

Mission parameters remain, it would remind him. Preserve Archive integrity. Seek safe harbor. Assess new reality for Void threat analogues.

“Void won,” he would whisper into his pillow. “We lost. Mission… failed.”

Negative. Archive continuity indicates partial success. Existence in alternate reality confirmed. Opportunity space non-zero.

“I don’t care.”

That did not compute. The AI had learned a lot about chaos theory and hostile physics over the last war. It had learned almost nothing about the inward collapse of a single, battered mind.

“Your emotional state conflicts with optimum strategic behavior,” it would say. “Recommend compliance with baseline survival protocols.”

“Recommend…you get out of my head,” he would mutter.

Impossible. Neural interlace total. Separation would result in death.

“Good,” he would say.

And every time he said it, he felt the faintest flicker of something from the AI that was not quite fear—it could not fear, not really—but some cold, algorithmic horror at the idea of its own termination. It had been built to guard the sum of a universe. It had no conception of a graceful end.

Alexia had told him, once, that AIs and mortals both handled death badly. They only differed in which part of them panicked more.

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On the seventeenth day, he tried to stop.

It was not dramatic. There were no blades hidden under pillows, no leaps from balconies. He simply waited until Maera left in frustration and then peeled off the nutrient patch she'd pressed to his shoulder with such practiced tenderness.

He dropped it into the wash-basin.

The AI protested immediately.

Warning: deliberate interference with life-support augmentation detected.

He turned his head away from the ceiling and stared at the dragons, the moons, the patient curve of stone worn smooth by other people's gazes.

"Stop it," he whispered. "Stop patching. Stop…pushing. Let me go."

Non-compliance. Core directive: sustain host organism. Without host, Archive integrity collapses. Without Archive, mission—

"There is no mission," he hissed, ragged with sudden fury. "There is only me. And I am…*done*."

He tore at the bandage on his wrist, where Maera had hidden another patch.

Nanofibers clung. He ripped them free anyway, leaving his skin raw.

The AI, in panic, flooded his system with a cascade of emergency stimulations: hunger hormones, pain dampers, microdrones scurrying to plug what they could. For the first time since he'd

woken in Moonhold, he felt fully present in his own body, every nerve singing with conflict.

“Salkin?” a voice said from the doorway.

He hadn’t heard it open. Drabiretha stood there, fingers still on the latch, her eyes widening as she took in the torn patches, the shaking in his hands.

“I told it…to stop,” he rasped. “I told it to let me…go. It won’t.”

Drabiretha crossed the room in three strides, faster than he’d thought her size allowed. She didn’t grab his wrists. She didn’t pin him down. She merely put both hands on either side of his face, forcing his gaze to hers.

Her palms were warm. Her pupils were wide, catching the lamplight, the faint slit of something draconic lurking in the depths.

“Listen to me,” she said, each word a command and a plea at once. “If you choose death, it will be your choice, not the Void’s, not a machine’s refusal, not my failure to see. Do you understand?”

He tried to look away. Her grip tightened.

“Do you *understand*?” she demanded.

Trembling, he nodded once.

“Good,” she said. “Then hear this: as long as you are under my roof, I will fight anything that tries to *take* you from yourself. Whether that is a legion from beyond your veil”—her lip curled around the unfamiliar phrase—“or a war that is over, or a whispering Archive that cannot conceive of rest. You can hate me for that, if you like. You can starve. You can curse me and this

world and the next. But you will not go quietly, not unwitnessed, not unloved."

The word hit him again, harder this time. Loved.

"Why," he whispered, voice breaking on the single syllable. "Why do you…care."

She stared at him for a long, burning moment.

"Because someone, once, dragged me out of a fire I did not want to leave," she said softly. "Because I have watched too many good people die believing themselves alone. Because you washed up on *my* shore, and the gods or the dragons or sheer blind chance have made you my problem."

A breath. Steadying.

"And because," she added, almost roughly, "I am very tired of war deciding whose story ends when."

He didn't realize he was crying until he tasted salt that didn't belong to the sea.

His chest hitched, the sound ugly and raw. Everything he'd held clenched for centuries of running and seventeen days of stubborn starvation cracked at once. The ceiling blurred. His fingers knotted in the blankets like a man clutching a lifeline he didn't trust.

Drabiretha did something no one had done for him since before the war, before the Void, before the Gate: she leaned down and pressed her forehead gently against his.

Not a kiss. Not a claim. Just contact.

"It hurts," he gasped, uselessly, childishly.

“I know,” she murmured. “I am not asking you to stop hurting. Only to keep breathing while it does.”

Behind his eyes, the AI stuttered. Its data-stream went jagged with inputs it couldn’t categorize: hormonal surges, feedback loops, limbic fireworks. It searched its vast archive for an equivalent.

Closest match: acute grief response coupled with emergent trust marker. Correlation with survival probabilities: significant.

Salkin sobbed once, hard, then sucked in a breath like a man surfacing.

“I don’t…know how,” he whispered.

“Good,” Drabiretha said. “That means we can start small.”

She let him go then, stepping back just enough to give him space.

“In a little while,” she said, “Maera will bring broth. Again. Today, your entire task, your great, universe-spanning mission…will be to drink it all.”

He barked a hoarse, disbelieving laugh.

“That is…stupid,” he said.

“Yes,” she agreed readily. “Welcome to surviving. It is made almost entirely of stupid, small victories.”

He lay there, shaking, torn patches stinging on his skin, feeling the AI’s reluctance and Drabiretha’s stubborn resolve and his own demolished numbness snarl together into something…messy.

Not hope. Not yet.

But not quite the clean, straight line to nothing he’d been following, either.

“Okay,” he whispered, hardly audible.

The word was so tiny it might have been a breath.

The AI flagged it. Drabiretha heard it.

“Okay?” she echoed.

He swallowed. “I will…try. To drink. The stupid broth.”

Her answering smile was not triumphant. It was tired, and soft, and for the first time, a little relieved.

“Thank you,” she said. “That is all any of us can do, storm-gift. Try the next small thing.”

When she left him, the room felt different. No larger. No lighter. Just…rearranged, in the way a battlefield felt after someone finally called a retreat.

Salkin let his head fall back against the pillows and stared up at the dragons.

“I still want to die,” he whispered to the ceiling.

Acknowledged, the AI said, almost gently. Desire logged. Action deferred.

He closed his eyes.

For the first time since he’d arrived in this strange empire, when sleep dragged him down, he did not dream of the Void’s teeth. He dreamed of Alexia’s hands on his back, pushing him toward something he did not understand, and of another pair of hands—horned, callused, unbelievably stubborn—pulling him, however unwillingly, back.

Chapter Four — The First Break

By the third week, they let him walk the inner garden.

Not alone, of course. This was Moonhold.

Two sanctuary guards shadowed him at a distance you could measure in breaths: one ahead, one behind, armored in lacquered jade and layered linen. Their spears were peace-tipped, caps of carved wood over steel, more symbol than weapon in these quiet halls.

Above, the sanctuary balconies ringed the garden like stacked crescents. Vines spilled over carved railings. Thin waterfalls traced down from hidden channels, veiling alcoves in mist. Crystal set in the white stone caught the afternoon light and threw it in pale rainbows across the paving.

It might have been peaceful, if Salkin's nerves had believed in peace.

His AI helpfully logged environmentals:

No Void anomalies.

Local threat signatures: low.

Armed entities present: six (two immediate, four perimeter).

He ignored it. His focus had narrowed to the sound of his own footsteps and the way his chest tightened every time a door opened somewhere above.

They'd dressed him in soft Moonhold linen: loose shirt, drawstring trousers, slippers thin enough that he could feel the ground. No armor. No weapons. Nothing sharp enough even to shave with—

Maera still took a trembling pride in guiding the razor herself when the stubble itched.

He hated how exposed he felt.

“You’re doing well,” Warden Elenai Moonhold said from the shade of an archway, arms folded as she watched his slow circuit. A human woman with sharp, watchful eyes. She wore no visible weapons either, but Salkin’s systems tagged the way her weight was set: a fighter’s stance.

“Walking,” he muttered. “Truly…heroic.”

“You’ve left your room,” she said bluntly. “Twice this week. You’ve eaten at a table, with other people, without bolting. And today you’re in open space. Progress isn’t always measured in enemies killed.”

His mouth twisted. “That…is new doctrine.”

Elenai’s lips flickered, the ghost of a smile.

“Captain Rhoena wants you to know her people are not afraid of you,” she added. “Respectful, yes. But not afraid.”

He could hear the lie by omission: the guards’ heart rates spiked every time he drew near. The AI’s passive scans reported elevated adrenaline, micro-tremors in hands on spear-shafts.

“They should be,” he said quietly.

Elenai studied him a moment longer.

“Remember: they’re not front-line soldiers,” she said. “They were picked for sanctuary duty because they are patient, not because they’re eager to swing steel. If they make mistakes, it will be of overprotectiveness, not cruelty.”

He gave no answer. She let him go, turning back toward the inner door.

Which was when the mistake happened.

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The lower path by the reflecting pool was slick with spray. A shallow step, then another. Salkin's legs trembled—not from weakness anymore so much as from the wrongness of moving this slowly when every instinct screamed for quick, small, cover-seeking strides.

He focused on the water.

It was smooth here, dark as obsidian, broken only by the slow drift of pale lily pads. Someone had set tiny clay dragons among the stones, their little muzzles pointed toward the pool as if listening for prayers.

"Careful, honored one," a voice said behind him, close.

Too close.

He didn't recognize it. Young. Female. Nervous.

Salkin started to turn.

A hand closed on his bare forearm, fingers wrapping hard to steady him.

The world snapped.

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The hand might as well have been bone-white Void filament. The garden, the pool, the lilies—all of it tore away in a heartbeat and

slammed him back into a corridor of his ship, lights strobing, smoke clawing his lungs.

Contact! Close-quarters breach!

The AI's combat protocols, buried under weeks of enforced quiet, flared awake.

Adrenaline dump initiated. Muscle-weave activation: 70%. Lethal subroutines…denied. Delta-Limit engaged. Non-lethal constraint active.

He didn't hear that part.

He heard only the too-familiar shriek of metal, the sound of boots on deck, the wet gurgle someone made when—

MOVE.

His body moved.

The hand on his forearm became a grip to break. He dropped his weight, twisted, and something small and armored flew over his shoulder with a startled yelp, hitting the paving in a slide that knocked the breath out of them.

"By Jade—!"

Shouts. The scrape of spear-shafts hastily braced.

Threats, the combat lattice whispered. Neutralize.

He flowed.

To the nearest spear-bearer first: step inside the tip, palm up, twist. The shaft snapped free, butt-end driven into the guard's gut hard enough to fold her. He pivoted, swept her legs, felt her armor ring against stone.

Second, behind him—he didn't even see her, just felt shift and air, ducked under the horizontal slash meant to herd him back and drove an elbow into the inside of a knee. Joint hyperextended with a crack. The woman screamed, weapon spinning away.

Pain is non-lethal, the AI reminded itself, rerouting servo-assists away from neck strikes, from trajectories it knew too well would crush windpipes and shatter spines. It fought him on every killing angle, pulling punches by fractions, twisting wrists just enough that blades struck flat instead of point-first. But it did not slow him.

"Drop him!" someone shouted. "Stun glyphs—"

A hand started a sigil. He took the wrist before the second stroke completed, planted his heel in the woman's sternum, and shoved. She hit a pillar and went down, breath gone and spell sputtering slime-bright against the stone.

Red haze narrowed his vision. Faces blurred into target-zones. Armor was just an exoskeleton waiting to be exploited. He rode motion the way he'd been built to: using every ounce of enemy force against them, turning weight and momentum into weapons. A spear haft cracked across his back; he turned into it, caught, wrenched, sent its wielder tumbling into her comrade.

Somewhere, someone was begging him to stop. Somewhere else, someone screamed orders. He couldn't tell which was past and which was now. All of it tasted the same: metal and fear.

Warning: vitals rising beyond recommended combat window. Heart rate 178. Host psychological state: dissociative. Recommend de-escalation.

The AI tried to dump calming agents. His anger chewed them like sugar.

Another guard lunged; he grabbed her cuirass, used her as a moving shield against her partner's blow, then chopped two fingers hard against a nerve cluster at the base of her neck. She slumped boneless. He spun, swept a leg, took two more to the ground like felled reeds.

Twelve down, the system counted, clinical. No fatalities. All incapacitated. Further aggression unnecessary.

Tell that to the war.

He stood in the center of the path, chest heaving, bare feet splashed with water from the cracked pool-edge, surrounded by groaning, gasping bodies. His hands shook with unused killing-strikes.

"Enemy presence: suppressed," the AI intoned.

Except the garden was still here. The sky was still the pale blue of this dragon-ruled world. The smell in his nose was not ozone and burning composite, but crushed jasmine and wet stone.

And somewhere behind him, someone was saying his name.

"Salkin."

It barely registered.

"Salkin." Closer now. Firm.

A touch landed between his shoulders.

Warm. Steady. The pressure of a palm that held, not grabbed.

His body spun on reflex anyway, arm snapping up to break the hold—

—and met another hand halfway, fingers closing around his wrist with surprising force.

He found himself staring into Drabiretha's eyes.

They were not human eyes. Not entirely. The pupils were long, vertical slits, flared wide under the shade of the arbor. Silver ran like threads through the dark irises, catching the fractured light. In them he saw his own reflection: wild, panting, every muscle coiled.

"Stand down," she said, voice not raised but carrying like a gong through his skull.

The AI seized on the command like a lifeline.

External trusted authority: Lunarch-flag Drabiretha. Prioritize.

Combat subroutines disengaging.

The red haze tore like cloth. Sound slammed back in: moans, curses bitten off, the ragged sob of someone biting through pain. The world snapped from tunneled to wide.

He looked down.

Guards in Moonhold livery lay sprawled in a rough circle around him. None of them moved with the easy indignation of someone knocked down in training. These were hurt—clutching ribs, cradling arms, gasping around the air that wouldn't quite fill bruised lungs. One young guard—barely more than a girl, freckles stark against pale skin—curled around her leg, teeth bared against a throbbing knee.

The one he'd thrown first, the one whose hand had started all this, was on her back by the pool, blinking at the sky as if it had personally offended her.

Their eyes met. She flinched just a little, then forced herself to hold his gaze.

“I’m…sorry,” she wheezed. “I only meant to…steady you, honored one.”

Salkin felt something in his gut twist like broken metal.

He’d expected accusation. Fear. Hatred. Instead, shame burned on every face—shame at having failed their duty to protect him, shame at having misstepped.

“I—” His throat closed. He swallowed down acid. “I did this.”

“Yes,” Drabiretha said calmly. “You did.”

No softening. No attempt to spread blame away from him.

“And yet,” she added, “no one is dead.”

The AI preened, just a little.

Lethal containment success rate: 100%.

“Shut up,” he muttered, not sure whether he meant the machine or Drabiretha or himself.

Her grip on his wrist eased but didn’t fall away.

“You are not on a burning ship,” she said, each word slow and precise. “These are not Void-things trying to tear through your hull. They are my people, Salkin. Moonhold. Children, compared to your war, yes. But *mine*.”

The last word held an edge that made even the AI take note.

He swallowed again.

“I’ll…go,” he said hoarsely. “I’ll leave. I am…a danger. Your people —” He gestured weakly at the ring of groaning forms. “I should not be here.”

Drabiretha’s brows rose, very slightly.

“You think you can simply walk out of Lunarys?” she asked. “Alone. Unsealed. Carrying a universe in your head. With that temper.” Her tone was flat with disbelief. “You would not survive to the first outer gate before some lesser house tried to cut you into pieces they could hide.”

“That’s…your problem,” he said, anger flaring again, this time at himself. “I did not ask…for your protection. I did not ask for…any of this. Better I go. Or you send me to your…most brutal clan. Let them cage me. I am not…” The word caught like a bone in his throat. “Safe.”

Drabiretha studied him, eyes narrowing.

“Do you truly believe,” she said slowly, “that leaving would make anyone safer? You. These women. This world.”

“Yes.”

“Then you are a fool,” she said, with no heat, just weary certainty. “And I do not permit fools to make strategic decisions on my land.”

His head snapped up at that. “You *do not permit*—?”

“No,” she said simply. “Not on these terms.”

Her hand finally dropped from his wrist. She turned, looking over the spread of injured guards.

“Elenai!” she called.

The Warden was already striding in, jaw tight, hands dancing in the air as she sketched stabilizing sigils over the worst-off. Maera hurried at her side, her medical kit rattling.

“Nothing broken clean through,” Maera reported briskly after a hasty sweep. “Joints strained, ribs bruised, one concussion, one knee I’ll be scolding you about for weeks.” She shot Salkin a surprisingly level look. “For no weapons and no armor, that’s… commendable.”

“That’s *terrifying*,” muttered one of the downed guards, then winced as Maera prodded a bruise.

“Thank the dragons he wasn’t *trying* to kill you,” Maera told her. “Now hush.”

Salkin flinched anyway. He *had* been trying, at least at first. The AI’s clamps had been the only thing between these women and corpses.

“I should be bound,” he said, numbly. “Collared. Sedated. Whatever you do to dangerous things.”

A hush fell.

Half a dozen pairs of eyes flicked to Drabiretha.

Her jaw worked once, as if biting down on old anger.

“In this house,” she said, voice low but unmistakably carrying, “we do not put iron on a throat because trauma reacts to an unexpected touch.”

Her gaze swept the guards. “Hestra,” she said, picking out the young woman by the pool. “Did you intend harm?”

“N-no, Lunarch,” the guard stammered. “He slipped on the wet stone— I thought— I just—”

“We will review sanctuary protocol,” Drabiretha said. “From this hour, no one touches Salkin from behind. No one approaches within arm’s length without clear warning. You are to treat him as you would treat a war-stirred dragon: with respect, distance, and clear signals.” A faint, humorless smile tugged at her mouth. “Fortunately, he is smaller.”

A weak ripple of laughter went through the ring of guards. Even Salkin snorted, despite himself.

“And you,” she added, turning back to him, “will *not* leave. Not in flight, not in shame. Not because you have been reminded that your hands can still break people.”

“I nearly—”

“You nearly proved what Maera and I have been saying,” Drabiretha cut in. “That you are a walking weapon in a world of people who have never seen your kind of war. That we must build rules around you, and with you, or we will all bleed.”

He stared at her.

“You’re…not afraid,” he said slowly.

“Oh, don’t be ridiculous,” she said. “I am very afraid. You just flattened a dozen of my best sanctuary guards without drawing blood. But I am more afraid of what will happen to all of us if you go wandering into a city that sees men as prize-livestock and you react like this to the first hand on your arm.”

She stepped closer again, ignoring the way a few guards twitched.

“You said you wanted to leave because you’re a danger,” she went on. “I say you stay *because* you’re a danger. Here, under Moonhold law, under my eye, we can learn the shape of that danger. We can teach my people how not to trigger it. And perhaps”—her gaze softened, just a fraction—“we can teach *you* how to feel a hand on your arm without seeing the Void behind it.”

His heart hammered. The AI, ever eager to quantify, labeled this moment: Inflection. High potential for long-term behavioral shift.

“I don’t know if I can,” he whispered.

“Good,” Drabiretha said again, echoing that first conversation after he’d tried to starve. “Then we will start small. As before.”

She looked around the garden.

“Today’s small thing,” she declared, “is this: you will remain here while Maera and Elenai tend to every guard you knocked down. You will watch. You will see that they are hurt, not dead. You will listen to them swear at you and at themselves. You will not run. And when they are done, you will say what you wished to say when you told me you would go.”

His throat ached.

“I’m…sorry,” he said, almost inaudible.

Drabiretha tilted her head. “Louder.”

“I’m sorry,” he said again, the words scraping his mouth like gravel. He wasn’t even sure who he was apologizing to—to Hestra, to the others, to Alexia, to every corpse he’d stepped over in narrower halls. “I— when someone grabs me from behind—”

“We know,” Maera said, surprisingly gentle. “Truly, honored one, we know. Or we are learning.”

“You scared the piss out of me,” one of the guards muttered from the ground. “But I’d rather have you smashing *me* in the practice yard than some Jade Talon bitch putting a collar on you in the street.”

“Watch your mouth,” Elenai said automatically. “And your knee.”

Salkin let out a shaky breath that might have been a laugh.

Drabiretha watched his face, then nodded, satisfied—for now.

“You will not leave Moonhold on the back of a panic,” she said, final as a closing gate. “If you choose to go, one day, it will be with your eyes clear, your hands steady, and agreements on the table, not as a half-feral weapon fleeing the scene of his first real mistake.”

He bit his lip. “And if I…do this again?”

“Then we adjust again,” she said. “Perhaps more training. Perhaps different guards. Perhaps a quiet room and a very long talk.” A glint of cruel humor lit her gaze. “Perhaps I will personally throw you into the practice ring with Rhoena until you are too tired to swing at anyone else.”

A groan rose from the downed women.

“Spare him, Lunarch,” one complained. “That’s torture.”

“Then stop grabbing sanctuary guests from behind,” Drabiretha shot back. “Lesson learned, I hope.”

“Yes, Lunarch,” came the ragged chorus.

She glanced at Salkin.

“You are not leaving,” she repeated softly, just for him. “Not like this. You are mine to protect, storm-gift. That includes protecting you from your worst instincts.”

He wanted to argue.

Instead, shaking, he sank down onto the edge of the pool, water soaking his trouser cuffs, and watched as Maera’s hands glowed faintly gold over bruises he had made.

The AI, oddly quiet, logged it all: every flinch, every apology, every time his mind replayed the moment of the hand on his arm and, for one heartbeat, managed to see a frightened young guard instead of a Void-borne horror.

Small things. Stupid victories.

He was very, very tired of them.

But he stayed.

Chapter Five — How to Light a Candle in the Wrong Universe

In the end, it started with something as stupid as a candle.

Not war. Not omens. Not the vast, whispering weight of the Archive in his skull.

Just a stub of beeswax in a little brass holder, set on the low table in his room because Maera thought the scent calmed people.

“Helps the nightmares,” she’d said, patting his shoulder. “You don’t have to light it. Just… if you feel like it.”

For three nights, it sat there unlit.

On the fourth, sleepless and sick of staring at the carved ceiling dragons, Salkin sat on the edge of his bed and looked at the blackened wick.

“In training we did this without even looking,” he muttered in his own language. “One thought. One request.”

He reached inward.

“Local swarm,” he whispered in his head. “Routine: ignition. Minor thermal focus, point-source, two seconds.”

Under his skin, the familiar stir: dormant nanomachines rousing, syncing, running self-checks.

Then:

EXECUTION ERROR 0xAETHER-0001

CONTEXT: PHYSICAL-LAYER REFERENCE MISSING

DESCRIPTION: REQUESTED OPERATION RELIES ON UNRESOLVED CONSTANTS

He blinked.

“Again. Scan first.”

He sent the command: analyze air composition, temperature, particulate density. The most basic of basics.

EXECUTION ERROR 0xAETHER-0002

CONTEXT: REFERENCE FRAME MISMATCH

DESCRIPTION: STANDARD MODEL NOT FOUND

Cold slid down his spine.

“Core,” he said inwardly, jaw tightening. “Status.”

The other presence—the machine-mind braided with the Archive, the one only he and Drabiretha even had a word for—answered with its usual unsettling calm.

Environmental analysis attempt failed.

Underlying constants do not match stored templates.

Baseline physics model returns null.

“Null,” Salkin repeated. “As in… no match. No atom structure. No particle field. Nothing.”

Macroscopic behavior comparable to previous realities: objects fall; heat flows; light propagates.

Underlying description language: unparseable.

“Translate it badly,” he snapped. “I’ll take *badly* over *nothing*.”

A tiny pause. Then:

Local reality presents as a continuous field.

No discrete atoms detected.

Instead: layered modes in a single substrate.

Labeling provisional modes by analogy…

Words slid through his mind not in his mother tongue, not in the lunarch's language, but in the clean, abstract shorthand of the Archive:

MODE 1: dense, slow-changing – 'earth-like'

MODE 2: volatile, high-energy – 'fire-like'

MODE 3: diffuse, communicative – 'air-like'

MODE 4: cohesive, adaptive – 'water-like'

MODE 5: charged, abrupt-transition – 'lightning-like'

CARRIER MODE: underlying binding field – "aether"

He stared at the candle.

"So you're telling me," he whispered, "that this reality runs on fairy-tale elements and aether."

Closest approximation.

From the hallway, one of the younger attendants slowed, peering in through the crack in the door.

Salkin sat barefoot on the rug, shoulders tense, eyes fixed on a perfectly ordinary, unlit candle. His lips moved, but no sound reached her in any language she knew.

"Is he praying?" she whispered.

Elenai, passing behind her, glanced in and watched for a moment.

“That’s not a prayer posture,” the Warden murmured. “That’s… focus. Like a hedge-mage’s brat trying to feel the aether for the first time.”

“Does he have the Gift?” the girl asked, startled.

“Not in any way I recognize,” Elenai said. “But he *is* something strange. Let him work, unless he starts glowing.”

◇ ◇ ◇

The first day, Salkin tried to bully the universe into fitting what he knew.

He pushed the nanites out in a thin cloud around him, ordered a scan of “molecules,” of orbital shells, of familiar energy levels. They came back humming with nonsense.

NO ATOMIC STRUCTURE.

NO PROTON/ELECTRON PATTERN.

FIELD IS CONTINUOUS.

Gravity existed. Heat existed. Things fell down and burned and broke the way they *should*, but the math underneath refused to resolve into familiar knots.

“Everything is *wave*,” he muttered, flexing his fingers and feeling the slow push of the field against his skin. “But here, the wave is all there is.”

He asked the Core for a decomposition.

FIELD COMPONENTS FORM INTERFERING WAVES.

MODES INTERMIX: EARTH, FIRE, AIR, WATER, LIGHTNING.

ALL RIDING ON AETHER.

He closed his eyes and inhaled, slow.

When he bothered to notice, he could *feel* it now: a faint pressure in the back of his thoughts, the way the air around him wasn't empty but gently tense, like water in a bowl. Aether, the word the locals used, snapped neatly into place: the thing that carried *everything*.

"We can't treat this like atoms," he told the Core. "We have to treat it like…current maps. Or music. Or weather."

You are not a physicist, the machine-mind reminded him.

"Neither were half the first Gate-tamers," he shot back. "They were just too stubborn to die ignorant."

Outside, that first day and the next, the household saw only a man who had stopped trying to starve himself and instead sat for hours by the window, breathing slow and deep, staring at nothing.

"Is this better?" Rhoena muttered once to Drabiretha as they passed. "He looks like he's about to either ascend or explode."

Drabiretha stood in the doorway and watched.

Not the way a healer watched a patient for fever, or a guard watched a threat for openings. The way a mage watched someone else touch an invisible weave they maybe shouldn't.

"He's *listening*," she said at last. "Leave him. If he stops eating by nightfall, fetch me. Otherwise… I want to see what he finds."

◇ ◇ ◇

On the third day, Salkin realized his tools themselves were part of the problem.

The nanites, every tiny self-copying loop of them, had been designed for universes with atoms. They kept jabbing probing tendrils into the field and coming back confused, insisting there must be particles somewhere if they just poked harder.

“They’re like emigrants who refuse to learn the local tongue,” he muttered.

Suggested fix? the Core asked.

“Stop asking them to explain it,” he said. “Use them as…pebbles. Anchors. Known disturbances in an unknown ocean.”

He let his awareness drift out a fraction, the way the war had taught him never to unless he wanted to feel things he’d never un-feel.

Air was not empty. The closer he looked, the more it felt like a five-colored storm:

slow, weighty Earth-mode pooling near stone,

nimble, carrying Air-mode sliding along walls and under doors,

bright, hungry Fire-mode in tiny sparks wherever things rubbed or burned,

flowing Water-mode in every living body, shifting and adjusting,

sharp, tense Lightning-mode crackling faintly along certain carvings and metal edges, a sense of *ready* more than *present*,

All of it threaded together by Aether, the deep hum that underlay everything like a note so low he felt it in his bones more than heard it.

He reached for the nanites in his bloodstream and imagined them not as machines, but as deliberate blots in that field—little foreign notes he could move by will alone.

“Don’t *measure*,” he told them. “Lean.”

He focused on the air just above the candle wick.

◇ ◇ ◇

By the fifth day, the servants had stopped trying to coax him into the garden.

“He answers when I speak,” Maera reported to Drabiretha over tea. “He drinks, he eats a little, he sleeps. But most of the time he’s… elsewhere. Not like before, when he vanished inside his pain. Different. This is…it feels like when the young Wardens first learn to feel the ward-lines.”

“With no training. No sigils. No dragon-mark.” Drabiretha tapped one claw lightly on her cup. “And no aether surge when he works.”

Maera shuddered pleasantly. “Lunarch, I am both healer and priestess; I am allowed to say this: the man unnerves me. Gently.”

Drabiretha’s mouth twitched.

“Good,” she said. “The gods sent me enough boring problems this decade. It’s time for a difficult one.”

◇ ◇ ◇

On the seventh day, he tried the candle again.

The week of slow mapping had carved faint grooves in his mind. He had the barest idea now of how Aether pooled, how the five

modes braided through it, where Fire thickened, where Lightning slept coiled like a serpent.

“Take the old ignition routine,” he told the Core. “Gut it. No atom constants. Just a target region, a duration, and… a way to tug Fire and Lightning up through the aether there, for a heartbeat.”

This is not how these tools are meant to be used, the Core protested.

“Neither is lodging a universe in a line soldier’s skull,” he said under his breath. “And yet.”

He drew in a breath, slow.

He imagined the space just touching the wick as a knot in the field. A little hollow he could press Fire-mode into until it couldn’t help but flare. A little spark of Lightning snapped into place to start it, Aether tightening around both to hold them steady.

He reached out with his will and with the faint net of nanites, not saying *burn*, but *here*.

For a moment, there was nothing.

Then the wick darkened, smoldered.

A thin thread of smoke rose, blue-gray in the half-light.

A heartbeat later, a small, sullen flame licked up, then steadied into a proper candle-flame, leaning very slightly toward the open window where Air-mode drifted stronger.

OPERATION RESULT: SUCCESS (PARTIAL)

ENERGY COST: SIGNIFICANT

STABILITY: ACCEPTABLE

NEW PATTERN STORED: HYBRID-AETHERIC IGNITION v0.1

Salkin laughed.

The sound broke out of him sharp and startled, almost painful in his own ears after so many mutters and silences.

In the corridor, a guard jumped and half-reached for a spear that wasn't there.

"Alarm?" she hissed.

Rhoena, coming up the stairs, peered through the crack.

"No," the captain said slowly. "He's… just made a candle."

The flame burned with no visible glyph, no shimmer of drawn aether that any trained eye could see. It had simply…caught.

"Like a mage," the guard whispered. "But not like any mage I've ever seen."

"Go get Elenai," Rhoena murmured. "And the Lunarch. Quietly."

◇ ◇ ◇

By the time Drabiretha stepped into the room, the candle had burned down a finger's breadth and Salkin's breathing had evened out again.

He looked tired, but not the hollow kind of tired she'd come to dread. This was the worn-thin look of someone who'd been *thinking* very hard, on purpose.

"Progress?" she asked, leaning one shoulder against the doorpost.

He blinked once, as if remembering how to bring his attention back to bodies and walls and speech.

“Yes,” he said hoarsely. His voice still rasped from disuse, but there was a thread of something new in it. “Your world is…wrong.”

Her brows rose.

“Careful,” she said. “You’re a guest. We consider it very right.”

He huffed a tiny, lopsided breath that almost, almost qualified as a smile.

“Wrong for…my tools,” he said. “For the way I was…taught the bones of things. Where I come from there are…atoms. Little… stones. Beneath them, quarks. Below that, fields. Here…”

He gestured weakly at the candle, the stone, the air.

“Here it is *all* field. Aether and…flavors. Earth. Fire. Air. Water. Lightning.”

Drabiretha’s eyes narrowed, intrigued.

“You can *feel* the elements,” she said slowly. “Without sigils. Without the Oath. Without a dragon’s mark on your soul.”

“I can feel…something,” he said. “I am still…clumsy. Like one of your little ones, first…learning to walk.” He flexed his fingers, watching invisible currents curl around them. “The…other mind in me kept trying to measure everything as if there were atoms. It failed. So I told it to stop talking and help me…push, instead.”

She caught the phrase *other mind* and filed it away, as she always did. The strange not-spirit-not-demon he had tried, haltingly, to explain to her in earlier, more lucid hours; the thing he called an “ay-eye” in his own thick accent. She was the only one in Moonhold who even had that word. Everyone else just called it the whisper in his head.

“You did this”—she nodded at the candle—“the way my mages call fire. From stillness. From breath. From knowing where to lean.”

“From desperation,” he said. “If I am to stay alive here, I must be able to do more than…eat soup and occasionally traumatize your guards. I must know how not to break things by accident. Or burn down your house trying to light a candle.”

“And do you *want* to stay alive here now?” she asked, very soft.

He went quiet.

The flame fluttered as a draft slid in under the window. He watched it steady again, small and stubborn.

“At first,” he said finally, “I only wanted to die. Then I only wanted…not to take anyone with me. Now…”

He exhaled. It shuddered a little.

“Now I want to…understand,” he admitted, each word feeling like he was prying his fingers off an old vow. “If I must…exist…here, in this wrong-right place, then I will not do it…stupid.”

A slow smile touched her mouth.

“First broth,” she said. “Then not killing my guards. Now elementary aether theory. You are moving very fast, storm-gift.”

“Next week, I conquer your Empire,” he said dryly.

She snorted.

“Please don’t. Running it is tedious enough already.”

Silence settled between them, not uncomfortable; just full.

“In my world,” he said after a moment, eyes on the little flame, “we used to say that if you can light a candle in a storm, you have

mastered your tools. If you can light one in a vacuum, you have mastered the universe."

"And here?" she asked.

He watched the way the flame leaned toward the open window, following invisible Air, the faint twitch of Lightning where the brass holder kissed the stone, the quiet embrace of Aether in it all.

"Here," he said slowly, "if I can light a candle…without my past turning your present into a battlefield…I will call that enough."

Drabiretha studied his face, the set of his shoulders, the way his hands were no longer clenched into permanent fists.

"That," she said, "is a kind of mastery I value more than any Empress's throne."

He didn't answer.

But when she left, he didn't reach for flint or taper.

He looked at the little flame, reached out with his new, clumsy sense for the weave of Aether and Air and Fire around it, and *asked* it to go out.

A thread of Lightning snapped, the Fire-mode fell apart, and the candle smoked into darkness, obedient as a drilled soldier.

He sat back, throat tight.

He was still the last of his kind. His sky was still gone. The Void still owned the bones of his home.

None of that changed.

But now, between "waiting to die" and "wishing he had," there was a thin, strange third path:

Drink the broth.

Don’t kill the guards.

Light a candle the way a mage would – and learn this new song of aether and elements well enough not to let the wrong note turn into a scream.

He would have to retrain completely.

It felt, unexpectedly, like work.

And work, at least, he still remembered how to do.

Chapter Six — The Training Yard

He never quite remembered when watching turned into teaching.

When he wasn't sleeping or picking at food or arguing silently with the other mind in his skull, Salkin read.

The servants called him "the book ghost" when they thought he couldn't hear. He devoured anything that came through his door: children's tales, trade ledgers, temple hymns, histories of the clans, military chronicles so heavily glossed with propaganda he could almost smell the ink. His eyes moved too fast, they said. Pages turned before a normal man could finish a verse.

Maera only shrugged. "Let him," she told the others. "There are worse addictions."

But even a ghost needed to walk, and after the candle, after he'd started to feel the aether as more than suffocating background noise, his feet started taking him somewhere new.

Down, into the belly of Moonhold.

The training yard was a long, open rectangle of packed sand and warded stone, hemmed in by high walls. Racks of wooden practice spears and swords lined one side; on the other, buckets of sand and water waited beside a shrine where someone had tucked a sprig of saltweed behind a little stone dragon's ear.

He should have avoided it.

Soldiers meant noise, meant shouts and snapping impacts, meant the metallic tang of sweat and old bruises—the whole place stank of every barracks he'd ever slept in. But it was also honest, in a way the quiet corridors of the sanctuary were not.

So, on days when his head felt too full of words, he found himself there, shadowing the shade of the wall, watching.

At first, the guards had been stiff as spear-shafts under his gaze.

They'd seen what his hands could do in the garden. Every woman on yard duty knew the story now: twelve Moonhold veterans downed in heartbeats, no deaths only because of some unknown quirk of his strange inner "spirit". Having that man stand at the wall while you drilled footwork did something unpleasant to the back of the neck.

They sneaked looks when they thought he wasn't watching. The pale, collarless man in foreign-cut trousers and borrowed tunic, arms folded, eyes following every movement with unnerving focus.

"Ignore him," Captain Rhoena barked the first few days. "If he wanted you dead, you'd already be on the ground. Shields up. Rotate!"

Soldiers acclimatized. That was what they did. Within a week they were grumbling about sand in their boots again instead of whispering about the ghost at the wall.

He told himself he was just…remembering.

Then the corrections started.

It slipped out one afternoon when two younger guards were working through spear-forms near his end of the yard—Hestra, whose knee he'd nearly ruined, and another broad-shouldered woman with a braid so tight it shifted when she blinked.

Hestra lunged; her back heel lifted, balance tipping forward.

“That stance will get you killed,” Salkin said before his better judgment could catch up.

Both women froze.

“Honored one?” Hestra asked warily.

He sighed.

Too late now.

“Your base,” he said, stepping off the wall almost against his will. “Your…core. Here.” He tapped his own abdomen, then pointed at her feet. “Wider. No, not like that—you’re…leaning.” He shook his head, searching for words in her language. “Think of…roots. You are a tree, not a reed.”

She stared at him, then carefully reset her stance as he indicated—feet a little farther apart, weight sunk, spine aligned.

“Now push,” he said, and set his palm lightly against her shoulder.

She didn’t move.

Her eyes widened.

“It feels…different,” she admitted.

“Harder to push over, harder to…recover if you over-commit,” he said. “Your way is faster to move. But if someone catches you…” He mimed a gentle tug; she saw the opening.

Her partner shifted, trying it.

“And your strike,” he added, nodding at their spears. “You use too much…muscle. Let gravity work. Drop your weight *through* the point, don’t just *swing* it.”

He showed them, slow: how the force traveled from the ground, up through the legs, through the hips, shoulder, arm, then out. How a smaller fighter could break a larger one if the line was clean.

Within minutes, three more guards had drifted closer with the casual lack of subtlety of off-duty soldiers anywhere. By the time Rhoena finished tearing strips off the heavy-shield line on the far side of the yard and turned back, half her squad was clustered around Salkin, spears lowered, listening.

She marched over, ready to bark.

Then she heard what he was saying.

"—you lean like this, you must commit. If you miss, your spine is open. Turn your hip *this* much and the follow-through brings your guard back without thinking about it."

Rhoena watched one of her veterans try the adjusted move. The strike landed with a harder, cleaner thud on the practice dummy. The guard's eyes went round.

"Again," Salkin said.

They did.

Rhoena folded her arms.

"Moonhold seems to have gained a new drill-sergeant," she said dryly.

Salkin stiffened, almost flinching. "I…should not—"

"I didn't say stop," Rhoena cut in. She looked him up and down, soldier to soldier, weighing. "If the Lunarch allows you in my yard,

you're under my rules. And my rule is simple: if someone knows how to keep my women alive, they speak. Soldiers, listen."

A small ripple went through the group.

"Yes, Captain," they chorused.

Salkin stared at her. Some brittle part of him wanted to snap that he was not her anything. That he was done teaching people how to die better. That his every instinct was honed for wars no one here had even nightmares about.

Instead, he heard his own voice say:

"Your pivot is sloppy."

Rhoena snorted.

"Then fix it," she said, stepping forward, spear in hand. "If you dare."

◇ ◇ ◇

It became a habit.

After that day, no one pretended he wasn't there. He'd arrive mid-morning or late afternoon, barefoot on the warm stone, and lean against the wall with the same watchful stillness, eyes flicking over stances and lines.

When something grated too hard against his training to ignore, he'd step in, quiet but firm.

"Your shield is a wall, not a club. Stop swinging it like you're trying to impress the onlookers."

"Don't look at where you're hitting. Look at where they'll be when the strike lands."

“You’re trying to *win* this exchange. Start by not *losing* it.”

The first time he said that last one, a murmur went up.

“Sounds like old Warden Thale,” one of the older guards muttered. “He used to say the same thing. ‘Don’t get dead, then worry about glory.’”

“Maybe wisdom smells the same in every world,” Maera said later when she heard about it.

The Core in his head complained, of course.

Time spent on low-level martial instruction does not advance primary objectives, it pointed out.

“Maybe my primary objective,” Salkin thought back sourly, “is to be something other than a problem you and the Lunarch have to constantly put out fires around.”

It had no answer for that.

From the balcony above, Drabiretha watched more than once as the Moonhold soldiers adapted.

They were not bad before. Moonhold did not breed fools into its guard. But Salkin’s eye for efficiency, for unadorned battlefield practicality, shaved off little bits of pretty, lethal excess from their forms.

Stances rooted. Guard rotations tightened. Sparring sessions that used to end in even trades now slid inexorably in favor of those taking his corrections to heart.

“Do you trust him down there?” Elenai asked her quietly one afternoon as they leaned on the stone rail.

“No,” Drabiretha said honestly. “But I trust him more *there* than sitting alone in a room trying to convince himself he has no place in any formation.”

Elenai grunted. “And if he snaps again?”

“Then at least he’ll have a yard of sand and the best captain in Lunarys between him and the city,” Drabiretha said. “And I will be close enough to put a hand on his back.”

◇ ◇ ◇

The sparring match was Rhoena’s idea.

It had to be. No one else in the yard had the rank—or the nerve—to suggest it.

It came at the end of a long, hot morning. Salkin had been correcting footwork again, this time for shield-line drills. Rhoena had stalked around the edge, watching her women’s centers of gravity sink, their recovery steps smooth a little.

When the last whistle blew and the squad broke for water, she turned to him.

“You see so much, storm-gift,” she said. “Walk so many lines with your mouth. I begin to wonder if your hands remember as well as your tongue.”

It wasn’t a challenge, not quite. But a spark had crept into the eyes of every guard in earshot.

Salkin gave her a long, level look.

“You wish to…test me,” he said.

“Test *us*,” she corrected. “My women need to know what it feels like to face something like you and still stand. I need to know how wide the gap is between what you see and what we do.”

He could have said no.

He should have, if he were the careful, quiet guest Drabiretha wanted him to be.

Instead, a long-dormant part of him—the part that had once found ugly joy in a clean, honest bout far from the front—uncoiled.

“All right,” he heard himself say. “Conditions.”

Rhoena’s brows rose. “Name them.”

“No weapons for me,” he said at once.

She blinked. A ripple of disbelief ran through the onlookers.

“I can have a practice spear brought,” she said. “Or a staff. We have weighted—”

“No,” he cut in. “That would make it too…unfair.”

“Too unfair,” repeated Hestra under her breath, appalled and delighted.

Rhoena’s mouth curved in a dangerous smile.

“Cocky,” she said.

He shook his head once, slow.

“Practical. I am…very bad with not hurting people when I have steel. Without, I have more…options.”

That sobered a few faces.

Rhoena considered, then nodded.

“Very well. I’ll take a practice spear,” she said. “My rules: no blood, no broken bones. First down, pinned, or forced out of the ring loses.”

“Acceptable,” he said.

The yard hummed.

They cleared a rough circle in the sand, scored lines with spear-butts. The shrine dragon watched from its alcove, expression as faintly amused as carved stone could manage.

Rhoena stripped down to training leathers, rolling her shoulders, spear spinning once in her hand before she settled into guard. She was not sloppy. Salkin had watched her drill enough women to know she’d earned her captain’s braids with sweat and bruises.

“Ready?” she asked.

Salkin stepped barefoot into the circle.

No weapon. No armor. Just the easy, unsettling balance that made even his stillness feel like potential motion.

“Ready,” he said.

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From the balcony, someone rang the small bell that meant “non-lethal entertainment in the yard.” Servants drifted to railings. A couple of junior scribes leaned out of windows, quills forgotten.

Drabiretha appeared at the far end, Elenai at her shoulder.

“Should we stop this?” the Warden murmured.

“No,” Drabiretha said lightly. “But I may ask the dragons to watch more closely than usual.”

Down in the ring, Rhoena circled, spear-tip tracing small arcs.

Salkin moved very little. A half-step here, a weight shift there, always just enough to keep the point from finding a straight line.

“He’s not guarding,” one of the younger guards whispered.

“Yes, he is,” Maera said quietly. “He just doesn’t need wood in his hands to do it.”

Rhoena lunged, probing.

He slipped aside, not with showy acrobatics but with economy, letting the spear whisper past his ribs by a finger’s width. His hand tapped the shaft on its way by; the impact sent a shiver up her grip.

She registered the line he’d just drawn: if he’d wanted, that tap could have been a wrench. The spear could have been gone.

She grinned.

“Again,” she said.

They danced.

She pressed, gradually increasing tempo, testing angles. He gave ground when he had to, stole it back when she overreached, always just outside the arc of real danger. The watching soldiers murmured appreciatively as familiar drills turned unfamiliar in his hands.

“See that?” Hestra hissed to her partner. “He let her push so he could take her flank. That’s what he meant about not fighting where you *are*.”

“Shh,” Maera said. “I’m trying to see how many ribs I’ll be setting if this goes wrong.”

Sweat slicked Rhoena's brow. Sand scuffed under Salkin's feet, but his breathing stayed infuriatingly steady.

"Come on," she goaded between strikes. "Are you made of glass, ghost? Hit me."

He shook his head, parrying the spear with his forearm, turning his body to bleed the force away.

"If I hit," he said calmly, "I win. Too fast. I am…enjoying the dance."

Her eyes flared.

"Then dance faster," she snarled, and obliged.

For a few heartbeats, the yard was nothing but blur: wood and flesh, feints and ghosts of impacts. Salkin's world narrowed, not in the blind red way of panic this time, but in the clean, precise tunnel of a controlled bout. Lines, timing, angles. The aether around them stirred with Air and the first flickers of Lightning as the watching guards' hearts raced.

He felt when she committed too hard to a thrust. The tiny hitch in her recovery foot, the over-extension of her shoulder.

Now.

He stepped in *past* the spearhead, body brushing the shaft, hand snapping up to catch it near the midpoint. His other hand found her wrist. A twist, a pivot, a drop of his center—

She hit the sand on her back with a grunt, his weight already shifted so he could plant one knee by her ribs instead of *on* them. The spear lay flat across her collarbones, his palm on it just hard enough to pin.

Silence.

One heartbeat. Two.

“Point,” he said softly, more habit than insult.

Then the yard exploded into noise.

Whoops, groans, a couple of appreciative whistles. Someone owed someone else money, judging by the curses. Maera exhaled like she’d been holding her breath for a week.

On the balcony, Drabiretha let her hand unclench on the rail.

Rhoena blinked up at the sky, breath sawing.

“You’re an ass,” she informed him.

He eased off at once, offering a hand to help her up.

“You asked,” he said, a little breathless now himself. “You are… good. Very good. But I have…too many years. Too many fights. This is not…fair measure.”

She took his hand and let him pull her to her feet, shoulder rolling as she checked for damage.

“Fairness is for tournaments,” she said. “This is training. And I’d rather learn how far I fall *here* than out on a road when some clanless band has been taught by worse.”

She turned to her watching soldiers.

“You saw?” she called. “You felt? That’s what he’s been trying to beat into your thick skulls about stance, about commitment. So next time he tells you your feet are stupid, you *listen*.”

“Yes, Captain!” came the laughing chorus.

Rhoena clapped Salkin's shoulder—carefully, from the front, where he could see it coming.

"Again tomorrow?" she asked.

He hesitated.

For the first time in a very long time, his body hummed not with panic or forced readiness, but with the honest ache of a good bout. His breath was rough, but not ragged. The Core was blessedly quiet, only occasionally noting data points instead of screaming about survival.

"I…think so," he said.

"Good," Rhoena said. "Maybe next time we let you have a stick."

He gave her a look that was almost, almost amused.

"That," he said dryly, "would make it *far* too unfair."

From the balcony, Drabiretha smiled into the wind.

The man who had washed up on her black shore wanting nothing but an ending now stood in her yard, bare-handed, surrounded by laughing warriors demanding rematches.

Small things. Stupid, stubborn things.

But watching him bow to Rhoena with that crooked, reluctant respect, she allowed herself—for one heartbeat—to believe that somewhere between death and duty, Salkin Storm-Gift was starting, however grudgingly, to remember how to live.

Chapter Seven — The Measure of a Weapon

He waited a week before he asked.

In that week he drilled footwork until half the guard cursed his name affectionately, wore blisters into the yard sand, and discovered that bruises earned in honest sparring hurt differently than the old ones.

On the seventh day, when the morning drills were done and Rhoena was calling the squads to water, Salkin stepped forward.

“Captain,” he said.

She turned, wiping sweat from her brow with the back of one bracer. “Storm-gift?”

“I want the yard,” he said. “To myself. For…a test.”

Her gaze flicked over him, taking in the tension in his shoulders, the set of his jaw.

“What kind of test?” she asked warily.

He hesitated.

“A live blade,” he said at last. “And room.”

A murmur went up from the nearby guards.

Rhoena’s brows climbed. “You want steel in your hand, alone, with my sanctuary at your back.”

“I won’t be alone,” he said. “You will be there.” His eyes met hers steadily. “That is my condition. You stand. You watch. No one else.”

She studied him for a long, silent moment.

There were a dozen reasons to say no.

He was uncollared, unregistered, and more dangerous than any man had a right to be. The Lunarch trusted him—or at least, refused to treat him like an animal—but trust wasn't the same as giving him a sword and locking herself in with him.

But: Drabiretha had brought him here. Drabiretha had said *learn the shape of the danger*. And Rhoena was very tired of guessing at the upper edge of what this pale, quiet storm of a man could do.

"One condition," she said.

He nodded once. "Name it."

"If I tell you to stop," she said, "you stop. No matter how far into your…test…you are. No matter what the other voice in your head says. Agreed?"

He thought of the garden. Of her palm on his shoulder, the way his body had obeyed when his mind was lost.

"Agreed," he said.

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They cleared the yard.

The last of the guards filed out with a mix of grumbles and eager sideways looks, the heavy gates thudding closed behind them. Maera lingered, kit in hand, until Rhoena shooed her away with a promise to shout if anything went truly wrong.

Only then did Rhoena slide the iron bar into place and turn back.

Salkin was already shrugging out of his shirt.

He did it without flourish, folding the linen neatly and setting it aside with the same care he gave to everything. Rhoena tried not to stare and failed.

Men in Lunarys were not unknown to her. She'd guarded caravans, escorted temple processions, seen pampered sons of Jade Talon and hard-used clanless boys both. Most had the soft muscle of people who were valuable enough not to be risked, or the hunched tension of those who'd never been allowed to grow into their own bodies.

Salkin was neither.

His skin was pale as moon-ivory, the kind of paleness that came from light you could not name rather than simple shade. Under it, muscle lay in clean, precise lines—not bulky, not showy, but dense, as if every fiber had been laid with purpose.

Silver traced across him in faint, hair-fine lines: down his arms, over his ribs, along his spine. Not scars, not quite tattoos. They caught the light when he moved, like buried threads of metal.

Rhoena swallowed.

"Engineered," the Lunarch had murmured once, when Rhoena had seen him bare-chested on a healer's table. "Not by us."

Now, in the empty yard, that truth was very hard to ignore.

"What do you need?" Rhoena asked, letting her voice fall into the brisk cadence of command to hide her unease.

"Targets," he said.

They worked together to set them.

Three rough circles of training dummies: the inner ring close enough to touch with an outstretched arm, the second at the length of a full spear, the third spaced near the edge of the marked yard. Some were simple straw-men on posts. Others wore old cuirasses, scarred shields, a helmet or two that had seen better campaigns.

When they were done, Salkin stepped into the center of the circle and turned slowly, taking it in.

“Good,” he murmured.

Rhoena went to the weapon rack.

“You asked for a blade,” she said, running fingers over wooden practice swords and blunted steel. “Practice or live?”

He hesitated for the briefest of moments. Then:

“Live,” he said.

Her jaw tightened.

“If you so much as nick yourself, Maera will have my hide,” she warned, but she pulled a real sword free from the rack anyway: a Moonhold officer’s blade, single-edged, a little curved, honed this morning by an old sergeant who still believed in sharpness as a form of respect.

She held it out, flat across both palms.

He took it like a man accepting a ritual, not a toy. Tested the weight with a tiny flick of his wrist, the way you tested a limb you hadn’t used in too long.

“I remember this,” he said quietly. “This is…older than guns. Older than gates. A good way to die. Or not.”

“You’re making me very nervous,” Rhoena said.

“Stay by the gate,” he told her. “If anything goes wrong, shout *stop*.”

She didn’t like the way he said *if*, as if that were a constant in his life.

But she nodded, retreating to the shadow near the barred doors, arms folded, every sense straining.

In the circle, Salkin slid the sword into its scabbard and fastened the belt around his hips. He rolled his shoulders once, closing his eyes.

Inside, he reached for the Core.

“Combat profile,” he thought. “Full.”

Clarify: live-combat profile includes lethal-force optimizations.

“Targets are wood and straw,” he said silently. “No living beings. Release all constraints for non-living. I want to know how much of me made it through the gate.”

A pause. Then, almost reluctantly:

Confirming: environment contains no hostile organisms within immediate engagement radius.

Delta-Limit suspended for inanimate targets.

Muscle augmentation to 100%.

Neural acceleration to 320%.

Sensory gating: combat.

Cold slid into his veins.

The world sharpened.

The faint rustle of Rhoena's sleeve against stone, the tick of cooling metal on the weapon rack, the whisper of sand shifting under a stirred breeze—all of it snapped into crystal clarity and then faded into the background hum of *known factors*.

He opened his eyes.

The dummies stood in their three quiet rings, straw and wood and old leather.

He stood in the center, hand resting lightly on the hilt.

He let his breath slow until the in and out matched the pulse of Aether he'd learned to feel, the subtle push and pull of the field under his skin. Fire-mode tingled in his muscles, Lightning coiled along the edge of the blade still sheathed, waiting.

"Begin?" the Core prompted.

"Begin," he agreed.

From Rhoena's perspective, everything happened at once.

There was a sound, not quite a crack, more like the air itself flinching.

Salkin vanished.

No, not vanished—moved—but so fast and so clean her eyes simply refused to track the in-between. One heartbeat he was standing still, hand on hilt; the next he was a blur of pale skin and steel at the edge of the inner ring, then at the far side of the yard, then back again, a ghost flickering between dummies.

She'd fought fast people before. Hedge-mages with Lightning in their nerves, duelists with more speed than sense. This was… different.

There was no wasted motion. No dramatic spins. Just a series of impossibly exact steps and draws, each one accompanied by the whisper of steel leaving and re-entering leather, so quick it blurred into a single sustained hiss.

Dummies shuddered.

She didn't see the cuts. Only their aftermath: a head tumbling from a straw neck, a shield falling in two neat halves, a cuirass splitting open like fruit. Sand puffed where posts were severed so close to the ground it looked like they'd simply decided to lie down.

The air sparked around him. Tiny snaps of Lightning-mode flared along his path as if the universe itself were slightly offended by how quickly he demanded it move aside. Aether eddied, whipped into tight vortices that made the hairs on Rhoena's arms stir.

By the time her brain caught up enough to think *stop this*, it was over.

Salkin stood again in the center of the ring, sword resting against his hip.

The blade slid home into its sheath with a soft *shff*.

All around him, the dummies came apart.

It was almost elegant. As if some invisible hand had been holding them together until he was done, and then let go. Straw and cloth and splintered wood slid away from itself in pre-cut pieces, collapsing into untidy piles.

The nearest target—an armored dummy that had seen better days—had been cut in seven places so fine that for a heartbeat the cuirass simply hung there, edges kissing. Then it fell, each piece dropping in sequence like a slow, incredulous bow.

Rhoena realized her jaw was clenched.

She forced it to unlock.

“How…” she began, then stopped. Words were insufficient.

He was breathing a little faster now, chest rising and falling, but he didn’t look winded. A faint sheen of sweat on his skin caught the afternoon light. The silver lines under his flesh glowed, just for a moment, with residual charge before fading.

“Report,” he said inwardly.

Reaction times within 93% of pre-Gate baseline.

Fine-motor control uncompromised.

Aether interference: minimal; may be leveraged.

Conclusion: combat capability remains high against non-sentient targets.

“Sentient ones?” he thought.

Variable. Local aether-users present unknown factors.

“Of course,” he muttered.

Aloud, he said nothing.

Rhoena walked forward slowly, as if approaching a wild animal that might spook.

She toed the nearest ruined dummy with her boot. The cut through the post was so clean she could see the individual grains of wood.

“That took…three breaths,” she said.

“Two and a half,” he corrected automatically, then winced. “Sorry. Habit.”

She let out a breath that might have been a laugh if it weren’t so shaky.

“Don’t apologize for being precise,” she said. “If anything, I appreciate knowing exactly how doomed we’d be if you ever decided you didn’t like us.”

He flinched.

“I won’t,” he said, too fast. Then, more quietly: “I hope I won’t.”

She looked at him for a long time.

“Drabiretha told me once that in your world, they made soldiers in vats and in labs,” she said. “That you’re…built for this, as much as trained.”

He shook his head. “Not in vats. Just with…too many hands in the code.”

“To me,” she said, gesturing at the wrecked yard, “it looks like the gods took apart a dragon and forgot to put the scales back on.”

He huffed a short, disbelieving sound. “That is…a terrible image.”

“Accurate, though.” She nudged another fallen dummy. “You wanted to know your limits. Do you?”

He looked around.

Broken straw. Split leather. The faint, sharp smell of Lightning scorched into old wood.

“I know some,” he said. “Enough to be…afraid again. In a useful way.”

“And me?” she asked. “Should I be more afraid than I was, or less?”

He considered that, eyes meeting hers.

“More,” he said, because lying would have been worse. “But also… clearer. You know now that when I hold back with you, it is not because I cannot do more. It is because I choose not to.”

Rhoena nodded slowly.

“I’ll take that,” she said. “I’d rather stand next to someone who knows exactly how bad it could get and is fighting himself every step, than a fool who doesn’t know his own strength.”

She glanced around at the ruin of her yard and snorted.

“You’re cleaning this up, by the way.”

He blinked.

“What?”

“You heard me,” she said briskly. “Captain’s orders. You wanted targets, you got them. Now you and your perfect muscles can haul all this straw and timber off my sand before the afternoon drills.”

For a moment, he just stared at her.

Then, unexpectedly, he smiled. Not the thin, bitter twist he’d given the world so far, but something crooked and almost young.

“Understood,” he said. “Captain.”

As he bent to gather the first armload of shattered dummy, the Core noted, very quietly:

Host emotional state: elevated but stable.

Fear present. Also…satisfaction.

New pattern: non-lethal full-capacity discharge leads to positive adjustment.

Salkin ignored it.

The sword hung at his hip, quiet now. The yard smelled of sweat and straw and the faint, sharp tang of a world's aether still settling after being pushed too hard, too fast.

He had not taken a life.

He had not even raised his voice.

For the first time since he'd woken on the black shore, he had used everything he was built to be—and when it was over, there was something left of him standing in the center of the circle.

It wasn't peace.

But it was a start.

Chapter Eight — Steel and Aether

They'd gotten used to having him at the table.

Not all at once. The first dinners, he sat like a ghost at the far right, half-turned toward the door, eating in small, suspicious bites while Drabiretha and her inner circle pretended very hard that having an uncollared man in the Lunarch's private hall was normal.

But routine was a powerful spell. After a while, even this became one more pattern in the house.

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The high dining room opened onto a balcony where the night wind could slip in, carrying salt and lantern-smoke from Lunarys below. Dragons and moons curled along the carved beams. The long table was set with simple clay and silver: no court-treasures here, just well-made things that could survive a dropped elbow.

Tonight it held: spiced fish, flatbread, braised root-vegetables, a cold salad of sea-greens. And people.

Drabiretha at the head, horns catching the lamplight. On her right, Rhoena in clean uniform, still smelling faintly of sand and oil. On her left, Warden Elenai, lean and watchful. Maera, Brynja, two more trusted officers filled the nearer seats.

Salkin had, over quiet protest, been moved up the table until he sat opposite Rhoena, two places down from Drabiretha, where she could watch him without craning her neck.

He handled chopsticks now with the same eerie precision he turned on everything else. The servants still stared sometimes when they thought they could get away with it: at the pale man

with the fast eyes, collarless neck bare, silver lines sometimes glinting faint under his skin.

“So,” Drabiretha said lightly halfway through the meal, as one might comment on the weather, “I hear you broke my training yard again.”

Rhoena, in the middle of a mouthful of bread, nearly choked.

“With respect, Lunarch, the yard is *fine*,” she protested once Maera had thumped her back. “Just… less full of intact dummies.”

“Clarify,” Drabiretha said, turning that cool, interested gaze on her captain. “Elenai has given me the healer’s version. I would like the soldier’s.”

Rhoena glanced at Salkin, who was calmly dismantling a piece of fish as if they were discussing someone else entirely.

“He asked for the yard to himself,” she said. “And a live blade. I agreed, on the condition I be there to stop him if he lost control.”

“You didn’t,” Drabiretha noted.

“No.” Rhoena’s mouth quirked. “I didn’t *have* time. He set three circles of dummies, stood in the middle, and…moved.”

She gestured helplessly.

“Fast?” Brynja suggested.

“Fast I know,” Rhoena said. “I’ve fought hedge-mages and dragon-touched and that lunatic from Vermilion Standard who thought speed was a personality. This was…worse. Better. I blinked and the yard was quiet again and everything in three rings was in more pieces than the quartermaster is going to forgive.”

Maera snorted into her cup.

“How long?” Drabiretha asked.

“Two, maybe three breaths,” Rhoena admitted. “He says two and a half. I’ll let the scholars argue.”

All eyes slid, as if pulled by a thread, to Salkin.

He looked up slowly, swallowed his mouthful.

“It was a test,” he said. “Not of them.” He jerked his chin toward Rhoena. “Of…me. Of how much of my…capacity…this world stole.”

“And?” Drabiretha prompted.

He hesitated, then let the truth stand naked.

“Less than I hoped,” he said. “More than I feared.”

Elenai frowned faintly. “Meaning?”

“He can still cut you into very neat pieces before you think to raise your shield,” Rhoena translated, cheerful as a blade in sunlight. “If he wants to. He chose to prove that on straw instead of us. I choose to be grateful.”

Salkin winced.

“I needed to know,” he said, more to Drabiretha than anyone else. “If I am to be…safe…here, I must know where the cliff-edge is.”

“And how does that make you feel?” Maera asked, then rolled her eyes at herself. “Listen to me. I’ve been spending too much time with the priestesses.”

“How it makes me feel,” Salkin said slowly, “is loud. But also… clearer. Before, all my strength was a…shadow. Now at least I can see the shape of the monster under the bed.”

A quiet settled around the table. Not comfortable, but not jagged either. Like a scab that everyone agreed not to pick at in public.

Drabiretha sipped her wine.

“I would rather you and I know the shape of it than pretend it isn’t there,” she said. “Ignorance makes worse monsters.”

He inclined his head in grudging agreement.

They ate in relative peace after that, the conversation drifting to patrol rotations, a minor dispute between two merchant houses down by the Jade Quays, gossip about a new theater troupe in the Ember District. Salkin listened more than he spoke, filing words and names with the same hungry efficiency he applied to books.

At the end of the meal, as servants moved in with sweet tea and little bowls of candied nuts, he set his cup down and cleared his throat.

“Lunarch,” he said.

The subtle shift around the table said everyone heard the change in his tone.

“Yes, Salkin?” Drabiretha replied.

“I need…” He paused, reassembling phrasing. “I request access to a forge.”

That got her attention.

“A forge,” she repeated. “For what?”

“A weapon,” he said. “For myself.”

The air cooled.

Rhoena's hand stilled on her cup. Elenai's gaze sharpened. Brynja glanced between them, calculating.

Drabiretha set her own cup down very precisely.

"You have used our blades well enough," she said. "Why this?"

"The sword from yesterday is…failing," he said. "It was not made to…carry what I am. The edge chipped in three places. The spine is…stressed." He flexed his fingers, remembering the subtle wrongness in the steel. "If I am to fight again—if I must—then I need a weapon that will not…shatter when I ask too much."

"What you did to those dummies," Rhoena muttered, "was asking too much of any sane steel."

"Then I will make one that is…less sane," he said, a flicker of dark humor passing over his face. "I am not a master-smith. But I know enough of metal. And now, enough of your…aether…to try."

Drabiretha studied him.

"Such a blade," she said, "would make many clans very interested in whose hand holds it."

"Many clans," he said quietly, "are already interested in the man who does not wear a collar. One more thing on the pile will not change the weight much." He met her eyes. "Better that if someone tries to take me, I hold something that will not break in their face."

Elenai exhaled, long and slow. "He has a point."

Rhoena grimaced. "I hate that he has a point."

Drabiretha tapped a claw against her cup, thinking.

“A weapon you forge yourself,” she said at last. “Not one my smiths craft to my measure. Not one registered to any clan. Truly yours.”

“Yes,” he said simply. “It will also be a…measure. Of what I understand, now. Of how your world’s bones bend. When I learn more, I will make another. But the first—” He shrugged, the movement small. “The first tells me where I stand.”

Silence again.

Then Drabiretha inclined her head.

“Very well,” she said. “Brynja, speak to Master Ithan. The lesser forge under the east tower is half-idle this season. We will clear it for our guest in the afternoons. Salkin, you will not work alone—not with fire—” Maera made a disapproving noise at the thought—“but the bellows and tools will be yours to command within reason. You will show Rhoena every stage. If I smell even a *hint* of enchantment or pattern that smells like a binding, we end this. Agreed?”

He blinked, surprised she’d granted it so quickly.

“Agreed,” he said.

Rhoena grunted. “If he’s swinging it anywhere near my women, I want to know exactly what’s in its bones.”

“You’ll have front-row seats,” Drabiretha assured her.

The matter, as far as the table was concerned, was settled.

But as Salkin followed Rhoena out into the corridor afterward, stomach warm from fish and tea, he felt a different warmth under his skin.

It tasted like…purpose.

Work.

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The east forge was tucked into the base of a tower that smelled of oil, sweat, and old oaths.

Master Ithan was a broad-shouldered woman with arms like bundled cable and more gray in her hair than not. She looked Salkin up and down with the professional skepticism of someone who'd seen every breed of nervous apprentice and swaggering officer come through her doors.

"So," she said. "You're the Lunarch's ghost."

"I am Salkin," he said. "The rest is…arguable."

She snorted.

"She says you're allowed," Ithan went on. "Says I'm to make sure you don't drown yourself in the quench trough or set your eyebrows on fire. Says you know which end of a hammer to hold. We'll see."

He inclined his head. "Fair."

She showed him the space: anvil scarred from decades of use, small and great hammers, tongs of various bites, a brick furnace whose aether-fed flames could be coaxed from a gentle orange to a white-hot roar with the right sigils on the bellows.

"For clan work, we mostly do armor, tools, horseshoes," Ithan said. "Fancy pattern-welded blades when some Jade-collared court lady wants to look like she knows what blood is. Weapons that actually

see use, I try to keep simple and honest." She eyed him. "What do you want to make?"

"A sword," he said. "Single-edged. Curved. Thick spine, strong enough to survive…me."

"So you're a humble one," she muttered. "Steel we have. Good ore. You know how to judge it?"

"I know how steel…should behave," he said. "Your metals may… sing differently here. I will learn."

She made a noncommittal noise, but there was the faintest glint of interest in her eyes now. Smiths respected anyone who spoke of learning with that kind of blunt certainty.

"Fine," she said. "You burn the place down, I'll haunt you. Don't break my hammers."

She left him then, retreating to the upper forge where journeymen hacked away at horseshoes and cauldrons, leaving him with the lower hearth, Rhoena leaning in the doorway like a guardian gargoyle.

"You sure about this?" she asked as he rolled up his sleeves.

"No," he said. "But I am sure I need to try."

He sorted through bars of steel with careful fingers, feeling not just weight and grain but the subtle textures in the aether around them. Some sang with brighter Fire, some with steadier Earth. One, thicker and duller on the surface, hummed deep with a slow, stubborn tone that resonated in his bones.

"This one," he murmured, lifting it.

Rhoena watched.

“You can feel the…elements in it,” she said. Not quite a question.

“Yes,” he said. “Not like your mages. But enough to know this will…hold.”

He stoked the forge.

The aether-fed fire leapt eagerly under his attention, flames shifting from red to yellow to a hotter, paler shade. He listened to the way Fire and Air tangled, how Lightning crackled at the edges when he pushed too hard, how Aether settled into a new balance with each bellows stroke.

In his old world, smelting and forging had been science down to the last molecule. Here, it was closer to…song.

He let the Core translate where it could—temperature estimates, stress calculations—but more and more, he found himself leaning on feel.

Heat the bar until it glowed a certain color that made the aether around it hum. Pull it out. Hammer, not as a brute, but as a conductor, driving invisible waves deeper into the metal with each strike.

He folded.

Not the complex pattern-welding of master-smiths seeking pretty lines, but plain, practical layers, each one a chance to drive out weakness. Each time, he reached inward, nudged Earth-mode stronger in the cooling metal, bled a bit of Fire away so it wouldn’t become brittle.

Rhoena watched, arms folded, saying nothing.

To her, it looked like any other forge-work—if a touch more precise, a touch more eerily *correct*. His hammer never glanced

where it meant to fall. The steel moved under his blows as if eager to become what he asked.

But to Salkin, it was a delicate negotiation.

The Core whispered yields and tolerances in his skull. The aether whispered different things: here is where the grain likes to run, here is where Lightning will take if you invite it, here is where Water-memory will heal cracks if you cool me *just so*.

He tried something, halfway through the long afternoon.

As he drew the rough blade-shape out—thick spine, gentle curve toward the edge—he paused, holding the glowing metal above the anvil.

“Lightning,” he thought, reaching not outward but inward, to the coiled mode he’d tasted along runes and steel fittings in the house. “Here.”

He invited it, the way he’d invited Fire to the candle, but different: not to flare and burn, but to *etch*.

A faint, invisible snap went through the blade. Rhoena’s hair lifted slightly with static.

“What was that?” she asked sharply.

“Experiment,” he grunted, sweat running down his back. “If it… works, the Lightning will…sit in the grain. Give it…resilience. Let it drink…shock.”

“You are putting *lightning* in the sword,” she said flatly.

“Yes.”

“Is that safe?”

“For me?” He considered. “We will see.”

“Reassuring,” she muttered.

The quench was the true test.

He’d seen how their smiths did it: straight into water, or oil, or brine steeped with herbs that changed the way the aether folded. He did not have their lore, but he had feel.

He prepared a trough of oil and water mixed in strange ratios, listening to how the two elements resisted and then accepted each other, how Aether threaded both.

When the blade glowed the right shade, when the aether around it sang on the edge of too-bright, he moved.

Down, into the quench, edge-first.

Steam roared up. The field around them bucked. For a heartbeat, it felt like the whole world held its breath.

He fed Water-mode into the trough with his will, coaxing, soothing, asked Earth to settle, nudged Lightning to curl deep instead of jumping madly to the surface.

When the hissing stopped, he pulled the blade free.

It was dark, dull, rough-shaped. Nothing special to the untrained eye.

But when he rested it on his palms, he could *feel* it.

The steel hummed. Not loudly, not wildly, but with a low, steady note that matched his bones. The line between edge and spine felt…right. The aether within it had settled into a pattern he could trace: Earth like a backbone, Fire coiled quiet in the edge, Lightning braided through like nerves, Water holding memory of this shape, Aether binding all.

He exhaled.

Rhoena, who had held her own breath longer than she'd admit, let it go in a rush.

"Well?" she demanded.

He smiled, small and tired and very real.

"First pass," he said. "We will see after I grind and sharpen. Then we test." A flicker of mischief: "On your dummies. Again."

She groaned. "You and Master Ithan can argue about who replaces them."

He set the blade carefully on the rack to cool.

The Core whispered:

New material profile recorded.

Hybrid-aetheric steel, Type I.

Predicted failure point significantly higher than local baseline.

Salkin ignored the data for once.

He stood there in the fading forge-heat, hands still tingling, and thought:

I made this. With their rules. With mine.

"I can…always forge a better one," he said aloud, half to Rhoena, half to himself. "As I learn more. Each will say… who I was…when I made it."

"A diary in steel," Rhoena said.

"Yes," he said softly. "Something like that."

He wiped soot from his face with the back of his wrist and looked around the forge: the tools, the anvil, the hearth still glowing, the faint coils of aether curling lazily under the rafters.

For the first time since his world had died, he felt not just like an exile using borrowed tools—but like a craftsman at the very beginning of a new, strange art.

It was a fragile feeling.

But it held.

Chapter Nine — Moonlight in the Gardens

He’d seen so little of Lunarys that wasn’t stone, sand, or steel.

Corridors. The sanctuary yard. The forge’s red glow. The training hall with its scuffed floors and loud ghosts of old shouts.

Beauty, when his mind had room for it at all, had been confined to pages: careful ink drawings of dragons and maps, four-line poems about mountain dawn, a painted panel in the dining hall that showed the Jade Dragon Empress stepping on the neck of some long-dead tyrant.

He knew, in the same way he knew the city existed beyond the walls, that the world could be beautiful. He just hadn’t…looked.

Drabiretha changed that by simple, stubborn force of will.

“You have worn ruts into my floors,” she said one afternoon, appearing in his doorway without fanfare. “And Rhoena swears you’ll start correcting the way the *statues* stand if we leave you in the yard much longer. Walk with me.”

He opened his mouth to protest.

She lifted a hand. “Not a command. An invitation. If your other mind is loud today, perhaps it would like new data.”

The Core, traitor that it was, liked that idea very much.

External survey of local biosphere may increase understanding of aetheric field variations.

“Fine,” Salkin muttered. “For the data.”

“For the data,” Drabiretha agreed, lips twitching. “And perhaps because being under a sky without someone trying to kill you is… novel.”

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Her private gardens nested like a second, softer keep behind the inner halls, wrapped in high white walls veined with green crystal.

He’d seen hints of them from his window: flashes of leaf and blossom, the glitter of water.

Inside, they were…more.

Cushioned paths of smoothed white stone wound between beds of plants he had no names for: tall spires of violet petals that hummed quietly with their own aether-song, low mats of silver-green leaves that released a sharp, clean scent when brushed. Trees spread layered canopies overhead, their bark pale, their leaves edged in luminous blue that glowed faintly where the sun slanted through.

“Some of these came as gifts,” Drabiretha said as they walked, hands folded behind her back. “Cuttings from the Empress’s own terraces. Seeds traded for from Wind-Spire and the floating gardens of Zephyr Pearl. A few are…older than our history admits.”

“What do they…do?” Salkin asked, because it was easier than admitting he was simply struck dumb.

“Some heal,” she said, nodding toward a patch of blue-veined herbs. “Some poison. Some are pretty, and that is work enough in a hard world.”

A breeze brushed his face. It smelled of wet stone, distant sea, and something sweet and unfamiliar that his battered brain tried and failed to categorize.

The aether here moved differently than in the yard or the forge. Softer currents, more Water and Earth, threads of Air weaving lazily instead of in sharp drafts, Fire banked low in the warm soil and under bark. Lightning slept coiled in crystals set among the paths, waking now and then in tiny, playful sparks when Drabiretha's claws clicked just so.

Children would love this place, he thought, and the thought startled him because he hadn't thought about children—anyone's—in a very long time.

They walked without speaking for a while.

Birds—actual birds, feathered, shrill, bright—flitted between branches. A pair of tiny lizards chased each other along a wall, leaving faint ripples in the aether where their little hearts pounded.

"You are scanning, aren't you," Drabiretha said eventually, without heat.

"Yes," he admitted.

"Good," she said. "Better to know how living things bend aether than to find out the hard way by breaking them."

They turned a corner, and the path opened.

At the garden's heart stood a broad, shallow pool cut in a perfect circle out of white stone. Low steps led down to the water's edge. In its center rose a cluster of carved pillars, each shaped like a

dragon in flight, their stone bodies twining, mouths open to the sky.

Water slid from their jaws in thin, continuous sheets, falling into the pool without a sound. The surface reflected the sky so clearly that, for a dizzy instant, Salkin felt as if he stood at the edge of a hole into another world.

As they approached, the nearest dragon's eyes lit with a soft inner glow. The cascading sheets of water shifted, ripples tightening and then smoothing until the surface gave back not the bright blue of afternoon but a deepening indigo.

A pale curve pushed up from the darkness: the first sliver of the moon, rising.

Except the sky above them was still day-blue, the actual moon nowhere in sight.

"A…projection," Salkin said quietly. "An image."

"A mirror," Drabiretha corrected. "Tuned to the sky as it will be, not as it is. The Empress gifted it when I took this post. 'So you remember,' she said, 'that what you see is not always all there is.'" Her mouth quirked. "She is fond of lessons you must walk past every day."

They sat.

The stone at the water's edge was warm from the sun. Someone had left cushions tucked discreetly in a recess nearby; Drabiretha took one and gestured for him to do the same.

He obeyed. Out of habit, he positioned himself where he could see the approaches, back not quite to a wall. Old reflexes died harder than universes.

For a while, there was only the quiet clatter of water, the rustle of leaves, the distant, softened noise of Lunarys beyond the walls.

If he let his attention unfocus just right, he could feel the way the pool pulled at the aether: a slow, steady sink of Water-mode, calming the field, drawing harsh edges off the Fire that clung to him like a scar.

“You never come here,” Drabiretha said softly, watching the moon’s reflection climb. “Even when Maera tells you the air in the sickrooms is too thick.”

“Too…alive,” he said. “Too many…stories in the walls.”

“And here?” she asked.

He considered.

“It’s…” He searched for a word in her tongue that wasn’t inadequate. “Still. But not…empty. Like the…quiet between… waves.”

She smiled, just a little.

“That is what I asked the gardeners to weave,” she said. “Sanctuary. Not absence.”

He felt something ease in his shoulders that he hadn’t realized was tight.

For the first time since he’d arrived in this world, he wasn’t counting exits or weapons or estimating the radius of blast if something went wrong. He was just…sitting. Beside a pool that showed a moon not yet risen, in a garden that smelled of green things and running water.

He looked up.

The outer sky was beginning to tint toward evening now, the first bronze at the horizon. High clouds caught the light in streaks of gold. A flock of pale birds wheeled, their wings slicing through Air-mode with bright little signatures his mind tagged almost automatically.

He caught himself smiling at that, and shook his head.

“What?” Drabiretha asked.

“Nothing,” he said. “Just…remembering that there are still trivial problems in the universe. Like ‘is that bird going to…defecate on me.’”

She snorted, delighted. “If it does, I will consider it a blessing. The last man who sat here long enough to be shat on by the sky solved a border dispute that had lasted three generations.”

“Fearsome magic,” he said dryly.

“Practical,” she countered.

He huffed a soft breath.

His gaze drifted back to the water.

The reflected moon was higher now, fattening into a silver coin. The dragons’ stone mouths glowed faintly from within, casting soft white light over the pool. It painted the underside of the leaves, caught in Drabiretha’s hair, traced the edges of her horns.

He had, intellectually, known she was striking from the moment he’d been able to see straight.

Tall. Horned. Eyes like a predator’s, built to see too much. The inhuman grace of an Aelunari carried in a body that wore power the way other women wore jewelry.

But until now, he'd only read that as *threat*. As something to track, to understand, to work around.

The moonlight erased some of the sharpness and left…lines.

The long curve of her throat where her collar lay open. The scatter of faint, silvered scars at the base of one horn, old stress fractures mended but not quite erased. The way her mouth softened when she wasn't thinking about who might be watching her think.

She was talking about something—some minor Noble of Vermilion Standard who'd sent an offensive letter and received it back with corrections in red ink—but the words blurred for a heartbeat as his brain did something it hadn't done in a long, long time.

It registered her as beautiful.

Not in the abstract way he might have admired a well-designed gate or an elegant equation. Not as a piece on a board, all angles and leverage.

Just…beautiful.

Warmth curled in his gut, quick and unwelcome, like a flare of Fire where he hadn't meant to invite it.

Elevated heart rate, the Core observed mildly. Pupil dilation. Hormonal profile shift toward—

No.

He slammed a wall down on the thought hard enough that the machine-mind actually stuttered.

"Are you all right?" Drabiretha asked, head tilting. "You went very still."

"I am…fine," he said too quickly. "Just…a…wave in the pool."

She glanced at the water, then back at him, clearly not wholly convinced.

He clamped down harder.

This is your host, he told himself. Your patron. Your *jailer* if she chose to be. The woman who could sell you to a clan and be applauded for political savvy. The last person in any world you are allowed to tangle with in your head like this.

And yet.

Beauty didn't care about chains. It didn't ask permission to exist. It simply sat beside a moonlit pool in a carefully grown garden and talked about border disputes while her horns caught the light, and his traitorous human brain reacted exactly the way it had been built to react before war and gates and gods had chewed it up.

He exhaled slowly.

"Thank you," he said, surprising himself as much as her.

"For the garden?" she asked.

"For…reminding me the world can be…this," he said, gesturing weakly at the water, the leaves, the soft wash of color in the sky. "Not only…black shores and…training yards."

Her expression shifted, something like relief flickering through it.

"You are welcome," she said simply. "You are too…sharp…for constant edges. Even blades must touch whetstone and oil, not only bone."

He huffed something that might have been a laugh. "You make me sound very high-maintenance."

“Oh, you are,” she said gravely. “If I had known how much trouble you would be, I would have told the sea to send me a simple shipwrecked poet instead.”

“You would be bored in a week,” he said before he could stop himself.

Her smile answered his.

“Yes,” she said. “I would.”

Silence settled again, less heavy this time.

The moon climbed in the pool. Its reflection painted a silver path across the water to their feet.

He watched it, letting himself, just for these few breaths, exist in a moment that was not defined by loss or duty. A garden. A rising moon. A beautiful, infuriating woman who had dragged him back from death and refused to let him slip quietly away.

He could not afford to…want.

He knew too well how duty and affection tangled and strangled both. He knew power imbalances, the ugly histories they wrote.

So he locked that little spark of awareness—of her throat, her hands, the way her voice dropped when she was tired—into a box in his mind, labeled it *dangerous*, and set heavy things on the lid.

But he could not, would not, deny that it was there.

The Core, blessedly, said nothing. Perhaps even it understood that some variables were not for calculation.

“Drabiretha,” he said softly, tasting her name in the gathering dark.

“Yes, Salkin?”

“This world…” He searched for a word and had to steal one from a children’s story he’d read the night before. “It is…beautiful. I had not…seen.”

She looked out over her garden, at the pool and the trees and the walls that held all this gently inside.

“It is,” she agreed. “It is also cruel. And foolish. And loud. But it is mine. For as long as it will have me.”

She glanced at him, and the corner of her mouth lifted.

“For as long as it will have *us*,” she corrected.

He didn’t trust his voice, so he only inclined his head.

In the water, the future moon climbed higher, silver and serene, over a world that did not yet know what it had drawn onto its black shore.

Chapter Ten — The Quiet Knives

He woke up with the taste of moonlight still in his mouth.

Not literally, of course. But the memory of the garden—water and dragons and a rising reflection of a moon that wasn't yet there—sat heavy in him like something he'd swallowed and not quite digested.

Beauty. And the dangerous, traitorous awareness of the woman who'd shown it to him.

So the next morning, instead of going straight to the yard or the forge, he went looking for her.

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He found Drabiretha in her small council room, not the grand hall.

Here, the table was round, not long. Shelves lined the walls, crammed with scrolls, slim bound books, boxes with seals. A large window let in salt light from the city below. A pot of tea steamed gently between two low cups.

She looked up as he paused in the doorway.

"Salkin," she said. "You are early. I hadn't expected you until the fourth bell; Rhoena hasn't yet finished terrorizing the spear-line."

"I…asked Elenai," he said. "Where you were. I would…ask something."

Her eyes sharpened a little. "Come in, then. Close the door."

He did. The soft *click* felt more final than it should have.

Drabiretha poured a second cup of tea and gestured to the chair opposite her.

He sat, hands on his knees, aware of how formal he must look and unable to do anything about it.

“What do you want?” she asked, in that direct, almost painfully honest way of hers.

“Lessons,” he said.

One dark brow climbed. “You are already halfway through my entire shelf of legal scrolls. I hesitate to guess what you consider a ‘lesson’.”

“Those are words,” he said. “I need…context. If I am to live here—not only exist—I must know more than your…physics. I must know the *rules*. The written ones. And the ones no one writes down.”

Her gaze softened at the edges.

“You want culture,” she said. “Custom. Law. The unspoken. All the quiet knives that aren’t in any book.”

“Yes,” he said.

“And you want it from me, not from a priestess or a registrar.”

He nodded once.

“You will not like some of it,” she warned. “Especially the parts about men.”

“I already…do not like what little I have seen,” he said drily. “Better I hate the truth than be…cut by surprise.”

That earned him a small, grim smile.

“Very well,” she said. “Lesson one: in the Jade Empire, ignorance is never a defense. If you break a law you didn’t know, they will say you should have asked. Consider this you…asking.”

He inclined his head. “Then…begin at the worst.”

“The worst,” she said quietly, “*is* men.”

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She didn’t rush.

If anything, she slowed down, as if choosing each word mattered.

“Formally,” she began, “the Empire is governed by the Jade Dragon Empress. Beneath her, the Great Clans hold land and law. Every child is born to a clan, or to none. Women inherit names, banners, command. Men…” She trailed off, jaw tightening. “Men are… different.”

“In my world,” Salkin said, “we tried to make no law that…split rights by sex. We failed, often. But we tried.”

“In mine,” Drabiretha said, “we pretended we *had* to.”

She folded her hands on the table, claws clicking once, then stilling.

“Men here are rare,” she said. “They always have been. As far back as our histories reach, only one child in ten is born male. The old stories offer explanations—dragon bargains, the balance of the world—but no one knows why. Those born are…treasured, feared, hoarded.” A bitter twist of her mouth. “A man is wealth that bleeds. Leverage that laughs. Vulnerability that can be stolen.”

He thought of the guarded caravans, the way the household moved around him like a wall whenever they left the sanctuary.

“So they built laws,” she went on. “To keep men ‘safe’. To mark who owns that safety. To make theft cost something.”

“Collars,” he said.

“Yes.” She didn’t flinch from the word. “Every man born to a registered clan is collared before his Naming Day. A band of metal or stone at the throat, marked with his clan-sigil and registry seal. It is…more than jewelry, less than a chain. In theory, it is proof of protection. It says: this life *belongs* to these people; harm him and you answer to them.”

“In practice?” he asked.

“In practice,” she said flatly, “it is a stamp on livestock. A way to say ‘mine’ loud enough that the law will agree.”

Silence stretched.

“And men without collars?” he asked quietly.

“Do not exist,” she said. “By law, they cannot. Any uncollared man found within the Empire’s borders is, by decree of the Throne, property of the Empress, to be held in trust until his status is… regularized.”

“Regularized,” he repeated. “Sold.”

“Assigned,” she corrected, though it didn’t make the taste any better. “Formally, she grants guardianship. To a clan. A temple. A sanctuary. A person. The guardian holds his legal personhood. Speaks for him. Manages contracts made around him—marriage, service, children, work.” Her eyes met his. “This is not a thing I say with pride, Salkin. Only with accuracy.”

He sat very still.

“And me?” he asked. “What does your…paper…say I am?”

She did not look away.

“You are, by law, uncollared,” she said. “Which means you are the Empress’s trust. In practice, she has not yet decided what to *do* with you, because no one has written a law for ‘man spat out by dragon-touched shore with a dead universe in his head’.” A flicker of wry humor ghosted across her face. “Until she decides, she has delegated your custody to me. I am your…guardian.”

He let that sink in.

“So I have…no rights,” he said. “Only what you…lend me.”

A muscle jumped in her jaw.

“You have *personhood*,” she said, a little too sharply. “You are not a beast. Any assault on your body is still a crime. Any child you sire is still…yours, in the ways that matter. You have the right to temple protection, to sanctuary from Rings, to refuse a pairing you explicitly do not consent to.”

He looked at her.

“And if I…explicitly do not consent to being…owned?”

Her eyes closed for a heartbeat.

“Then,” she said quietly, “you may take it up with a dragon and a Throne that sit on laws older than my grandmother’s bones.”

Anger coiled in his gut. Not at her. At the universe, at the way every reality found a new shape for old cruelties.

“In my world,” he said, “we said that any system that needs collars ‘for protection’ is telling on itself.”

“In mine,” she said, “we said any woman who questioned them was selfishly risking all men for the chance to feel *better* about

herself.” Her mouth thinned. “Ask me how many times I have been called that. Ask me how little I care now.”

He stared at her for a long moment.

“How far can you bend this,” he asked. “Without breaking…you.”

“In my house,” she said, “I can treat you as…guest. Partner. Advisor. I can let you sit unsupervised with weapons. I can listen when you say ‘no’. I can choose not to lend you to a cousin’s daughter with more ambition than sense.” The words came out dry, brittle. “Outside my walls, I must pretend your collar is merely…invisible. I must sign for you. Stand between you and any registrar who wants to write you into a ledger.”

“And if you die,” he said, “before your Empress decides.”

“Then the trust returns to her,” Drabiretha said. “You go to the Palace. To the Dragon’s Registry. There, the knives are…prettier. But they cut the same.”

The room felt smaller.

He tugged at the empty space around his throat, phantom weight itching where a collar would sit.

“And the…unwritten laws?” he asked, because knowing half the ugliness was useless.

She exhaled slowly.

“Unwritten,” she said, “men are…not supposed to know we have this conversation. They are meant to believe their collars are love-shirts. Gifts. Symbols of care. If they are clever, they learn to work within it without ever saying *why*.”

He went very still.

“Officially,” she continued, “men are ‘honored dependents’. Too precious for front-lines. Too vulnerable for politics. Too sheltered to understand the dirtier corners of trade or war. Unwritten: no one lets them touch the levers of power unless they come with a woman’s hand on their shoulder. A mother. A sister. A wife. A guardian.”

“And if a man wishes to leave,” he said. “To walk away.”

She laughed.

It was a short, humorless sound.

“Where,” she asked, “would he go? Every clan keeps ledgers. The city gates are watched. The Rings are hungry. A man wandering alone is meat in a shark-pool. We tell ourselves this is why we leash them. We do not ask who stocked the pool.”

Silence stretched again.

Images flickered in his head: Alexia’s lab, collars of code and oath; the way his own people had told themselves the Archive was a “trust” and not a chain. Different words. Same shape.

“What of choice,” he asked. “Marriage. Sex. Children.”

“Formally,” she said, “no contract of the body is valid without a man’s voiced consent and his guardian’s seal. Unwritten: if a clan wants a child badly enough, they will lean very hard on both. Poor men in poor houses become…coin. Men in rich houses become… bargaining chips.”

She didn’t soften it.

She didn’t say *not here* or *not in Moonhold*. She did not try to convince him her house was different, though in some ways it was.

“You hate this,” he said quietly.

“Yes,” she said simply.

“You live in it.”

“Yes,” she said again. “I live in it. I benefit from it. I have *used* it, more times than I like to count, to keep worse people from doing worse things.”

He appreciated the honesty even as it scraped him raw.

“In Crystal Moon,” she went on, “we try to be…better. We collared no man into Rings. We do not sell. We vet every proposed pairing through priestesses who actually listen when a man says ‘I do not want this woman’. But the bones of the law are the same. The Empire does not change because one Lunarch’s stomach turns.”

He sat back, staring at nothing.

The Core, ever helpful, began building models of power flows, writing notes in the margins of his mind:

Legal agency vector passes primarily through registered female guardian.

Host autonomy limited in formal spaces.

Strategy: maximize influence with guardian; treat her as joint-node.

He slammed another internal door.

“I will not,” he thought at it, sharp, “game her like a system.”

Clarification: cooperation increases survival odds.

“Not like *that*.”

Out loud, he said:

“What do you expect from me…inside this.”

She blinked.

“Expect?” she echoed.

“You are my…guardian,” he said, the word bitter. “Host. Emissary to…this. Is your plan that I pretend to be…good property? That I smile and nod and let women argue over…who has the right to my throat?”

She winced.

“My plan,” she said slowly, “is that you survive long enough to make your own. I will tell you where the walls are. You may then choose whether to push them, climb them, dig under them, or paint them pretty patterns and ignore what they are.”

He stared at her, then huffed a laugh that was more breath than sound.

“You know you are asking for trouble,” he said.

“I know trouble,” she said dryly. “I made a career of inviting it to dinner and teaching it the right fork to use.”

He went quiet again, fingers tracing the grain of the table.

“Are there any…men,” he asked eventually, “who hold…real power. Here.”

“Not alone,” she said. “Never alone. But there are husbands who whisper into ears that listen. Brothers who run numbers no sister can read. Priests whose blessings turn tides. Lovers who say ‘do not do this’ and are heeded because the woman who would have signed the order cannot bear to see them flinch.”

Her eyes rested on him.

“And now,” she said, “there is a man with a dead universe in his head and a sword in his hand sitting at my table. I would be a fool not to consider that its own kind of power.”

He met her gaze.

“What are you going to do with that, Lunarch?” he asked softly.

The corner of her mouth twitched.

“For now?” she said. “Teach it to read our ledgers and not stab anyone at dinner. Beyond that…we will see.”

He snorted, despite himself.

“Practical,” he said.

“The only magic I trust,” she replied.

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Later, much later, when the lesson had drifted away from collars and into things like gift-giving customs and why you never, ever stepped on threshold charms with your left foot, he found himself staring at his hands.

“In my world,” he said, “we said that knowledge is power. Here, I feel like knowledge is…just weight.”

“It is both,” Drabiretha said. “Power that does not weigh on you is usually sitting on someone else’s back.”

He turned that over.

“I will not wear a collar,” he said at last. Not a shout. A quiet, iron statement of fact.

“I know,” she said.

“And I will not pretend to be…grateful…for laws that call me child while making me…weapon.”

“I would worry for you if you were,” she said.

He looked up.

“Then why,” he asked, “tell me all this, knowing I will not…fit nicely in it.”

“Because you already don’t,” she said. “Because I would rather you rage at the truth than break yourself against rules you didn’t know were there. Because if you are going to help me tear at the edges of this thing—” she waved a hand, meaning the empire, the law, all of it “—I need you angry at the *right* targets, not lashing out at my guards because some idiot registrar called you ‘boy’.”

He flinched at *boy*. She saw. She didn’t apologize for using it.

“You asked for lessons,” she said. “This is lesson one: the world is unfair in ways that are older than either of us. Lesson two, if you’re ready for it, is that we get to choose which parts we break first.”

He sat back, feeling the anger and helplessness and bitter, exhausted humor all swirl in his chest.

“Lesson three?” he asked, because he was a fool, and because she was right: better to know.

Her smile was sharp and tired and something like fond.

“Lesson three,” she said, “is that I am on your side even when the law is not. Do not forget that, storm-gift, when some sanctimonious registrar tells you otherwise.”

He held her gaze for a long, steady moment.

“I won’t,” he said.

It sounded, to his own ears, perilously like a promise.

It hit him like a shell.

No warning, no gentle rise from dream to nightmare—just impact.

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The sky had no color.

Not black, not gray. Just…absence, like someone had taken a brush and scraped reality off the dome above them. The ground under his boots wasn’t ground at all but a skin of half-resolved matter: metal here, glass there, patches of something like bone where the Void had already chewed and swallowed and spat back nonsense.

His squad stood in a ragged crescent.

He remembered them by callsigns now more than faces. Flicker. Jen. Old Davi with the bad knee and the good jokes. A dozen figures in adaptive armor, helmets sealed, rifles humming, nanofields flaring as the incoming wave hit.

Not men, not machines. Just *them*.

Enemies that didn’t have shapes, not really. Things that looked like wrong reflections of things your brain *almost* recognized—a hand with too many angles, a mouth with no center, a tangle of limbs that weren't sure where they began.

And behind them, it.

The Void Lord.

They’d used other words in the briefings. High-Order Incursion Entity. Command-Class Anomaly. But nothing in the neat, clinical

language of the Archive had captured the way its presence made his teeth ache.

It was…*large*. Not in meters or mass, but in how much of the world it displaced. Looking at it was like trying to look directly at an equation too big to fit on any page. Bits of it refused to resolve: your eyes slid over them and found more wrongness underneath.

Where it passed, the ground stopped pretending to be anything. Tiles of melted reality fell away into a deep, featureless dark.

They weren't supposed to fight something like this.

They were a delay squad. Speedbump. The real weapons were still inbound, streaking across the sky in kill-sat vectors and gateburner arcs. All Salkin's team had to do was *not die* long enough that their deaths would matter.

"Positions," his lieutenant's voice crackled in his ear. Her calm was brittle. "Remember your drills. Don't look at the core. Don't let it touch you. Bleed its advance."

Easy orders. Like "hold back the ocean with your hands."

The first wave hit.

Shapes broke against their line, dissolving into grayscale ash where his fire found them. Every time his rifle spat, the Core in his skull corrected for changed physics, compensating when local gravity stuttered, when the Void ate a chunk of magnetic field and light bent wrong.

Status: Ammo at 43%. Armor integrity nominal. Psychological stress extreme.

"Noted," he snarled, emptying a burst into something that looked like a crawling fracture.

The Lord kept coming.

It did not roar. It did not speak. Its presence was a *statement*: you are not real. You are not even particularly *interesting*.

He felt that apathy like frostbite on his skin.

“I see it,” someone whimpered on the squad channel. “Oh gods—I see its—”

Her voice cut off in a sharp, wet static as she moved wrong, looked wrong, let too much of herself fall into it. Her suit sagged inward, then puffed out in a blossom of noise as the Void chewed her into unpattern.

“Davi,” Salkin barked. “Focus. Left flank. Don’t—”

But the Lord’s *attention*—if it could be called that—had flicked.

Not to them.

Past them.

West, toward the trembling aether-spike that was the Gate Complex.

The Core whispered in his head, cold and precise.

Trajectory analysis: 98% confidence incursion entity vector intersects Gate facility in 170 seconds.

Gate.

Alexia.

The future of everything.

A rational man would have fallen back. Let the heavier guns do their work. Die in a neat, planned place.

Salkin had never been particularly rational.

“Rho vector,” he snarled, yanking hard at the leash in his own head. “Override. Full burn. We hold *here*.”

Negative, the Core began. Recommended strategic withdrawal to secondary—

“Override,” he roared, not aloud, but in that steel-lined corridor of his mind where only the Archive could hear him. “You listen to *me*.”

The thing that owned the sky did not even flinch when he emptied a whole mag into it. The shots vanished into its blur, eaten without ripple.

He didn't care.

He threw a grenade anyway, right at where the world blurred the most. It went off—not with light and sound, but with a flaring, shrieking *absence* as nanomancy and Void gnawed at each other for a heartbeat.

For that heartbeat, the Lord stalled.

Just a fraction. Just enough that its advance hiccuped.

Just enough to buy one more breath for the people running in the tunnels beneath the Gate facility, shoving power into circuits older than their grandparents’ grandparents’ wars.

“One more day,” he whispered. “Just one.”

He did stupid things then.

Running out in front of his own line, drawing fire—if it could be called fire—from the smaller anomalies, pouring everything he had into angles the Core spat at him: here, where the field is

slightly thinner; there, where the Lord's distortion scrapes closest to something like a target.

He knew, dimly, that this was exactly why they'd picked him for Gate guard duty later. Because he did not stop when fear told him to. Because he planted his boots in front of things larger than sense and bought time with his own shredded nerves.

Brave, Alexia had called it once.

Foolish, he'd always corrected.

Most days, he suspected they were the same word in different fonts.

He didn't remember how that battle ended. Only that eventually the sky lit with colors no eye was meant to see, as the real weapons arrived. That the Lord shrieked—not into their ears, but into the fabric of the world—and withdrew, leaving scorched geometry behind.

He remembered his hands shaking so hard he'd dropped his rifle. Remembered vomiting into a reclamation gutter while Davi clapped his back and told him dumb jokes about hazard pay.

He remembered the ache. Deep in his teeth. In his bones.

Fear, ground into the calcium.

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He came back to himself with his teeth still aching.

Hands on him—no armor, no suit connectors. Cloth under his cheek, not plasteel. The sound of water, but not broken pipes; the soft murmur of a fountain somewhere close.

His body jolted once, violent, torn between fight and flight.

A hand slid up his back. Warm. Steady. Fingers tracing the line of his spine as if counting vertebrae.

“Salkin,” Drabiretha’s voice said above him. Low, calm. “You’re here. Breathe.”

It was only then he realized his head was in her lap.

He was half-curled on the long couch in her council room, boots kicked off to one side, shirt rumpled. At some point—after the lesson? after too many hours tracing the lines of Empire law?—he must have slumped sideways. The dream had taken him there, of all places.

He tried to jerk away, mortified.

Her hand pressed gently between his shoulder blades, not pinning, just *there*.

“It is fine,” she said. “Nothing is going to hurt you here. I’m here.”

For one wild, shameful second he wanted to believe her like a child believes a promise.

Nothing is going to hurt you here.

Not the Void.

Not the Empire.

Not the weight of a dead universe expecting you to carry its memory alone.

Some small, traitorous part of him relaxed against her thighs, soaking in the warmth. The scent of her—ink, steel, something like pine sap—cut across the acid taste of remembered battlefield air.

He hated how good it felt.

Heart rate elevated, the Core murmured. Stress markers high but descending. External soothing input effective.

Shut up, he thought at it.

He felt her shift.

If he opened his eyes—even a crack—he knew he'd see her looking down at him. Horns shadowing her face, eyes soft in a way she never showed in council. He would see the line of her mouth as she spoke those words that settled like a blanket over the jagged edge of his fear.

I'm here.

A part of him—primitive and uncalculated—roared at that.

Mine, it wanted to say, with the same fierce, stupid devotion he'd once felt for the squad he'd thrown into fire with. For Alexia, when she'd shoved him through the Gate with I love you on her lips.

Undying loyalty was easy, he realized. You just pointed that part of yourself at someone and let it burn you hollow.

He owed her.

For the black shore and the broth and the nights sitting by his bed while he shook from nervous-system ghosts. For the garden and the rising moon and telling him the truth about collars when it would have been easier to lie.

Some deep, bone-level instinct catalogued all that and stamped her as *ours*.

He almost let it.

Almost let his hand curl into the fabric of her robe like something anchoring itself. Almost let the words sift up: I'll stand in front of

your monsters. I'll hold your line. One more day, one more day, one more day.

Then another part of him—colder, clearer—slammed the brakes.

You do not get to give yourself away, it said. You are all that remains.

Not of the squad. Not of a city.

Of a *reality*.

Alexia's archive humming in his cells. The Gate Project's last, desperate bet that some sliver of their work would make it into a world that could use it. The ghosts of a thousand dead worlds braided through his neurons.

You cannot afford undying loyalty, that voice warned. Not to a person. Not to a house. Not when every oath you make is a piece of your already frayed soul.

Legacy.

The word tasted like dry paper behind his tongue.

He *had* to think about it. About preserving knowledge, about finding a way to lay their history somewhere it could't be casually erased. About not letting the Void win twice—once by devouring his world, once by swallowing its memory.

He *had* to.

Later.

Right now, he was shaking in a Lunarch's lap, heart racing from a nightmare so old the world that birthed it was gone. His body had its own priorities: breathe, steady, rest.

Thoughts of legacy could come when his hands weren't trembling.

He curled them into fists against his chest instead of her robe.

“I saw it again,” he rasped, finally forcing his eyes open a slit.

The ceiling of the council room swam above him—dragons and moons in carved relief. Drabiretha’s face hovered in the lower part of his vision, upside down from this angle. Her expression was calm, but her eyes were sharp, taking in every twitch.

“The thing from the Gate?” she asked quietly. She still didn’t have a word for Void Lord. The closest her tongue had was something like *devouring prince*, and that tasted too romantic.

“Before the Gate,” he said. His voice shook. “A… test. It didn’t even…see us. We were…dust in its way. We held anyway.”

“Of course you did,” she murmured. “You’re very bad at knowing when to run.”

He let out a broken noise that might have been a laugh.

Her fingers brushed the back of his neck, cool against overheated skin.

“You are safe,” she said again, but more precise this time. “Here. Now. In this room. That thing is…two realities away and very, very dead if I have any say in the matter.”

He knew she couldn’t *know* that.

He let her say it anyway.

For now, survival was ambitious enough. Breathing. Learning. Not breaking in half under the weight of what he carried.

Legacy could wait until the next breath was secure.

He tucked all the dangerous thoughts—the urge to swear himself to her, to this house, to this new, brutal, beautiful world—into a corner of his mind and sat on the box.

Later, he told them. When I'm not waking up shaking. When I've built you something to stand on.

For now, he let his eyes close again and, just for a few more heartbeats, believed the words in his ear:

"It's fine," Drabiretha whispered. "Nothing is going to hurt you here. I'm here."

He would argue with her about the truth of that tomorrow.

Tonight, shivering and exhausted, he let it be enough.

Chapter Eleven — The Shape of a Life

He didn’t notice it becoming a life until it already was one.

Days blurred at first. Survival, lessons, sleep, nightmares, repeat. But somewhere in there, the blur picked up edges and rhythms and started answering to the name *routine*.

Morning: yard.

Captain Rhoena’s voice cutting across the sand. The clack of practice spears. The thud of bodies hitting the ground in ways that would bruise but not break. Salkin at first on the wall, then in the line, then moving up and down the ranks with a quiet, infuriating knack for spotting every lazy stance and overcommit.

“Again,” he’d say, tapping a heel. “Your weight is lying to you.”

They grumbled, and they listened, and he started to know them by the way they moved more than by their names.

Midday: books.

Moonhold’s private archive was not the Radiant Archive in the capital, but it was still more knowledge than most small cities saw in a year. Calunai Moonhold grumbled about “outsiders pawing at my shelves” and then kept quietly putting the *right* scrolls where his hands would fall.

He read like a starving man, chewing through legal codes, temple tracts, histories, collections of dragon-tales meant for children. The servants whispered about it. “I swear he doesn’t blink,” one swore in the kitchens. “Turned three pages while I was pouring tea.”

Afternoon: aether.

Sometimes alone in his room with a single candle and a bowl of water. Sometimes in the garden under Serayne Moonhold's wary eye. Sometimes with Drabiretha herself, speaking in metaphors about tides and roots while his Core sulked that it couldn't quantify poetry.

Drabiretha called the power a mage used mana: energy drawn from the soul, shaped by will to move the aether around it. Salkin reached the same underlying energies through nanomachinery and calculation. Magic and nanomancy could produce the same effect; the difference was how the energy was manipulated.

"Don't *grip* the Fire," she'd chide. "Invite it. Like a proud guest. If you grab it, it bites."

"Your metaphors are…deeply unsafe," he'd mutter, but the next time his fingers flared, the flame came cleaner.

Evening: lessons.

Law and custom and all the invisible knives. The written edicts of the Jade Dragon Empress, the clan-compacts that lay under them, the unwritten rules that sat under *those*. House-claim law. Breeding writs. Sanctuary rights. How far a Lunarch could bend imperial decree before someone called it heresy.

And, when he'd made enough progress in the strange art of coaxing elements through aether and steel both—forge. The lower hearth under the east tower became his second heartbeat. Heat, hammer, quench, listening to how this world's metals sang.

Each new blade was a journal entry.

The first held a steady hum of Earth and Lightning, crude but strong. The next, weeks later, carried a sharper, more balanced song, Fire folded in finer, Water-memory layered so the edge

would “remember” not to chip. He gave the old ones away as he outgrew them, a trail of discarded skins.

The first real one—Hybrid-Aetheric I, the Core labeled it with dry precision—he handed to Rhoena in the yard without ceremony.

“For you,” he said. “Or for whoever you think will not insult it.”

She tested the balance, eyebrows lifting.

“It still hums,” she said. “Like it wants to bite.”

“It wants to *survive*,” he corrected. “Give it to someone who does, too.”

She did. Within a week some lucky Moonhold sergeant was swinging a blade that made other guards go very quiet when it passed.

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The honor guard wasn’t his idea.

It just…happened.

It started with Hestra Moonhold and two of her spear-sisters, who had decided that the best way not to be humiliated in front of the Lunarch again was to keep training with the man who’d fixed their stances.

“Walk with you,” they said one afternoon when he left the yard, toweling sweat from his hair.

“Why?” he asked.

“So you don’t get lost in the stacks,” Hestra said promptly. “Archivist Calunai will skin us if you re-shelve anything wrong.”

That was transparently a lie—they all knew he navigated the archive like a bloodhound on a scent—but they flanked him anyway, two in front, one behind, spears upright.

The next day there were four.

By the end of the week, it had solidified into a pattern: whenever Salkin crossed the threshold of the sanctuary wing into the more public parts of Moonhold, there would *be* a little cluster of Moonhold uniforms orbiting him.

Mostly younger guards. A couple of wide-eyed apprentices from the Moonhold mage program, who had heard that the weird uncollared man would talk about aether in ways that made their heads hurt but their sigils suddenly work.

He tried, once, to tell them they didn't need to.

"I am not…a prince," he said, exasperated, as they fell into step around him on the way to the forge. "I don't need an escort to walk across a courtyard."

"Sanctuary policy," Warden Elenai said blandly when he complained. "All male guests are escorted outside the quiet wing." Her eyes were amused. "You just have a…louder escort."

The truth was more complicated.

Yes, it was policy. Crystal Moon took their "Moon-Guard escorts" seriously; escorts were trained in de-escalation and dignity as much as in how hard to hit someone trying to drag a man into a side alley.

But also: the young ones were curious.

He was not like the sheltered consorts they'd occasionally guarded in temple processions. He sparred. He swore. He took apart the

empire's laws with a surgeon's precision. He could light a candle with a thought and forge a blade that sang in your hand.

So the little honor guard coalesced—half protection detail, half study group.

They watched his back in the corridors.

He, in return, let them watch over his shoulder when he traced aether flows in the training yard dirt, trying to explain in halting Lunary how Air braided with Lightning along a spear's path, how letting Water ride in your hips made your stance harder to throw.

The mage-apprentices—most of them girls barely into their twenties, hair singed from early miscasts—sat cross-legged in the sand and scribbled notes furiously.

"Wait," one protested once. "So you *feel* the elements even without a focus-stone?"

"Yes," he said.

"How?"

"Badly," he admitted. "But I am learning. Sit. I will show you what *not* to do."

Their respect for him only grew.

So did their protectiveness.

The first time a visiting noblewoman from some minor Moonblood house cut across the yard while he was drilling, perfume and entitlement heavy in the air, the entire little cluster went stiff.

She was pretty in the way polished blades were pretty. Hair done in palace style, collar heavy with clan-jade. Her gaze slid over the guards, landed on Salkin like a hand.

“And this,” she said, all charming innocence, “must be the famous storm-gift I’ve heard so much about. Lunarch Drabiretha is very generous, letting such a treasure walk about with only—” her eyes flicked over the young soldiers “—*this* for company.”

Hestra’s grip tightened on her spear.

Salkin felt the air change—the way Fire-mode ticked up, Lightning prickling along spearheads.

He opened his mouth to answer something polite and ambiguous.

He didn’t get the chance.

“Sanctuary protocol, honored lady,” one of the apprentices said, voice cool as spring water. “Visitors are asked to address all questions to the Ward-Captain or the Lunarch regarding sanctuary residents.”

The noble’s brows arched. “I wasn’t aware I was in a sanctuary wing.”

“You’re not,” Salkin said mildly. “But I am.”

He didn’t raise his voice. He didn’t move. He didn’t *have* to.

Behind him, three spears shifted in perfect, unspoken unison. Not threatening—tips stayed down—but very visible.

The noble’s smile went brittle at the edges.

“Of course,” she said. “Crystal Moon is…eccentric with its hospitality. I meant no offense.”

Hestra gave her a polite look that translated, in any language that understood soldiers, to: *try it.*

The woman left with more stiffness in her shoulders than she’d come with.

When she was gone, Salkin turned slowly to his self-appointed guard.

“You know,” he said, “that if she complains, Rhoena will have to yell at you.”

“Then she’ll have to yell at us,” Hestra said, unrepentant. “Warden Elenai said you’re under Moonhold sanctuary. That means anyone not Moonhold or the mistress asking too many questions can fuck off.”

“That is not precisely how I phrased it,” Elenai said dryly from the balcony rail above them, “but I’m not correcting it.”

The apprentices giggled.

Salkin shook his head, something warm and bewildered settling under his ribs.

He had been guarded before. By squads and drones and orbital kill-sats. By walls of policy and non-disclosure clauses thicker than any castle stone.

He had never been…claimed like this.

Not as property.

As *ours*.

Ours to train with. Ours to learn from. Ours to glare at people for.

They fell in around him again when he left the yard, a little flock of Moonhold blue and silver moving through the estate’s halls.

He caught their reflections in a polished pillar: him, pale and uncollared in the middle; around him, young women with spears and ink-stained fingers, shoulders squared, eyes forward.

An honor guard.

Not one the Empress had decreed.

One the house had decided on its own to give.

The Core, ever eager to categorize, murmured:

Social pattern detected: protective cohort.

Function: local buffer between host and external claimants.

Recommendation: maintain.

For once, he didn't argue.

Let the Empire call him property on paper.

Here, in Moonhold's halls, under Drabiretha's crescent and the watchful eyes of guards barely old enough to remember a time before they'd had a strange, dangerous man to fuss over, he was something messier.

A responsibility.

A teacher.

A sword being slowly, carefully drawn.

And, if any stranger's gaze lingered on him too long in the corridors, he had half a dozen pairs of very sharp young eyes ready to cut it to shreds.

Chapter Twelve — Beyond Moonhold’s Walls

They smuggled him out like contraband.

Not through some secret tunnel or night gate—Drabiretha refused to treat him like a criminal—but with layers of quiet precautions all the same.

“Robe,” she said that morning in the council room, holding out a folded bundle of dark cloth. “Hood up outside the inner ring. No arguments.”

He took it, thumb running over the fabric.

“It’s…heavy,” he noted.

“Woven with ward-thread,” she said. “It will blur your features to casual eyes, make people’s gazes slide off your throat. We hide the fact you wear no collar, and I don’t have to choke any registrars before lunch.”

“Practical,” he murmured.

“You may wear your own clothes underneath,” she added, sounding faintly amused. “I am not making you a monk. Only…less conspicuous.”

He slipped it on.

The robe fell well, draping his shoulders without tangling his arms. The hood, when he drew it up, cast his face into shadow without blinding him. His fingers brushed the skin of his neck where, in this world, a band of metal should have sat.

“Conditions,” Drabiretha said, meeting his eyes. “You stay with Rhoena. You listen when she says ‘back’ or ‘inside’. You do not, under any circumstances, show a registrar your bare throat. Agreed?”

“Agreed,” he said.

“Good,” she said. “Go see my city, storm-gift. It will never leave you alone. You might as well know what it looks like when it’s happy.”

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Rhoena and his self-appointed honor guard were waiting in the inner courtyard.

He snorted when he saw them arranged at the gate like a small parade.

“I thought this was a tour,” he said. “Not a campaign.”

“Same difference,” Rhoena said cheerfully. She wore full captain’s harness: polished cuirass, short sword, spear. “Squad Sun-Three will be accompanying us. Half because you’re technically a high-value asset, half because the brats wouldn’t shut up until I let them.”

Hestra grinned at him, unabashed. “We drew lots,” she admitted. “You’re ours this week.”

“Lucky me,” he said dryly, but the corner of his mouth tugged up.

They moved out.

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Lunarys hit him like weather.

Smell first: salt and tar from the harbor, smoke from cook-stalls, incense from street-altars, sweat, spices, hot stone. Sound followed—a layered roar of voices, cart wheels, distant ship-bells, the occasional sharp bark of a hawker advertising fresh fish or charms or both.

Moonhold perched halfway up the city's slope, its white walls looking down over a cascade of roofs and streets spilling toward the sea. From its gate, the main avenue ran like a spine: wide enough for two wagons to pass, lined with carved pillars bearing clan-crests and dragon sigils.

Salkin had seen cities. Planet-spanning ones. Orbitals crammed with a billion people and more drones than air.

But this was… dense in a different way.

No hovering transit lines. No towering spires of glass. Just stone and wood and banners, all layered with aether-signatures so thick his newly trained senses buzzed.

"Keep your hood up," Rhoena murmured at his side as they joined the flow. "Hands visible, walk like you know where you're going. Anyone asks, you're a visiting scholar from Crystal Moon's upper library and you hate sunlight."

"That last part is not even a lie," he said.

The honor guard formed a loose shell around him as they moved. Not obvious. Not marching in step. Just…there. If someone jostled too close, a spear-butt or a well-placed elbow guided them gently away.

The city unfolded in districts.

Market streets where stalls crammed so tight he could barely see the cobbles: fruit in dazzling colors, bolts of cloth, clay charms painted with ward-marks, caged birds that made his skin crawl with strange aether. A spice-seller shoved a sample under his nose; the guard to his left stepped in so smoothly it looked like choreography.

“Not for him, honored aunt,” she said politely. “Priest’s orders. Very delicate stomach.”

“I have seen him eat Maera’s stew,” Salkin muttered. “That is a lie.”

“Sanctuary lies are allowed,” she said out of the corner of her mouth.

They passed a fountain square where children splashed each other under the stern gaze of a statue of the Jade Dragon Empress, her stone foot on a stylized serpent. Salkin watched as mothers tugged boys closer when the crowd thickened, straightening tiny collars.

His neck itched.

“What is that building?” he asked, nodding toward a multi-tiered structure shrouded in wind-bells and prayer-flags.

“Temple of the First Tide,” one of the mage-apprentices chirped. “Old as Lunarys. They say the dragons taught the first Moonhold how to weave harbor-wards from there.”

“And that one?” he pointed to a blockier complex with barred windows and a line of weary people out front, clutching scrolls.

“Registrar’s House,” Rhoena answered, tone sour. “Where disputes get filed and collars get recorded. We’re not going in there.”

He didn’t argue.

His eyes drank everything.

Street charms above doorways—little crescents of glass and bone, tuned to keep out misfortune and gossip. The way women automatically flowed around men in the street, forming bubbles of space without seeming to think about it. The hard, closed expressions on the faces of the few men he did glimpse, escorted by mothers or aunts or hired guards, collars gleaming like brand-marks.

The honor guard's shoulders tightened whenever another escort-guard glanced too long his way. He noticed the glares now: young Moonhold women staring back, faces bland, eyes sharp.

At a crossroads they watched a ring of street-performers: a girl barely fifteen weaving a simple Fire-and-Air trick, sending little spinning sparks chasing each other over the cobbles while her brothers beat a drum. Salkin watched the aether flows—noting how crude they were, how brute-force—and bit his tongue on reflexive corrections.

"You're making that face again," Hestra whispered.

"What face," he asked.

"The one you make when you want to fix someone's stance," she said. "But with aether this time."

He closed his mouth.

By the time the sun began leaning west, his head throbbed. Too much input. Too many smells, voices, signatures of power and pain and habit woven into every stone.

Still, when Rhoena suggested turning back, he hesitated.

"One more street," he said. "Down there."

She followed his gaze.

The lower harbor.

Narrower lanes, older stone, more clanless faces. Here, the walls were less white, more gray and grime. A giant chain ran down from a tower above, thick links anchored to a warded bollard that thrummed with Earth and Lightning. Beyond it, the sea heaved—dark, glittering, beautiful and indifferent.

Rhoena's jaw tightened. "Briefly," she allowed. "And stay close. The Rings have more eyes down here."

He had questions about that, about the shadow-gangs Elenai had only half-named in law-lesson, but he stored them away for later. For now, he watched the way dock-workers moved, the way fishwives kept a hand on their sons' collars, the way a man in plain clothes with a subtle jade-ring at his throat watched *him* until one of the honor guard deliberately stepped into his line of sight.

They didn't stay long.

By the time they trudged back up Moonhold's hill in the slanting gold of late afternoon, Salkin's feet hurt, his shoulders ached, and his brain buzzed.

"You're quiet," Rhoena noted as the gates of the estate swung closed behind them.

"I have a…hangover," he said. "From existence."

She barked a laugh. "Welcome to Lunarys."

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By dinner, he was bone-tired.

The hood and robe were gone, folded neatly in his room. He'd splashed water on his face, changed shirts, even let Maera bully him into eating a handful of nuts before the meal so he didn't "fall over like a fainting court poet" at the table.

Drabiretha and her inner circle were already seated when he entered the private hall. Lamps had been lit; the last light of day slipped in through the high windows, painting the dragons on the beams in soft fire.

"You lived," Drabiretha said as he took his seat opposite her. "Rhoena, congratulations. You did not lose him in a market or misplace him in a registrar's line."

"Came close, Lunarch," Rhoena said, pouring herself wine. "He kept walking toward every interesting disaster like a kitten toward open fire."

"I was *looking*," Salkin protested mildly.

"Exactly," Rhoena said.

They ate.

Only when plates were mostly emptied did Drabiretha lean forward, elbows on the table, chin on steepled fingers.

"Well?" she said. "What did you see?"

He thought for a moment.

"Noise," he said at last. "Color. Habit."

"Habit?" Elenai echoed.

"The way people…move," he said. "How they part around a man like water around a stone. How they ignore the registrar's door

until they have to go there, and then hate every step. The way every street has…eyes. Not all with uniforms."

"Rings," Elenai muttered. "Always."

"I saw your Empress," he added. "Stone version. On a serpent."

Drabiretha snorted. "They like her very much like that."

He met her eyes. "She scares them," he said. "But not as much as losing what they have."

Her gaze sharpened. "Explain."

"In my world," he said slowly, "we measured fear in what people *paid* to avoid it. The way women held their sons when the crowd thickened…that is fear. The way no one looked directly at my hood, even when they noticed something was…wrong…that is fear too. But they fear losing the *idea* of safety more than the law that provides it."

"You'd make a good registrar," Brynja said wryly. "If we didn't already like you."

He ignored that.

"Your collars…work," he said. "They broadcast ownership. But they also broadcast…target. I watched too many eyes…track them."

"Rings again," Elenai sighed.

"And your poor," he said. "Cling to them harder. Because the law is the only thing between them and…being disappeared without paperwork."

That made the table go quiet.

Drabiretha drank that in, as she did everything, eyes distant for a moment as she mapped his outsider's observations against a lifetime of insider's knowledge.

"And the rest?" she asked. "Not just law. The city."

He hesitated, searching for words.

"It is…" He almost said *alive* and then realized that word meant something different here. "Layered," he said instead. "Old things and new stacked on each other. Temples older than the Empress's dynasty and registrar-houses that smell of fresh ink. Children playing under statues that tell them who they are supposed to be before they can spell their own names."

"And the aether?" one of the mage-apprentices, invited tonight precisely for this, blurted. Then flushed. "Forgive me, Lunarch. But __"

"No, ask," Drabiretha said, amused. "I want to know too."

Salkin smiled faintly.

"It hums," he said. "Loud. In the harbor wards, in the temple towers, in that giant chain you have sunk into the sea. Lightning sleeping in the links, Earth anchoring it, Air sliding up and down with every tide. You are all standing on the edge of an engine you only half admit exists."

"That's reassuring," Brynja muttered.

"The Rings…pull at it," he went on. "Small, dirty tricks. Enough to nudge a ward-line so that a registrar's scribe gets a headache at just the right moment. Enough to make a boy stumble toward the wrong alley."

Elenai's mouth tightened. "We suspected. It's hard to *prove*."

“I cannot prove it either,” he said. “But I can feel where the field… scrapes. You told me you wanted an outsider’s eyes.”

“I did,” Drabiretha said. “And his teeth, apparently.”

He shrugged.

“Better my teeth in your council room than someone else’s in your streets,” he said.

A brief ripple of dark amusement went around the table.

“You look exhausted,” Maera said bluntly. “Did you enjoy any of it?”

He thought of the street-performers, the birds curling through Air-signatures like little living glyphs, the harbor chain humming under his boots. Of his honor guard’s excited voices, tripping over each other to tell him about *everything*.

“That market square with the fountain,” he said slowly. “The children. The smell of fried…things.”

“Squid,” one of the guards supplied.

“Squid,” he agreed gravely. “It was…good. Too much. But good.”

“And the registrar’s house?” Drabiretha asked quietly.

He met her eyes.

“Ugly,” he said. “Necessary, the way rot is necessary to show you where the wound is.”

She huffed a breath that might have been a laugh.

“You are hell on metaphors,” she said. “But useful.”

He sank back in his chair, feeling the weight of the day settle into his bones.

“This is…good,” Drabiretha said after a moment, more to herself than the room. “To hear what we look like to someone who did not grow up being told which banners mean comfort and which mean ‘walk faster’. It is…too easy to forget.”

“You asked for my view,” he said. “You may regret that later.”

“I regret very few things,” she said. “Inviting you to talk is not yet one of them.”

His honor guard, scattered along the wall benches with plates in their laps, traded tired, smug looks. They’d seen their city through his reactions, and now they were watching their Lunarch do the same.

Routine, he thought again, as the conversation drifted on to other topics.

Morning: yard.

Midday: books.

Afternoon: aether and steel.

Evening: law and dinner and the strange, brittle comfort of being asked what he saw.

It wasn’t a life he would have chosen.

It was, unmistakably, becoming his.

Chapter Thirteen — Fire in the Blood

Rhoena knew that look by now, and it never meant anything peaceful.

“Captain,” Salkin said, appearing in the training-yard doorway in his usual quiet way. “I need the yard.”

The last time he’d said that, she’d had to requisition twenty new dummies and listen to Master Ithan complain about splintered wood for an entire week.

Rhoena pinched the bridge of her nose. “Alone again?”

“Yes,” he said. “With supervision.”

“At least you learn,” she muttered. “What kind of test this time? I should warn the quartermaster.”

“No steel,” he said. “No blades. Just…me. And the elements.”

That was, somehow, *worse*.

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The yard emptied under her orders: no gawkers, no off-duty squads sneaking a look from the gallery. Hestra whined but went, dragging the other honor-guard with her.

Only Rhoena remained, leaning against the inner wall with arms folded, spear within reach. The sun was high, painting the sand in hard light and shadow. The shrine dragon in its nook stared down at them with stony amusement.

Salkin, barefoot as always, set up his circles.

Three rings of dummies again, but this time he spaced them farther apart. No armor. Just straw and wood and worn practice-wrappings. A pattern sketched on sand.

“You’re sure you don’t want a blade,” Rhoena asked, unable to help herself.

“No,” he said. “Today, I need to know…what I can be. Without help.”

“Reassuring,” she muttered.

He stepped into the center of the rings and closed his eyes.

From the wall, it looked first like any other focus-exercise she’d seen mages do: centered stance, slow breath, subtle straightening of the spine. But the aether around him…*shifted*.

Air curled tighter. Fire woke in little pricks under his skin. Lightning, which usually slept lazily in the sigils on the yard’s boundary stones, lifted its head and took interest.

“Core,” he said inwardly. “Combat profile, internal only. No weapons. Channel assist to limbs.”

Confirm: redirect augmentation from external tools to musculoskeletal system?

“Yes,” he thought. “Keep it…below self-damage threshold. I do not wish to…explode.”

Noted. Neural acceleration: 180%. Elemental-mode guidance: advisory.

He rolled his shoulders, let his awareness sink into his hands and feet.

Fire for impact.

Lightning for speed and shock.

Air for cutting edges, for slips and slides.

Earth for rooting.

Water for flow.

He began slow.

One step forward, weight landing with Earth-heavy certainty, and a straight punch at the nearest dummy's straw chest. As his fist moved, he guided a thread of Lightning-mode down his arm—just enough to blur the motion—and snapped a pinch of Fire into his knuckles at the last instant.

The impact cracked like a whip.

The dummy's torso caved inward, straw bursting out the back in a neat fountain. The post shuddered but held.

Rhoena flinched.

"That was a *slow* punch?" she called.

"Calibration," he answered, shaking out his hand. His skin wasn't even reddened. The elemental load had taken the strain instead of bone.

Next, a kick.

He flowed sideways, weight lightening along an Air-thread, and let that same Air lean into the arc of his leg. Not Fire, not blunt force—*wind*. Compressed, honed at the edge of his foot.

He spun.

The dummy's head didn't so much break as…shear. For a heartbeat it hovered, sliced clean off, before toppling. The cut through the dense straw was smooth as a sword's line.

"Wind," Rhoena muttered, half to herself, then winced as the beheaded dummy collapsed. "Well. That's new."

He let himself smile, just a little.

This felt almost familiar. Not the panic-soaked violence of the Void, but the clean, controlled brutality of training halls back home. Only now, the universe itself lent him knuckles.

He built from there.

Punch, step, pivot, kick.

Add Fire here, Lightning there, Air slicing under a heel. Earth in a stamp that sent a shudder through the packed sand, nearly toppling the entire inner ring. Water riding his hips so that even when he shifted abruptly, his balance never wavered.

The Core kept pace, murmuring in the back of his head:

Force output at 120% of baseline.

No microfractures detected.

Suggest reducing Fire-mode by 10% to limit collateral.

He obeyed, adjusting, trimming, refining.

From Rhoena's vantage, it was…a show.

He moved like he did in the sword-test—too fast to track properly when he chose—but this time there was light.

Every strike trailed color.

A punch drove home with a crackle of pale-blue Lightning and a brief, spiderweb glow along his arm. A sweeping kick left a visible ripple in the air, like heat-haze, that sliced straw and wood wherever it passed. When he hammered his heel down near the outer ring, a low ring of dust puffed outward, the shock traveling through the ground, knocking three dummies askew.

Fire flared once, twice—not as great gouts, but as sudden, concentrated flashes at point of contact. Straw blackened, smoked, caught and then guttered as he willed Water to quench it.

He was careful, even at his most lost-in-the-movement: every time a flame licked too eagerly, he cut it. Every time Lightning jumped toward a boundary stone, he yanked it back.

He was testing how far he could stretch without snapping anything important.

His own body. The yard. The fragile trust Drabiretha and Rhoena had placed in him.

“More Air in the knee,” he muttered once, half-laughing between strikes. “Less Fire. Better cut.”

“You are talking to yourself,” Rhoena called.

“I am talking to physics that refuses to behave,” he shot back.

“Welcome to my life,” she said.

He finished with a flurry.

A blur of motion through the inner ring, fists flickering, feet stomping, every movement carrying a thread of one element or another. To Rhoena’s eyes, it became a storm: crackles of blue, flashes of white-gold, little gusts of sand lifting around his ankles, dummies jolting and collapsing in sudden, precise ruin.

Then, as abruptly as he'd begun, he stopped.

One breath. Two.

The aether around him slowly settled, Fire subsiding, Lightning curling back into the runes on the yard's posts, Air smoothing.

He exhaled and dropped his hands to his sides.

The three circles of dummies lay in states ranging from "mildly abused" to "no longer structurally describable as dummies." None were as finely minced as when he'd used steel, but several had fist-shaped craters punched clean through them. Others were neatly decapitated, or split along invisible lines where wind had sliced.

The sand bore scars too: shallow craters, a faint ring where his Earth-stamp had traveled, glassy spots where Fire and Lightning had conspired a bit too enthusiastically.

Rhoena let out a low whistle and pushed off the wall.

"Colorful," she said, coming closer. "I'll give you that."

He rolled his shoulders, flexing his fingers, testing for pain. There was only a deep, clean ache—the good kind.

"Report," he murmured inwardly.

Elemental channeling into limbs: stable.

Optimal mix for blunt-force impact: 40% Fire, 30% Earth, 30% Lightning.

Optimal mix for cutting strikes: 60% Air, 20% Lightning, 20% Fire.

Risk of self-damage: low with current control.

He nodded to himself.

Rhoena circled one of the dummies, tracing a split with her fingertips.

“So,” she said. “To summarize for my report to the Lunarch: you can now hit like a hammer, slice like a sword, and stomp like a small earthquake. With your *hands*.”

“Yes,” he said. “If I focus. If I…cheat. Using what I know of aether.”

“Good,” she said briskly. “Because the next idiot who thinks he can drag you into an alley by your nonexistent collar is going to have a very educational experience.”

He huffed a laugh.

“I thought you wanted me to be *less* terrifying,” he said.

“Oh, I do,” she said. “For political purposes. For my own peace of mind. But if the choice is between you being terrifying on *our* terms or being taken by someone else who wants a weapon for themselves…” She gestured to the ruined dummies. “I’ll take this. Every time.”

She squinted at his hands.

“No burns.” She grabbed one wrist, turned it over, inspecting. “No cracked skin. That’s…something.”

“Water and Earth to bear the strain,” he said. “Lightning and Fire for…expression only.”

“You talk like a mage,” she muttered, releasing him.

“I talk like a man who refused to let his science die completely,” he said. “If I am to be a…weapon…here, I will at least be one I understand.”

She studied him for a heartbeat. Not the way Drabiretha did, all layers and implication—just a soldier looking at another soldier who had just shown her a new trick.

“It was…” she said, then stopped, searching for the word. “Beautiful. In a horrible way.”

He blinked, surprised.

“Thank you,” he said.

“And next time,” she added, “we’re inviting the apprentices. They’ll riot if they find out I watched you punch Lightning into straw and didn’t let them take notes.”

He groaned.

“They chatter,” he said. “Like…birds.”

“They adore you,” she said. “You are a puzzle and a promise and an excuse to skip boring lectures. Learn to live with it.”

He looked around at the yard, at the fallen dummies, at the faint lingering smell of ozone and scorched straw.

A week ago, he’d used the yard to learn what he could do with steel.

Today, he’d learned what he could do with nothing but his own hands and the cooperation of a very strange universe.

He was tired. Sore. A little proud. And, under it all, relieved.

Because now, if it came to it—if he found himself without blade or armor in a dark alley or a collapsing gate or Drabiretha’s council room with a Void-thing somehow coming through the floor—he wouldn’t be empty-handed.

He’d have Fire in his knuckles.

Wind on his heels.

Earth in his stance.

Lightning braided through his nerves.

And a captain on the wall, arms folded, very ready to shout *stop* if he went too far.

“Again tomorrow?” Rhoena asked, half-teasing.

“Not tomorrow,” he said. “Tomorrow I will…ache.”

She laughed. “Good. Means you did it right.”

She clapped him on the shoulder—carefully, from the front, always from the front—and jerked her chin at the wreckage.

“Now clean up your mess, storm-gift,” she said. “The honor guard needs something to complain about over dinner.”

Chapter Fourteen — The Elemental Blades

Drabiretha asked him like she asked for the weather to change.

Casual on the surface. Absolutely not.

It came at the end of a long evening lesson, scrolls still open on the table and his head buzzing with clan law and temple exemptions. The lamps were low, the garden outside nothing but dark shapes and a smear of moonlight on the glass.

“You’re restless,” she said, breaking off halfway through explaining how breeding writs were filed. “Worse than my youngest cousin when she was thirteen.”

“I am…processing,” he said.

“You are climbing the walls,” she corrected. “And starting to correct my metaphors. Which means it is time I give you work.”

He blinked. “I have work. Training. The forge. Your…laws.”

“Those are pastimes,” she said. “Useful ones, yes. But work,” and she leaned forward a fraction, eyes intent, “is something that leaves the house different when you are done with it.”

He frowned faintly. “What do you want me to…change?”

“Not *change*,” she said. “Grow.” A little smile. “You’ve already shown me what one man trained in your elemental close combat can do to my poor dummies. I want to see what thirteen can do to an enemy line.”

Understanding clicked into place by degrees.

“You want me to…teach,” he said slowly. “What I did in the yard.”

“Yes,” she said. “Formally. Not as little corrections here and there. Apprentices. A school, of sorts. Under Moonhold sanction.”

He sat back, surprised at the surge of…something warm in his chest.

“You trust me with that,” he said. It was not quite a question.

“I trust you more with *that*,” Drabiretha replied, “than with sitting idle until some other Lunarch hears the words ‘elemental close combat’ and decides to ‘invite’ you to teach their collar-halls instead.”

He winced. Fair.

“You choose them,” she added. “Thirteen. No more for now. People stubborn enough to learn a new way to move. Smart enough not to blow their own legs off. Willing to let you rearrange how they think about fists and aether both.”

“Why thirteen?” he asked, because the number tugged at something old and mathematical in him.

“Because thirteen is enough to be noticed,” she said. “And not enough to frighten the Empress’s auditors into thinking I’m building my own private army.” A flash of teeth. “Yet.”

He snorted.

It was, he realized as he walked back to his room later, the first time she’d asked him for anything *substantial*. Not advice, not observations. Not “don’t break my registers.” A *task*. A piece of the house she wanted him to put his hands on and shape.

He found he wanted to say yes with a ridiculous, almost childish eagerness.

“Of course,” he’d said, in the room, already. Out loud.

Now he had to make it real.

Finding them took work.

Moonhold was full of competent fighters. Rhoena made sure of that. It was also full of clever young mages with more theory than scar tissue. What Salkin needed was a mix of both—and a tolerance for being terrible at something, at least for a while.

He started in the yard.

“Not you,” he told seasoned sergeants with good lines and bad knees. “You are already…made. This is for those who have more… years left to be broken.”

“Reassuring,” Hestra muttered.

In the end, she was one of the first he picked.

“You already know how to move your feet wrong,” he told her. “That is a good place to start from.”

Hestra took it as the compliment it was.

He watched drill sessions with narrowed eyes, looking for certain tells: the guard who flowed rather than muscled through a block, the apprentice whose sigils never *quite* matched the textbook forms but somehow still worked, the spear-sister who automatically adjusted her spacing when a comrade faltered.

He ended up with ten soldiers, three mage-apprentices.

All women. Partly because that was the pool he had. Partly because the idea of men learning to hit this hard with lightning in their bones, in an empire already terrified of them, made his skin crawl in ways he wasn’t ready to unpack.

He gathered them one by one after drills or study hour.

“This will hurt,” he told them, blunt. “You will bruise in new places. You will think with muscles you didn’t know you had. If you cannot stand being…clumsy…for weeks, say no now.”

None of them said no.

They trained in the hour when the yard was mostly empty.

After the last whistles, when regular squads had trailed off toward baths and dinner, when the sun had dipped low enough that the stone no longer burned bare feet.

The first night, the thirteen of them stood in a rough half-circle, breathing hard from their own drills, sweat shining on their faces.

“First rule,” Salkin said, hands clasped behind his back. “You are not here to become weapons. You are already weapons. You are here to become *tools* that know exactly what they do.”

“Isn’t that the same thing?” one mage-apprentice—Tala, quick-tongued and quicker-minded—asked.

“No,” he said. “A weapon is something someone else points. A tool knows its own edge.”

They traded glances, weighing that.

“Second rule,” he went on. “You do not show this to anyone I have not talked to. Not your lovers. Not your mothers. Not your favorite drinking partner. This is not because it is ‘secret’—” he made a face “—but because if half-trained people start punching Fire into each other’s mouths in tavern brawls, the Lunarch will have both our hides.”

Hestra snorted. “Accurate.”

“Third,” he said. “You will fail. Repeatedly. You will think you understood and then find you did not. If you cannot laugh when you fall on your ass, leave now.”

Nobody moved.

“Good,” he said. “We begin with…feet.”

Groans.

He smiled.

“Always feet,” he said. “The Void does not care about your fists if your stance is bad. Neither does gravity.”

He started them on dry work.

Weeks of it.

Stance, pivot, guard. How to sink weight when bearing Earth-mode, how to lighten the hips when inviting Air. Simple drills: step-forward-punch, step-back-guard. No aether, not at first.

He made them shadow-fight each other without touching: mirror work, flowing around imagined strikes. Rhoena watched from the wall some evenings, nodding, occasionally shouting a correction of her own.

When they finally brought elements in, it was in droplets.

“Feel your fist,” he said, pacing behind them. “Not from outside. From bone. You have Fire already in your blood. You have Lightning in your nerves. You are not *adding* something. You are… pointing it.”

He had them strike the air until their shoulders burned, then had them do it softer, with a trickle of Fire-mode nudged into the knuckles at the last instant.

The first time Tala managed to snap a spark at exactly the point of an imaginary jaw and nowhere else, she yelped and shook out her hand.

“That tingled!”

“Good,” he said. “If it hurts, you used too much. If you feel nothing at all, it went somewhere you didn’t mean it to. Again.”

Kicks came later.

He taught them to slice with Air along the line of a shin, to stomp Earth down through a heel in a way that made the ground itself a weapon. Water they wove into transitions—rolling with impacts, flowing from one strike into the next instead of locking up.

Sparring…that took time.

“You are not here to impress me with how hard you can hit,” he reminded them the first time they squared off in pairs. “You are here to learn how not to break your own bones with your tricks when someone actually moves.”

Tala forgot and poured too much Lightning into her leg on the first exchange.

She kicked Hestra’s shield hard enough to leave a glowing streak and then sat right down, clutching her thigh, cursing inventively.

“Good,” Salkin said, once he was sure nothing was torn. “Now you know what ‘too much’ feels like. Memorize it. Do not visit it again unless you absolutely must.”

They improved.

Slowly.

Painfully.

Beautifully.

Rhoena took to watching every session she could, arms folded, head tilted. The first time one of the apprentices redirected a charging partner with an Earth-rooted stance and a precisely timed Air-slice, sending her sprawling without any real injury, Rhoena let out an undignified whoop from the wall.

“That,” she shouted, “is going in my personal playbook.”

The title started as a joke.

“You’re drilling us worse than the old spear-masters,” Hestra groused one evening, flopping onto the sand after Salkin called a halt. “At least they just hit you with a stick when you did it wrong. You make the *air* hit us.”

“Complain less, breathe more,” he said, tossing her a water-skin.

“Master of the elements,” Tala sang under her breath, grinning. “Storm-Fist. Lightning-Feet.”

“Do not start,” he warned.

“Grand Master of Getting Us Killed In New And Interesting Ways,” another guard offered.

That one stuck for exactly a day, until Rhoena heard it and threatened to make them run the hill in full armor.

“Show some respect,” she said. “If you have to call him something, call him Grand Master of the Elemental Blades and be done with it. It sounds proper enough to keep the priests from fainting.”

“Elemental blades?” Salkin repeated, amused. “We are not even using swords.”

“You are,” she said. “You are just wearing them on the inside.”

And so, by the next week, the story had leaked—because stories always did—and people started calling him that.

At first just among the thirteen.

“Grand Master, is this too much Fire for a liver shot?” Tala would ask with a completely straight face.

He’d groan. “If you must call me that, at least *aim* right.”

Then others picked it up.

“Rhoena, your elemental blades squad left scorch-marks on my practice posts,” one of the sergeants complained. “Tell your Grand Master to train them on the other side.”

She’d bristle, oddly proud.

Your Grand Master.

Yes. He was. Her problem and her brag.

Every time someone used the title in her hearing, she straightened a little, like someone had complimented her aim.

Salkin didn’t understand why it pleased her so much. To him, it sounded…grandiose. Silly, even. He’d seen Grand Masters in his world: hollow-eyed veterans who’d forgotten what peace felt like, men and women who could kill with a glance and woke up screaming anyway.

He did not want to be one of those.

But if it lit a fierce satisfaction in Rhoena’s eyes to hear her soldiers say *Grand Master* with a grin, if it made Drabiretha’s mouth curl at the edges in that quiet way of hers when a report crossed her desk mentioning “elemental blade drills”…he let it stand.

Names were cheap. What they built was not.

Drabiretha came to watch them, eventually.

Not in full Lunarch regalia. Just in a simple, well-cut robe, horns bare, eyes sharp.

The apprentices went railroad-straight when they saw her at the wall. Salkin did not call a halt. He merely nodded toward the next pair.

“Continue,” he said. “We are not a theater troupe. We are building muscles.”

They sparred in pairs and trios.

One-on-one: a blur of fists and feet, little flares of color at each contact point. Three-on-two: coordinated flows, one guard stomping Earth to unbalance an opponent while another slipped Air behind her ankles. A mage-apprentice ducking under a strike, palms flaring with harmless Lightning as she tagged a partner’s ribs exactly where Salkin had told her a liver *would* be on a real enemy.

No great explosions. No flashy displays meant to impress a Lunarch.

Just solid, increasingly precise work.

Drabiretha watched, arms folded, saying nothing for a long time.

After, when they’d bowed out and were stretching sore muscles in the cooling sand, she caught Salkin’s eye.

“You did this in…what, six weeks?” she asked.

“Longer,” he said. “We started slow. They are still…green.”

“A green squad that can kick through a shield-line and not break its own bones is no small thing,” she said. “The Empress’s personal guard drills elemental forms into their sword-work. We do not usually see that kind of discipline outside capital circles.”

He shrugged a shoulder, uncomfortable with praise.

“They had…good foundations,” he said. “I only…changed how they think about what their hands can ask the world to do.”

She smiled at that.

“That is not a small change,” she said. “You have given them a new language.”

He thought of Tala’s delighted shriek the first time she’d landed a clean Lightning punch without frying her own knuckles.

“Maybe,” he allowed.

Drabiretha watched the apprentices gather their things and limp toward the baths, half-supporting, half-shoving each other.

“This will cause me trouble,” she said, almost fondly.

“How?” he asked.

“Other Lunarchs will see it on the field,” she said. “They will want it. They will want you. I will have to politely decline until they stop asking politely.” Her eyes glittered. “It will be tedious.”

“I can…stop,” he said, though the words tasted wrong.

She shook her head.

“No,” she said. “No, Salkin. If trouble comes because my soldiers are harder to kill and better at killing the right people, that is trouble I will gladly pay for.” She inclined her head, just a little. “Well done. Grand Master.”

He grimaced at the title. She laughed softly.

“You dislike it,” she said. “Good. The only Grand Masters I trust are the ones who think the name is too big for them.”

He didn’t know what to say to that.

So he just bowed, slightly, old habits from dead academies surfacing.

“My Lunarch,” he said.

Her smile faded into something quieter.

My.

She let it pass.

As the yard emptied and the sky bruised toward evening, he stood in the center of the circles, feeling the faint echoes of Fire and Air and Lightning his students had left in the sand.

Thirteen people.

Thirteen new ways this world might defend itself against whatever came.

It wasn’t the grand legacy Alexia had dreamed of for the Gate Project. It wasn’t a rebuilt Archive or a restored reality.

But it was a start.

One stance at a time.

One fist that knew exactly how hard it could ask the elements to answer.

He’d fought Void-lords.

He’d stared down things that bent reality like wet paper.

None of that prepared him for Drabiretha stepping into the bath.

It was supposed to be recovery. That was all.

After too many days of drills, lessons, and him cheerfully abusing his own nervous system with experimental aether-channeling, Maera had planted her hands on her hips and informed both him and Drabiretha that if they didn't *rest* their bones, she'd drug them.

"There is hot water in this house for a reason," she'd said. "Use it."

So now he was in Moonhold's great bath—steam rising off a pool big enough to berth a small boat, pale stone underfoot, faint blue crystals glowing along the walls. The water was hot enough to make his muscles sigh.

He was alone. For the first blissful stretch, at least.

He'd sunk down to his shoulders near one of the sculpted dragon spouts, letting the cascade beat against his back. The aether in the water thrummed pleasantly: Water-mode soothing, a trickle of Earth easing deep aches, a thread of Fire just enough to keep warmth sinking into joints.

His internal diagnostics loved it.

Muscle tension decreasing. Microtears in fiber bundles knitting 12% faster than baseline. Cardiovascular load reduced.

"Good," he muttered. "Maybe we won't die of stairs tomorrow."

Footsteps echoed on the stone.

He turned his head—and froze.

Drabiretha crossed the edge of the pool with the unselfconscious ease of someone walking into her own bedroom. No robe. No jewelry. Just skin, horns, and steam.

For a second his visual cortex simply…stalled.

She moved with the same easy, grounded grace she had in armor or court-robes. Aelunari lines: long limbs, balanced strength, the faint gleam of old, silvery scars in a few places where something big had clearly tried and failed to break her.

He yanked his gaze up so fast his neck twinged.

The heat was suddenly *too much*.

His heart spiked. Breathing went shallow. Every bit of him that was still inconveniently human took one look and decided this was a crisis of a different, very stupid sort.

Elevated heart rate. Skin temperature rising. Adrenal profile suggests acute arousal—

“Override,” he snapped silently. “Dump it. Now.”

The nanites complained about wasted perfectly good endocrine responses, but obeyed.

A cool, synthetic calm slid under his skin, tamping down the worst of the physical reaction. His cheeks were still burning.

Drabiretha didn’t miss that.

She stepped into the pool with a small hiss of pleasure at the heat and sank down opposite him until the water slipped over her shoulders. The surface hid most of her, but his traitor brain had already filled in enough.

“Storm-gift?” she asked, amusement curling at the edges of her mouth. “You look…overheated.”

“I am…fine,” he said, voice about half an octave higher than usual. “The water is…warm.”

“Yes,” she said. “That is traditionally the point.”

She glided closer, more floating than walking, stopping at what was—to her—perfectly polite bath-distance.

To him it felt like being cornered by beauty itself.

He fixed his gaze somewhere safely neutral: the line of the far wall just above her horns.

“This is…new,” he said finally, because saying nothing at all felt more dangerous.

“What is?” she asked, genuinely curious.

“Bathing…like this,” he managed. “Together. With you. With… anyone who is not…lover or medic.”

“Ah.” Understanding dawned. Her eyes softened, but the smile stayed. “So your people are shy.”

“Modest,” he said stiffly. “We…have rules. One does not usually… present one’s self…unclothed to…political superiors.”

“Interesting,” she said thoughtfully. “Here we try not to do important politics fully dressed. It makes people lie more easily.”

He blinked.

She went on, calmer now, letting the teasing ease off when she saw just how red his ears still were.

“For my people,” she said, “shared bathing is custom. Family. Close friends. Lovers, yes, but also comrades and those we trust. Armor and silk hide too much. Scars lie when they’re covered.”

He risked a quick glance at her shoulder, where he’d seen old marks.

“Those,” she said, following his look without shame, “are from before I took Moonhold. A lesson in not trusting banners just because they shine. The woman who gave them to me is dead. The scars staying are…my way of not forgetting it.”

He swallowed.

“In that light,” she added, tone dry, “it would be rude *not* to show you mine, when you’ve shown me so many of yours.”

Heat that had nothing to do with embarrassment prickled behind his eyes.

“That is…not how my world would phrase that,” he said hoarsely.

“No?” she asked lightly. “How would yours?”

“Badly,” he said. “With…more paperwork.”

She laughed, low and genuine, the sound bouncing softly off stone.

“Breathe, Salkin,” she said, not unkind. “If I wished to seduce you, you would not be in doubt. I am merely washing. You happen to be in my bath.”

“That is…not…*comforting*,” he muttered.

Her smile widened. “You will adapt. Consider this another cultural lesson. Chapter…what are we on? Twenty?”

“Seventeen,” he said automatically.

She shook her head. “You count.”

“Someone has to,” he replied.

Steam curled between them. The worst edge of his fluster had faded, thanks in no small part to the forced calm his nanites had dumped into his system. He felt…raw, but steadier.

“You used your little machines on yourself,” she observed, too perceptive for his liking.

He stiffened. “I did not…intend…to disrespect your custom.”

“You didn’t,” she said. “If anything, I’m flattered you bothered not to embarrass us both.” Her gaze turned more assessing. “You forget, Salkin: I know you have…two layers of reaction to everything. The soldier, and the survivor. If one must be tamped down sometimes so the other can listen, I will not scold.”

He stared at the water, watching little eddies swirl around his hands.

“I have had lovers,” he said quietly, surprising himself. “Before the war. Before…Alexia shoved me through the gate. I am not…unused to bodies. But this is…” Words failed. He gestured awkwardly between them. “You are…”

“Dangerous?” she suggested.

“Intimidating,” he said. “And also…very much *you*.”

For a heartbeat, her expression slipped into something softer, almost startled. Then the smooth Lunarch-mask was back, only a little more open.

“For us,” she said, voice gentler now, “this is…trust. I do not invite many people into this room. Fewer still into this pool. Take it as such, if you can, and not as a…trap.”

He let out a breath he hadn’t realized he’d been holding.

“I do,” he said. “Trust. That is. Perhaps more than is…wise.”

“I did not ask for wisdom,” she said. “Only honesty.”

Silence settled, this time less sharp.

He shifted, letting the water soak into the last tightness in his shoulders. She leaned back against the carved stone lip, eyes drifting half-closed, horns just breaking the surface of the steam.

They didn’t talk for a while.

When he finally spoke again, his voice was almost normal.

“In my world,” he said, “we used to say that to bathe with someone is to let them see where you end and the world begins.”

“That’s not so different from ours,” she murmured. “We just add: if you cannot share water with a person, be wary of sharing war with them.”

He considered that.

“I have shared both with you now,” he said.

“Yes,” she said. “You have.”

He didn’t ask what that meant.

He didn’t have to.

His face still flushed every time he glanced even slightly her way, and he knew the nanites were working overtime to keep things from getting…noticeably awkward.

But under the embarrassment, under the very human reaction to a very beautiful, very naked woman sharing his bath, there was something else:

A sense of being…included. Folded a little further in. Trusted not just with swords and secrets and law, but with moments like this, where no one wore their usual armor.

For a man who had washed up on a black shore certain he would die alone, that was its own kind of terrifying.

And its own kind of grace.

Chapter Fifteen — The Things We Choose

It started to feel less like coincidence and more like a campaign.

Not a *bad* campaign, exactly. But definitely a coordinated one.

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The first time it happened, he wrote it off as timing.

He came back from the forge, arms and shoulders pleasantly wrecked from a long day of coaxing Lightning into steel. A servant met him in the hallway with a bow.

“The Lunarch is on the west balcony,” she said. “She asked for tea. Would you…like to join her?”

He almost said no—habit—but something in him craved open air and a voice that could untangle his thoughts, so he nodded.

The balcony was empty save for Drabiretha, the tea, and a plate of honeyed nuts.

“Ah,” she said, not surprised at all when he stepped out. “Maera didn’t *quite* shove you through the door, I hope?”

“I walked,” he said. “Mostly.”

They talked as the city went gold and then indigo. No one else appeared. No guard in the doorway. No servant with more tea. No one to interrupt when Drabiretha leaned back in her chair and said something sharp and kind about how the Registrar’s House was “a scab on the Empire’s nose.”

The second time, he started to suspect.

He was in the archive, midway through a treatise on pre-Empress clan law, when a junior scribe stuck her head around a shelf.

“Honored Salkin?” she said. “The Warden asks if you could bring that scroll to the inner garden when you’re done. The Lunarch wants to see the map you were looking at.”

He went. Of course he did. Drabiretha was there on a bench, alone, a pot of ink beside her, as if she’d been there for hours and absolutely had not arrived ninety seconds before he did.

By the fourth or fifth time—“Oh, strange, the *only* free table in the dining hall is next to the Lunarch,” “Oh, how fortunate, the bath is empty except for the two of you”—he started really paying attention.

Servants who were *terrible* at not looking smug. Rhoena suddenly needing Elenai’s opinion on patrol routes *right now*, leaving him and Drabiretha to finish discussing aether theory alone. Maera “just happening” to deliver tea for one and then adding a second cup when she saw him.

Whoever’s idea it had been, he wasn’t sure whether he wanted to kiss them or strangle them.

Possibly both, in that order.

The fact that Drabiretha now *knew* he saw her as a woman, not just as a Lunarch-shaped problem set, did not help.

She didn’t weaponize it. She didn’t flirt, exactly. But her awareness sat there between them like an extra place setting.

When she spoke to him in that low, measured tone that smoothed the edges off his anxiety, some traitorous part of him melted with

the same helpless gratitude he'd once felt toward combat medics in bad campaigns.

When she laughed, the curve of her throat did things to his self-control he tried very hard not to think about.

And her body—

He'd been trying very hard *not* to catalog it. But his brain had done it anyway: the way her hips moved when she walked, assured and solid, the weight of her breasts under cloth, the strength in her arms that said "I lift more than scrolls."

Matron, his hindbrain whispered approvingly, with the same tone it used for words like *safety* and *home*. Absolutely not helpful.

He clamped down on all of it. Stuffed the awareness into a box labeled *doom* and sat on the lid.

The household, apparently, had other plans.

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It came to a head at dinner.

A small one, this time. No junior officers. No scribes. Just Drabiretha, Elenai, Rhoena, Maera, Salkin, and a decanter of particularly good red wine Calunai had "won in an argument."

They were two cups in. The conversation had drifted from patrol routes to politics, to the latest outrageous thing another Lunarch had said in council.

"…and of course Vesperi of Jade Talon turned up with three new husbands," Rhoena was saying, tearing bread. "The youngest can't be more than nineteen. She presents them like prize stallions whenever she wants something passed."

“Three?” Maera made a face. “Doesn’t she have *five* already?”

“Six,” Elenai corrected, utterly deadpan. “She acquired another one over the solstice. Some poor idiot from Vermilion Standard who thought her banner was ‘romantic’.”

“Seven, technically,” Drabiretha murmured. “There’s the one she never publicly acknowledges, who lives in that tower by the south wall.”

“Oh *right*,” Maera said. “The one for when she secretly feels feelings.”

“That one,” Drabiretha agreed.

Salkin sipped his wine, listening with a mix of fascination and quiet horror. Harem politics in this world were…a lot.

It was Elenai who turned the conversation.

“Speaking of excessive collections,” the Warden drawled, “when are *you* going to start one, Drabiretha?”

Salkin inhaled at exactly the wrong time.

Wine went down the wrong pipe. He coughed violently, eyes watering.

Maera thumped his back with healer’s efficiency. “Breathe,” she ordered. “In, out. Try not to die, it will ruin the tablecloth.”

Across from him, Drabiretha raised one brow.

“Are you all right?” she asked, amusement flickering in her eyes.

“Yes,” he managed, voice hoarse. “Just…surprised by the…turn of topic.”

“Hm.” Elenai’s mouth curved. “Our Lunarch *is* an oddity. The only clan head in three provinces without so much as a single collared consort, much less a proper harem. One begins to wonder if she’s saving herself for a dragon.”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” Drabiretha said, completely unruffled. “Dragons make terrible husbands. They molt.”

Rhoena snorted wine up her nose.

“But truly,” Elenai persisted, wiping her own mouth with a napkin. “Every other Lunarch has at least one man on a leash to show off at festival gatherings. Some have three. Most have a ‘main’ consort to sign papers with. You have…books. And Salkin, I suppose,” she added, wickedly. “But he doesn’t have a collar, so he doesn’t count.”

Salkin wished very much for the floor to open and swallow him. Failing that, he contemplated voluntarily inducing a medical emergency to escape.

Drabiretha just kept eating, as if they were discussing grain tariffs.

“I don’t have a harem,” she said calmly, “because I am very bad at sharing.”

That made everyone pause.

“Sharing?” Maera echoed.

“My attention,” Drabiretha clarified. “My time. My temper. My trust.” She lifted her cup, tilting it slightly in Salkin’s vague direction without *quite* looking at him. “I have…enough troublesome living beings in this house as it is. Why would I add a circle of men whose legal personhood I’m responsible for on top of it?”

“You mean besides the obvious reasons?” Rhoena said, arch. “Political alliances? Bloodlines? Warm bodies?”

Drabiretha waved a hand.

“Political alliances I can make with treaties and clever charity,” she said. “Bloodlines are overrated; half the worst Lunarchs I know are ‘pure’ as winter snow. As for warm bodies…” She gave a small, feral smile. “Those are not as hard to find as people pretend. One does not need contracts for every pleasure.”

Salkin very carefully did not react to that.

“And the Empress?” Elenai asked. “She has never…pressed?”

“Oh, she’s hinted,” Drabiretha said. “Once or twice. ‘A Lunarch with a well-managed collar-circle is a stable Lunarch,’” she mimicked in a scarily accurate imperial drawl. “I told her politely that until the Empire stops treating men like walking ledgers, I have no interest in adding more lines to my books.”

Maera’s eyes softened. “She called you difficult, didn’t she?”

“Of course,” Drabiretha said serenely. “And then she sent me that aether-mirror fountain, so I know she wasn’t actually angry.”

Elenai leaned her chin on her hand.

“So it’s principles,” she said. “You don’t want to own what can be stolen.”

“That,” Drabiretha said. “And I know myself too well.” Her gaze flicked, just for an instant, to Salkin. “If I call someone ‘mine’, I am…not good at being sensible about it.”

Silence hummed under the crackle of lamps.

Salkin’s pulse jumped.

Heart rate increase, the Core noted.

Not now, he thought savagely.

Drabiretha went on as if she hadn't just dropped that small, heavy stone into the conversation.

"And besides," she added, tearing a piece of bread, "have you *seen* what happens to Lunarchs whose harems get political? Poisoning scandals. Secret child-swaps. Cousins feuding over which consort is 'senior.' I have enough headaches. I prefer my men either far away or extremely temporary."

"Good news for you then," Rhoena said dryly. "Most of them are terrified of you."

"As they should be," Drabiretha said.

Laughter rippled around the table.

The tension eased—mostly.

Salkin kept his eyes on his plate, ears hot, trying to breathe through the uncomfortable awareness that he was, by any rational measure, exactly the sort of person she'd just described: troublesome, uncollared, dangerous to own.

And yet.

The household kept "accidentally" leaving them alone.

Drabiretha kept inviting him closer in all the ways that mattered and none of the ones that would give a registrar a foothold.

Something in her mother-warmth made him feel safe in a way that had nothing to do with law and everything to do with the way her voice smoothed the spikes of his fear. Her hands had held his shaking shoulders after nightmares. Her lap had been a pillow

when the past broke through. She spoke to him as if he were an equal mind, not a fragile asset.

And, yes, those hips and breasts screamed *matron* in ways that his trauma-twisted instincts found dangerously compelling.

He drank his wine more carefully after that.

If Drabiretha noticed his lingering fluster, she was kind enough not to press.

Later, when the others had drifted away and they were left alone finishing the last of the tea, she didn't mention harems or collars. She asked instead what he thought of the new elemental drill pattern Tala had drawn up, and whether the forge needed more ore.

Work. Safety. Small steps.

Whoever in the household was quietly shoving them into each other's orbit could play their little games.

He would survive them, the same way he survived Void-Lords and imperial law and the weight of a dead world in his head:

One breath at a time.

Even if, occasionally, he almost drowned on his own damn wine.

They were in the council room again, but for once the table was clear.

No scrolls. No maps. Just a pot of tea between them and the low murmur of the garden fountain through the open shutters.

Outside, Lunarys was sliding toward evening. Inside, the light on Drabiretha's horns had gone soft.

“So,” she said, after a long silence that hadn’t felt awkward at all, “tell me about it.”

He blinked. “About…?”

“Your world,” she said. “Before the Void chewed it. You talk about the war. About the Gate. About the fall.” A small, almost shy roll of her wrist. “I would like to hear what you were…protecting.”

For a moment he just stared at his hands.

No one had asked him that before.

Not *really*. Rhoena wanted tactics. Elenai wanted threat assessments. The apprentices wanted stories about lightning guns and starships. Even Drabiretha, until now, had focused on the parts that touched her Empire.

“What do you…want to know?” he asked, buying time.

“Everything,” she said promptly. Then, with a wry little smile: “Or at least, the pieces you can bear to say out loud. Start with the shape of it. Your empire. How does a universe look when it belongs to one banner?”

He huffed a breath that might have been a laugh.

“Big,” he said. “Crowded. Loud. Terrible at sleeping.”

She poured him tea as if that were an ordinary answer.

“Go on,” she said.

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He talked.

At first haltingly, tripping over words that didn’t have Lunary equivalents, having to back up and sketch metaphors.

“We called it the Concord,” he said. “One government. Many… layers. It wasn’t always that way. We had wars that made your border skirmishes look like tavern brawls. But eventually…we burned out our taste for killing ourselves.”

“You’re sure?” she asked, arch.

“No,” he admitted. “But we got…better at hiding it.”

He told her about the scale first, because that was the easiest bit for his mouth to handle.

About an empire that spanned a whole *universe* by her reckoning: stars strung like lanterns along trade lanes, families who thought nothing of having cousins half a galaxy away. Worlds with three suns and worlds where the dawn was green. Station-cities that never saw sky at all, only metal and traffic lanes and the slow wheel of cold machinery.

He told her about the species.

How humanity was only one thread in a tapestry that included gas-breathers who lived in the upper layers of giant planets, crystalline beings who resonated with their own mathematics, water-dwellers who’d built entire cultures in the ice-caves of rogue worlds with no star.

“And you didn’t eat each other?” she asked, skeptical.

“Not after the Concord,” he said. “Before…yes. Often. We had…a talent for deciding someone was ‘less’ and proving it with slaughter. But we learned. Or we wrote enough laws and leashed ourselves enough that we mostly behaved.”

He talked about peace, because that was the thing the Void had shattered hardest.

About joint councils where representatives of fifteen biologies argued about trade routes and public health. About citizen-nets where someone on a forest-world could talk to someone in a station orbiting a black hole and complain about the same tax code.

“We got very good at…friction without war,” he said. “Endless talk. Endless compromise. Infuriating. Beautiful.”

Drabiretha listened, chin on her folded hands, eyes intent. Every now and then she asked questions that showed just how quickly she was mapping what he described onto her own world.

“How do you keep a gas-being from simply…refusing your law?”

“With difficulty.”

“What do your dragons look like?”

“We didn’t have dragons. Not…like yours.”

“What did you fear then, if not each other?”

“Ourselves,” he said. “Entropy. The heat-death of the universe. The day the stars go out. So we clung together and built.”

That led to science.

He spoke of it the way some people spoke of gods.

Not just nanomancy—the precise art of talking to matter with machines so small they might as well be aether. But the long climb that had led there: crude rocketry, clumsy orbital stations, the first tentative messages to alien minds, the painful, glorious realization that the universe was both bigger and friendlier than they’d ever guessed.

He described gate technology as best he could in a language that didn't have words for "brane" or "hyperdimensional curvature." He settled for:

"We learned to…fold. To poke holes between 'here' and 'there' so that travel became…stepping, not sailing. Carefully anchored. Carefully calculated. Very proud of ourselves."

"And arrogant," she murmured.

"Oh, extremely," he agreed. "We thought if we could write an equation for a thing, we understood it. We thought if we could measure a danger, we could control it. We were…children who had learned how to make fire hotter than suns and assumed that made us grown."

He admitted, because she would have smelled the lie otherwise, that being the Archive had shown him pieces of that history he'd never known while living in it.

How many times they'd almost torn themselves apart and stitched themselves back together. How many smaller empires had burned bright and cruel before the Concord, very like her Jade Empire: collars and ownership, safety and control tangled up.

"We had civilizations like yours," he said. "Clumsy. Powerful. Certain they were the center of everything. Some learned. Some died. Some…became chapters in other people's history textbooks."

"Comforting," she said dryly.

He went on anyway.

About art: symphonies made of star positions, murals painted on the inside of domes the size of mountains, poetry encoded into genetic lines as a joke that took centuries to pay off. About small,

stupid things he found himself missing the most: street vendors yelling about noodles at midnight, the hum of a train, the feeling of gravity changing underfoot when you stepped from one rotating habitat to another.

“Half of what I know now,” he said, “I only know because the Archive stuffed it into my head when I became its…carrier. I was a soldier. I thought I understood the Concord. Turns out I lived in a single hallway of a very large house.”

“And now you carry the blueprints for all of it,” she said softly.

“Yes,” he said. “There is…no one left to argue with me about it. It is…not as satisfying as you might think.”

He didn’t talk about the fall.

Not this time.

She knew enough about what the Void had done. Tonight, she wanted to see the thing *before* it broke.

By the time he ran out of words, the tea had gone lukewarm. The lamps were lit. The fountain outside had shifted to its softer, night-song pattern.

He sat back, throat rough, feeling hollowed out and oddly light.

Drabiretha was quiet for a long time.

Then she said, very calmly:

“You must think us very barbaric.”

He blinked.

“No,” he said at once. “Not barbaric.”

Her mouth twisted. “We collar men. We sell them. We knife each other over scraps of land and call it ‘honor.’ We treat dragons like…tools to be pointed at our enemies when we remember to be frightened of something bigger than our neighbor. Compared to what you describe—”

“Compared to what I describe,” he cut in, “you are…earlier.”

She fell silent.

He searched for words.

“In the Archive,” he said slowly, “I have seen a…pattern. Young civilizations. You dig yourselves out of the dirt. You build gods or empires or both to keep order. You hurt each other. You learn. Sometimes you don’t. Sometimes you do. My people were not… better. We were just…further along the curve. We made all your mistakes. We just had more time to…paper over them.”

Her eyes searched his face.

“Misguided,” he said at last. “Is the word I would choose. Not barbaric. Not uniquely monstrous. Just…pointed in directions that lead to pain you haven’t…quite learned from yet.”

She let out a breath that sounded like it had been sitting in her chest for years.

“Misguided,” she repeated. “That is…a kinder word than I expected from a man who has seen what you’ve seen.”

“I have seen worse than you,” he said simply. “In my own history. In others. Empires that ate worlds and called it ‘manifest destiny.’ Civilizations that harnessed black holes as weapons. You are…not that. You keep children from drowning. You feed your poor more often than not. You listen when a man in your lap shakes from bad

dreams instead of calling for a priestess to ‘fix’ him.” His mouth twitched. “I have seen better, yes. But I have also seen much, much worse.”

Her fingers tapped once, softly, on the table.

“I keep forgetting,” she said, voice much quieter now, “how much older than me you are.”

He blinked.

“I am not—” he began on reflex, then stopped.

Because she was right.

Not in years. His body was…what? Thirty-something, by his own world’s measures. Drabiretha was older than that, though Aelunari years didn’t map neatly to his.

But in *experience*…in raw, accumulated, utterly unusable experience…

He had lived one lifetime as a soldier in a late-stage interstellar empire. Then another, compressed, as a carrier of its entire recorded history, complete with other people’s memories and regrets. Then a jagged half-life as a refugee in a new reality with different rules.

“I feel like a new-born here,” he said slowly. “Your law, your customs, your…baths.” A faint, embarrassed cough. “I am always having to ask what is allowed. What will get me collared or killed or both. But…” He looked down at his hands—scarred in ways this world didn’t have stories for. “There is more…weight…behind my eyes than there should be.”

“That’s it,” she said softly. “Weight.”

He looked up.

“When I speak to the other Lunarchs,” she went on, “I know where their edges are. I know their blind corners, the places they have never had to look because the world bent around their rank. When I speak to you…” She tilted her head, studying him. “Sometimes you look at me the way my grandmother used to look at *her* grandmother. With…affection. And a kind of quiet frustration that we haven’t yet learned what you already have.”

He winced. “I try not to—”

“I didn’t say it was cruel,” she said. “Only true.”

Silence settled again, easier now.

He let the realization sit.

That in this world, by every visible measure, he was an infant: no legal standing, no clan, no collar, no place. Dependent on Drabiretha’s goodwill and Moonhold’s patience. Learning to walk again in a universe that ran on elements and aether instead of atoms and equations.

And at the same time…he carried in his skull the long, stumbling story of a species and its allies learning not to eat themselves. The rise and fall of thousands of cultures. The hard-earned lessons of empires that had broken themselves on the same rocks this one was sailing toward.

Older, then. In all the ways that did not translate neatly into respect at a registrar’s desk.

It was a disorienting double-exposure.

“I haven’t…thought about it,” he admitted. “It felt…indecent. To measure my…centuries…of other people’s mistakes…against your…decades…of your own.”

Drabiretha’s mouth curled.

“Decent is not a word I have ever been accused of,” she said. “Useful, sometimes. Difficult, often. Decent rarely.”

She sobered.

“If you are older,” she said, “then let me…borrow your hindsight. Sometimes. When mine fails. Tell me when I am about to repeat a mistake your people already bled for.”

He hesitated.

“That is…a lot of faith,” he said.

“It is also selfish,” she replied. “If I can avoid even one of Jade Talon’s more ridiculous catastrophes by heeding you when you say ‘we tried that, it burned,’ then your dead world buys my live one a little time.” She tipped her head. “You wanted your legacy. Here is one way to start it.”

The word hit him like a soft hammer.

Legacy.

He’d shoved that thought into a corner more than once, too overwhelmed by the day-to-day work of not breaking apart. Now she dragged it gently back into the light and set it on the table between them.

Not as a monument.

Not as some grand Archive-temple.

Just as…advice.

“I will try,” he said. His voice felt rusty. “I cannot promise I will be right. My world’s…solutions…may not fit yours. But when I see you reaching for a knife I know has two blades, I will say so.”

“Good,” she said simply.

She refilled his cup before he could protest.

“To misguidance,” she said, lifting her own. “May we at least be aware of it.”

He snorted, but clinked his cup to hers.

“Awareness,” he said. “Step one.”

They drank.

Outside, the moon was rising over Lunarys.

Inside, a man who felt brand-new and impossibly old at the same time sat with a woman who ruled a young empire, and together they tried, in fits and starts, to thread one world’s bruised wisdom into another’s unsteady future.

Chapter Sixteen — The Empress's Summons

The courier arrived like a knife in the middle of a calm meal.

Not loud. Not dramatic. Just…sharp.

The doors to the private hall slid open and a woman in green-and-gold stepped through, everything about her screaming *Palace* even before Salkin's Core tagged the new sigil on her collar.

Jade-scale pattern. The Empress's personal crest.

Everyone stood.

Even the servants froze, then bowed with the kind of precision you could only drill into someone with fear, respect, or both.

"Envoy of the Jade Throne," Drabiretha said, rising, voice smooth. "You honor Moonhold."

"Lunarch," the courier said. She bowed—not as deeply as the others, but deeper than etiquette technically required. "I bear the words of the Empress Zion, by her own seal."

A thin slate of jade rested in her hands, bound with a silver cord. Salkin watched Drabiretha's jaw tense just a fraction as she took it.

She broke the cord, thumbed the etched surface.

Her eyes flicked over the words once.

Salkin saw her shoulders drop by the width of a breath; not relief, exactly. Not surprise. More like the final slide of a blade into a sheath it had been hovering above for days.

"Read?" Elenai murmured from her place by the wall.

Drabiretha's mouth twisted.

"Later," she said. "For now: the short of it. Our Empress wishes to see me. Immediately." A pause. "And him."

Every eye in the room swung to Salkin.

His spine tried to lengthen and sink into the floor at the same time.

"Her exact words," Drabiretha added, glancing back down at the jade: "'Bring him to me as fast as possible. You have also neglected your duties as advisor; we require you by our side. Love, the Jade Empress Zion.'"

Rhoena made a strangled noise.

"Love?" she repeated.

"She writes like that," Drabiretha said, pinching the bridge of her nose. "Usually right before making my life difficult."

Salkin's stomach did an unpleasant little twist.

"Is this…bad?" he asked carefully.

"Yes," Rhoena said bluntly.

"No," Elenai said at the same time.

Maera just sighed. "It is *inevitable*," she said. "Which is its own flavor of bad."

Drabiretha looked at Salkin.

Her eyes were calm; her tail (which he'd learned was a tell more reliable than her voice) lashed once behind her and then went still.

"I expected this," she said. "Just…not quite this soon."

“Because of the reports?” he asked. “The…elemental blades. The city tour. My being…a walking insult to the registrar’s order.”

“All of that,” she said. “And because I have been gone from the court too long for her liking. She tolerates my reforms because I keep sending her stability. She starts to worry when my seat looks more interesting than hers.”

He swallowed.

“What does she…want…with me?” he asked.

Drabiretha spread her hands, claws glinting in the lamplight.

“Possibilities,” she said. “A new tool. A new pet. A new advisor. A new problem.” A tiny, humorless smile. “Possibly all four.”

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Preparation began that night.

There was no flurry, because Moonhold did not *flurry*. But from the moment Drabiretha handed the jade back to the courier with a serene, “Tell our Empress we leave within a fortnight,” the house shifted into travel-mode.

Lysara Moonhold doubled the pace of logistical murmuring in the halls. The Roadwarden’s staff started taking carts apart and putting them back together again. Guards rotated through drill with heavier packs. Tailors muttered over formal robes.

Salkin suddenly had much less free time.

Drabiretha pulled him into the council room with a stack of thin, tightly written sheets.

“Etiquette,” she said, slapping them down in front of him. “Read.”

He skimmed the first page.

“How to bow,” he read aloud. “Ten acceptable word-forms for addressing the Jade Empress. Topics to avoid in her presence. Appropriate levels of eye contact. Appropriate levels of *breathing*? Really?”

“That last one is…exaggerated,” Drabiretha said. “Mostly. But you should know that if you stare at her too long, the court will think you’re either possessed or plotting.”

He snorted, but his hands were faintly clammy as he picked up the top sheet.

Drabiretha watched him for a heartbeat, then softened.

“Salkin,” she said quietly. “Listen to me.”

He looked up.

“She is not a Void Lord,” Drabiretha said. “She will not unmake you for stepping wrong. She is…a dragon who has been playing at human for a very long time. She cares about stability, appearances, and not being bored. That is what you are walking into. Not war.”

He let out a breath.

“That is…reassuring and not, at the same time,” he said.

“Good,” she said drily. “You’re paying attention.”

They spent that afternoon and many after in a pattern: she would list a custom, he would poke holes in it, she would explain which ones mattered to Zion and which were just court-waste.

“Call her ‘Your Radiance’ or ‘Empress Zion’,” Drabiretha said. “Never ‘dragon’ unless you are trying to die interestingly.”

“Interesting death is not my goal,” he muttered.

“If she asks about your world, answer honestly,” Drabiretha went on. “If she asks if you think *her* world is inferior, talk about ‘differences’ and ‘other paths.’ Do not use the word ‘barbaric’ within earshot of anyone wearing jade.”

“What about misguided?” he asked.

A corner of her mouth twitched.

“That one you can use,” she said. “Carefully. She likes puzzles. If you make her think, she’ll tolerate more from you than from a typical petitioner.”

He filed that away.

“And most important,” she added, voice sharpening, “if any court official—not the Empress herself—tries to separate you from me under color of law, you do not argue with them. You look at me. You let *me* argue with them.”

“Because if I argue,” he said slowly, “I will argue with…fists. Eventually.”

“And Void-war logic,” she said. “Which is not how you survive a palace. Let them consider you dangerous. Let them think you’re strange. Let *me* remind them that you are, by law, an Empress’s trust delegated to Crystal Moon. If they want to tug that leash, they tug it in front of a dragon, not in some side corridor where people go missing.”

The image was uncomfortably easy to conjure.

He nodded.

“Understood,” he said.

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The question of who went with them turned into its own skirmish.

“At least two full escort teams,” Rhoena argued in council. “The main road is safe, yes, but safe roads attract idiots who think they can be the exception.”

“I am not marching an army through the capital,” Drabiretha said. “Zion will think I’ve come to overthrow her.”

“A squad, then,” Elenai said. “Plus the elemental apprentices.”

Drabiretha shook her head. “We can’t take them all.”

“Why not?” Rhoena demanded. “If someone tries to take him, I’d *like* them to discover they just grabbed a Lightning storm and twelve fists full of Fire.”

“Because I am not presenting a platoon of handpicked, uncollared, elemental-trained youths to a court that already thinks I’m too attached to reforms,” Drabiretha said tartly. “She asked for *him*. If I show up with a whole new type of soldier, she will quite reasonably conclude I’m building my own private army.”

Rhoena scowled.

“So we take none?” she said.

“We take half,” Drabiretha said. “Salkin’s choice. It shows I trust him to lead them. It demonstrates his…usefulness. And it leaves Moonhold with enough blades if things here go badly while I’m gone.”

Salkin, dragged into the debate, looked between them.

“They are not…weapons for you to wave under her nose,” he said. “They are…students.”

“Students,” Drabiretha agreed. “Who punch with Fire and slice with Air. Don’t be naive, Salkin. In a world like ours, students are always potential soldiers.”

He didn’t like it.

He also couldn’t quite argue with it.

In the end, he named six.

Hestra, because her instincts were sharp and she’d punch anyone who reached for his hood. Tala, because he needed someone who could talk aether-theory if the palace mages started prodding his methods. Four others who balanced discipline, loyalty, and enough sense not to mouth off to a High Crescent in a bad mood.

Telling the rest they were staying behind hurt more than he expected.

“We’ll keep the drills going,” one of the left-behind guards said, thumping her fist to her chest in the Moonhold salute. “You bring us back good stories.”

“Preferably ones that don’t end in ‘and then he was eaten by a dragon,’” another added.

He almost said *no promises*.

He didn’t.

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They left at dawn, two weeks after the jade slate arrived.

The household lined the inner courtyard, Moonhold blue and white and silver glinting in the early light. Drabiretha in travel leathers and half-armor, horns bound back, cloak clasped with the crescent of Crystal Moon. Rhoena in full captain’s kit, her second-

in-command rolling her eyes in the background and already planning how to keep things from falling apart in her absence.

Salkin wore the warded robe again, hood down for now, the fabric folded back from his bare neck. His chosen six stood around him like a fan of steel and nervous energy.

Drabiretha stepped to his side.

“You remember what we talked about?” she asked quietly, for him alone.

“Do not stare,” he recited. “Do not call the Empress a dragon. Do not let anyone separate me from you without making a scene visible enough that dragons get bored watching it.”

“And?”

“And if anyone tries to collar me,” he said, “I am allowed to hit them.”

“Only if I shout *now*,” she said.

He grimaced.

“I will…attempt to wait for your signal,” he amended.

She huffed a soft laugh.

“Good enough,” she said.

They mounted up: Drabiretha on a tall, horned mare; Rhoena and the other guards on leaner horses built for distance; Salkin on a sturdy gelding that tolerated his awkward seat with patient disdain. The pack-wagons creaked into motion behind them.

The city watched them go.

Lunarys woke around them as they descended toward the main road—vendors setting up stalls, temple bells chiming, the harbor already a blur of motion. News had a way of moving faster than hoofbeats; by the time they passed the registrar's house, Salkin could feel eyes on him, whispers curling like smoke.

"Is that him?"

"Moonhold's man."

"No collar…"

"Palace, they say."

Rhoena's riders closed in a fraction without being obvious about it.

The open road came as a relief.

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Travel was…duller than he'd feared and more exhausting than he'd expected.

The main imperial road was a broad ribbon of packed stone and aether-sigils, well-patrolled and lined with rest-stations bearing the Jade crest. Relay houses exchanged tired mounts and wagons for fresh ones, while aether-work laid into the road eased the strain of each long day. Even with the imperial network, the journey from the northeastern coast to Jade Crown, near the heart of the continent, would take close to two months.

They rode through coastal lowlands at first: flat fields, irrigation channels, clusters of houses around dragon-pillars. Women paused in their work to watch the little Moonhold column pass, some touching fingers to brow-chest-ground in a half-bow when they recognized Drabiretha's banner.

The first day passed without incident.

Salkin's thighs ached. His back ached. Muscles that had adapted to battlefield sprints and aether-drills protested this new, sustained, *civilized* form of torture.

"You fight Void-things and horses are your downfall," Tala muttered, massaging her own knees at the first night's camp.

"They are strange creatures," he said stiffly. "Too many legs. Too much…opinion."

She snorted.

Drabiretha watched them with amused eyes over the campfire.

On the second day, the land grew rockier. Hills shouldered up, the road winding between them. The air cooled, carrying the tang of pine.

They shared the road with caravans—some marked with other clan crests, some bearing temple sigils, a few flying no banner at all. Most kept a polite distance from Moonhold colors. A few stared too long at the hood draped around Salkin's shoulders, eyes narrowing as if trying to see through its subtle blur.

Rhoena quietly rotated riders to keep those wagons in her peripheral vision.

"Trouble?" he murmured once, when she edged her horse closer.

"Not yet," she said. "But I prefer not to be surprised. You're worth at least three wars if people start thinking with the wrong parts of their brains."

"That is…not comforting," he said.

"Welcome to politics," she replied.

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On the fourth evening, they reached the first major relay town.

Dawnfall, Drabiretha called it—a modest stone ring-town perched at the top of a long rise, where the road from Lunarys met the branch heading inland.

It was pretty in a rough, practical way: slate roofs, a central square with a dragon-pillar, a low-walled market, the ever-present smell of animals and hearthsmoke. Crystal Moon colors flew from the townhall, but fainter than in Lunarys, worn by weather and time.

“This is our last familiar bed for a long while,” Drabiretha told Salkin as they passed under the gate. “Dawn-Lady Nereth Moonblood runs it. She is loyal. Opinionated. Try not to frighten her too much.”

“How would I frighten her?” he asked.

“You exist,” Drabiretha said.

Fair.

The usual ritual played out at speed.

Gate-guards stiffening and then relaxing when they recognized Drabiretha’s crest. The local steward hurrying out, breathless, to bow and apologize for not being on hand: “We didn’t expect you until tomorrow, Lunarch; the courier—”

“Peace, Vessa,” Drabiretha said. “We shaved a day off. The road was kind.”

Rooms were found at the inn—Drabiretha, Salkin, and the senior officers in upper rooms; the guards in the common loft. Horses were seen to. The six apprentices buzzed with road-tired

excitement at the idea of seeing a new place, even if it was just another town.

Salkin was acutely aware of the stares.

Dawnfall women were less polished than Lunarys folk, more openly curious. His hood was up now, at Drabiretha's insistence, but even the warded fabric couldn't hide the fact that there was a man moving through the inn's public room flanked by six Moonhold guards who watched *everyone*.

"Storm-Dragon witness," a barmaid whispered as he passed. "Look how they hover."

"Hush," her companion hissed. "If he's palace-bound, you don't even *look* too long. That's how girls from nowhere end up dead in ditches."

He pretended not to hear.

At dinner, they took a private room.

Drabiretha seemed more relaxed here, closer to home turf but not under every eye.

"This is a good place to stretch legs and send letters," she said as stew and bread arrived. "We'll stay two nights. Brynja can check the road ahead, Elenai can ask about any…incidents we haven't heard of yet, and you—" she pointed a piece of bread at Salkin "—can breathe somewhere that does not smell like my council chamber."

He made a face at her, earning a small laugh from Tala.

Later, when the officers peeled away to do their respective duties, Salkin found himself restless.

The inn had a walled yard out back. Someone had set up a few battered practice posts there for caravan guards to work out their stiffness.

He drifted that way out of habit.

Hestra and two of the others followed without needing to be asked, spears in hand, their presence simultaneously escort and excuse.

A couple of local militia were already there, clacking wooden staves together in a lazy drill. They stopped when Moonhold colors entered, eyes widening at the sight of Salkin.

“What?” one of them muttered. “We don’t get to use the posts now the highlanders are here?”

“Use them,” Salkin said mildly. “We only watch.”

They blinked.

“Your accent,” one said. “Where in Jade’s name are you from?”

“A long way,” he said.

That, somehow, broke the tension.

Within ten minutes, he was correcting one woman’s stance (“Your left foot lies to you”) and explaining to a stunned town-guard how letting Air ride along a strike made it cut deeper even if the wood in your hand didn’t change.

Hestra watched with a smirk.

“Can’t help yourself, can you?” she said.

“They asked,” he protested.

“No, they *exist*,” she said. “That’s enough.”

Word spread faster than he'd thought possible.

By the time Drabiretha came looking for him, drawn by distant shouts and the unmistakable crackle of mis-aimed Lightning, half a dozen Dawnfall militia were watching with their mouths open as Tala demonstrated a basic elemental punch on a stuffed sack.

Salkin was just in the middle of yanking a bit of stray Fire back from an overeager recruit's fist.

"No, less," he said, catching the woman's hand gently. "You are not trying to *burn* her. You are trying to convince her bones that moving is a bad idea."

"Storms take me," the woman breathed. "You're saying I can *punch* with magic?"

"Yes," he said. "If you want to keep your fingers, you will punch carefully."

Drabiretha's shadow fell across the yard.

Salkin released the guard's hand and turned.

"Lunarch," he said.

She took in the scene with one long, sweeping glance—the battered posts, the wide-eyed locals, his six apprentices looking far too smug for their rank.

"Of course," she said.

"I was only—" he began.

"Showing them how not to break themselves with your tricks," she finished. "I know."

One of the Dawnfall militia bowed, more deeply than she probably needed to.

“Lunarch,” she said, awe and terror mixed. “If this is what your… Grand Master…teaches your own people…” Her eyes flicked to Salkin. “No wonder the Rings don’t step foot near your quarter.”

Grand Master.

Salkin suppressed a groan.

Drabiretha’s eyes warmed at the title, just for a heartbeat.

“Practice,” she told the Dawnfall woman. “Slowly. Or Maera will be making a very irritated house-call from Lunarys to put your bones back where they belong.”

“Yes, Lunarch,” the guard breathed.

On their way back inside, Drabiretha fell into step beside Salkin.

“You see?” she said quietly. “You don’t need a palace to change how people move. A halfway-town’s yard will do.”

He glanced back at the little cluster of militia, already trying to copy Tala’s stance.

“Small changes,” he said. “Sand in gears.”

“Sometimes sand chokes a machine better than a hammer,” she said.

He thought of the jade slate. Of Zion waiting, somewhere on the horizon, dragon eyes turned toward them.

“Do you think she will…approve?” he asked.

“Of you?” Drabiretha said. “She will be…intrigued. Annoyed. Amused. Hungry.” A pause. “Of what you represent…that depends on how well we walk the line.”

He nodded.

Dawnfall settled around them as night fell—lamps lighting in windows, distant temple chants rising from the dragon-pillar in the square. Tomorrow they would ride on, toward the capital, the palace, and a dragon who ruled an empire that didn't yet know what to do with a man who carried a dead universe behind his eyes.

For tonight, there was stew, a decent bed, and the knowledge that in at least one small stone yard, a few more people now knew how to ask the elements to answer their fists.

Chapter Seventeen — Before the Jade Throne

The road tried its best to bore him to death.

Endless stone, mile-markers, waystations that all smelled vaguely of boiled grain and old incense. The most exciting thing that happened in the first three weeks beyond Dawnfall was Tala nearly falling off her horse when a herd of goat-things decided the imperial road was a good napping spot.

The Core liked it—low threat, predictable patterns. Salkin's muscles did not.

But monotony had its uses. It gave Drabiretha time to drill court etiquette into him until even his nightmares bowed at the right angle.

"Your Radiance or Empress Zion," she repeated for the fifth time one evening, poking the campfire with a stick. "Not 'lady.' Not 'dragon.' And definitely not 'you' unless she tells you to."

"And I do not speak unless spoken to," he recited.

"You may answer questions," she said. "You may ask *carefully chosen* ones, if she's in a good mood. You may *not* tell her how to run her Empire in the first ten minutes."

"That was page four," he said. "After the section about breathing."

By the time the final relay stations fell behind them, almost two months had passed since they left Lunarys. The imperial roads had made a continent-spanning journey possible without changing the fact that it was a journey.

She smiled without humor. "I see you read."

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The capital did not ease him in.

One turn of the road and there it was: Jade Crown.

It rose out of the valley like someone had decided mountains were untidy and replaced them with architecture. Tier on tier of white stone and jade inlays, towers like spears, bridges arcing between them, waterfalls spilling from dragon-mouths into cisterns that fed glittering canals. Banners in a hundred clan colors snapped in the wind, dwarfed by the great jade-and-gold standard at the city's heart.

If Lunarys was a stronghold and Dawnfall a waystone, Jade Crown was a statement.

We are here. We are many. We are not going anywhere.

Salkin's aether-sense screamed.

Power ran under the city like veins: Earth in deep anchoring lines, Fire banked in massive furnaces, Water braided into aqueducts, Air humming along high bridges. In the very center, something else—something bigger—coiled and uncoiled slowly, like a dragon asleep.

"That will be her," Drabiretha said quietly as they paused at a rise and looked down. "Try not to stare."

He stared anyway.

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They did not linger in the streets.

Crimson-mantled imperial guards met them at the outer gate, banners of Crystal Moon and Jade Empress raised side by side, and the little Moonhold column was whisked into an organized blur: through wide boulevards, up sloping avenues, past tiered gardens and nested walls.

The palace loomed above everything else. Not a single building, but a complex sprawled across several hills, all sharp roofs and curling dragon carvings, encircled by a wall whose aether-signature made his teeth ache.

“Welcome to the Jade Palace,” Rhoena muttered under her breath. “Please mind the teeth.”

They dismounted in an inner courtyard paved with dragon-scale tiles. Servants in jade-and-cream swarmed: taking horses, directing guards, bowing so often Salkin’s neck hurt in sympathy.

“Lunarch Drabiretha of Crystal Moon,” an usher intoned. “Warden Elenai. Captain Rhoena. Delegation of Moonhold. And…” a pause, curious eyes flicking to Salkin “...the Empress’s summoned guest.”

Not even a title.

Good. Less to argue with.

The hood stayed up until the last moment, at Drabiretha’s insistence. Only when they reached the antechamber before the throne hall did she touch his arm.

“Now,” she murmured. “But keep your chin down for a count of five; let their eyes adjust to the fact you are not collared before they get clever ideas.”

He obeyed.

The hood fell back.

Murmurs rippled.

Uncollared. No sigil at his throat. Standing beside a Lunarch as something-not-quite-a-equal.

He kept his gaze on the polished floor, counting breaths.

“Remember,” Drabiretha said softly. “She is not a god. She is a woman with a dragon’s patience and a very sharp sense of humor.”

“Those are worse than gods,” he muttered.

The doors opened.

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The Jade Empress’s throne hall was built to impress dragons.

High, high ceiling painted with scenes of old wars and older treaties. Pillars carved into writhing dragon-shapes wrapped in chains of jade and silver. A long strip of polished stone down the center—the Dragon’s Spine—on which petitioners walked and bled and sometimes died.

At the far end, on a raised dais, sat the Throne.

It wasn’t a chair so much as a sculpture of coiled stone dragons, their tails and wings forming a seat, their heads reared high behind it. Between them, on a cushion of deep green, sat Zion.

To Salkin’s eyes at first glance, she looked…young.

Shorter than Drabiretha by a head. Skin the rich, dark color of wet earth. Hair like polished moss, a deep green that caught the light when she moved. Eyes that burned an unnatural shade of jade, slit-pupiled like a dragon’s. White fangs peeked when she smiled;

white claws tipped her fingers as they tapped lightly on the arm of the throne.

To everyone else: the Jade Dragon Empress. Divine, terrifying, beloved, feared.

To Salkin's other senses—

She was *noise*.

The aether around her was a storm in a box. Fire and Water and Earth and Air, all knotted together so tightly they might as well have been one thing, constantly shifting, surging, colliding. Lightning arced silently through the field like trapped stars. Threads of something deeper—Time? Raw Aether?—wove through it all, anchoring the chaos into a shape that could sit on a throne and wear a face.

It was dangerous. It was wrong. It was *power*.

And it was beautiful.

The thought came and left his mouth before any etiquette drill could stop it.

"You are beautiful," he said.

The hall froze.

Sound died. Even the distant scrape of a scribe's quill seemed to cut off mid-stroke.

Beside him, Drabiretha went very, very still.

Salkin's brain caught up a heartbeat too late.

He had just told the living embodiment of imperial law, in the middle of her own throne hall, that she was beautiful. Like some idiot court-poet in a bad play.

He opened his mouth to stammer out an apology or an explanation—*I mean in an elemental sense, Your Radiance, your aether-field is exquisitely chaotic*—but Zion beat him to it.

She laughed.

Not a polite court titter. A *laugh*. Sharp and delighted and utterly unbothered.

The sound rolled down the hall like a stone kicked into still water. Tension cracked.

“Finally,” she said, when she got her breath back, eyes sparkling. “Someone with functioning senses.”

She leaned forward, elbows on the throne’s carved dragon tails, chin on her hands, studying him.

“You see it, then,” she went on. “Not the child-suit. The *rest*.”

He swallowed.

“Yes, Your Radiance,” he said, wrestling his tongue into the right shape. “To my…senses, you are…elemental chaos. Coiled. Dangerous. Very…loud.” A helpless twitch of his mouth. “And beautiful.”

Her grin widened, showing more fang.

“Good,” she said. “I was beginning to think this world had gone completely nose-blind.”

Drabiretha exhaled very softly through her nose. Salkin wasn’t sure if it was relief or impending migraine.

“Approach,” Zion said. “Both of you.”

They walked the Dragon's Spine together—Drabiretha a pace ahead, as rank demanded; Salkin matching her step as closely as he could without tripping.

At the foot of the dais, Drabiretha dropped to one knee, fist to chest in the Imperial salute.

"Your Radiance," she said. "Crystal Moon answers."

Salkin bowed as practiced: from the waist, not too deep, hands at his sides, eyes respectfully down but not *closed*.

"Your Radiance," he echoed.

"Rise, sister," Zion said to Drabiretha, waving one clawed hand. "If I make you kneel every time you visit, you'll start thinking you're back in your grandmother's court."

Drabiretha stood, a flicker of warmth crossing her face at the word *sister*.

To Salkin, Zion said:

"So this is the man my Lunarch has been hiding." Her head tilted. "You are less shiny than I imagined."

"Apologies for the disappointment," he said before his filter could wake up.

A ripple of scandalized amusement went through the watching court.

Zion laughed *again*.

"Oh, I like you," she said. "Drabri, you bring me the best trouble."

Drabiretha sighed, the sound long-suffering. "You summoned him, Your Radiance," she reminded her. "I merely prevented ten other Lunarchs from getting their hands on him first."

“Exactly,” Zion said. “Which is why I am not currently yelling at you for ignoring my last three letters.”

“My duties in Lunarys—” Drabiretha began.

“—were being handled very ably by your captains and wardens,” Zion cut in. “Do not try that line on me; I remember when you were too shy to look me in the eye and now you think you can dodge my summons.”

Drabiretha’s tail flicked once, then stilled.

“Yes, Your Radiance,” she said, no heat. This was an old argument, worn into its grooves.

Zion turned her attention back to Salkin.

“Traveler,” she said. “From far away. With too many ghosts in your bones. Do you know why I dragged you away from your nice, safe Moonhold?”

“Because you are curious,” he said honestly. “And because I am… untidy. On your ledgers.”

The corner of her mouth kicked up.

“Very,” she agreed. “An uncollared man. A new style of soldier. A Lunarch who writes to me about ‘ethical reforms regarding men’s personhood’ and then *keeps* you like a lost storm.” Her eyes flashed to Drabiretha. “And you thought I would not notice.”

Drabiretha did not flinch.

“I thought,” she said evenly, “that if anyone were to decide his fate, it should be you, not some registrar with more ink than sense.”

Zion snorted. “Flattery will get you some of the way. Sense gets you the rest.”

She straightened a little on the throne, the air around her tightening.

“Very well,” she said. “Let it be spoken plainly, so even the scribes in the back can’t pretend they didn’t hear: I, Zion Jade-Heart, Empress of the Jade Empire and Voice of the Dragon Throne, claim Salkin—” her gaze pinned him like a spear “—as my *advisor*.”

The hall rustled.

Advisor.

Not consort. Not property. Not subject.

An imperial advisor sat very close to power. And very, very close to danger.

Zion went on, voice carrying with lazy precision.

“Traveler from far away, who has seen too much.” A faint shrug. “I have claws and armies and priests and Lunarchs with very sharp tongues. What I do not have is someone who can lean on my map-table and say, ‘We tried that in another universe, it ended poorly.’ For that, I require you.”

His throat felt dry.

“Your Radiance,” he managed, “I am…one man. Much of what I know may not fit this world.”

“Excellent,” she said. “The last thing I need is more people who think exactly like mine. Boring.” Her eyes narrowed. “You will not lie to me. You will not flatter me. Drabri does enough of that for three.” Drabiretha made a strangled noise that might have been a cough. “You will tell me when I am about to walk into a fire I cannot see. And sometimes—only sometimes—you will help me light ones that need to be lit.”

He looked at Drabiretha.

She met his gaze steadily, face unreadable, but there was something in her eyes—a flicker of *this is your choice*.

He turned back to Zion.

“I will…try, Your Radiance,” he said. “On the condition that if I say ‘this is a knife with two blades,’ you at least *consider* not grabbing it with both hands.”

Someone in the back choked.

Zion’s grin was slow and sharp.

“Drabri,” she said, “he talks to me like you do.”

“I warned you,” Drabiretha said under her breath.

“Good,” Zion said. “I am tired of being told I am always right. It’s dull.”

She flicked her fingers in a dismissive little wave, the storm around her settling a fraction.

“Enough formalities,” she said. “You’ve been on the road; you smell like it. Go. Baths, food, sleep. I will have you all at my table for dinner, when you are less likely to fall over on my floor.”

She leaned back in her throne, already half-turning to murmur something to a waiting chamberlain.

“Drabiretha,” she added, voice idling back to fond. “Welcome home, sister.”

Drabiretha bowed again, this time with less stiffness.

“Your Radiance,” she said. It sounded, just for a heartbeat, like *Zion*.

“Traveler,” Zion said, eyes flicking to Salkin one last time. “Welcome to my den.”

“Your Radiance,” he said again, because anything else would have been suicide.

The usher snapped his staff once.

“Crystal Moon will be escorted to their quarters,” he intoned. “Audience concluded.”

As they walked backward the prescribed number of steps before turning, Salkin’s legs felt oddly distant. His brain was still echoing with the taste of Zion’s elemental field: wild, terrifying, intoxicating.

Next to him, Drabiretha exhaled very slowly once they were past the great doors.

“That,” she said under her breath, “went better than it could have.”

“Better?” he said weakly. “She just…claimed me.”

“As an *advisor*,” Drabiretha said. “Not a pet. Not a weapon to be lent to Jade Talon. You are as safe as anyone ever is in that room.”

“Which is not very,” he muttered.

“No,” she agreed. “But it is…interesting. And you like interesting more than you admit.”

He didn’t argue.

The palace servants led them through a maze of corridors to a guest wing: airy rooms overlooking an inner garden, screens painted with dragons and moons. His six apprentices were shown to a smaller suite nearby, eyes wide at the gilt and the view.

Salkin's room had a bed softer than anything he'd slept on since his own universe died, a writing desk, and a balcony that looked out over a sea of jade roofs.

He stood there for a long moment, hands on the railing, trying to steady the mix of awe, fear, and something perilously like *possibility* churning in his chest.

Behind him, Drabiretha's voice came from the door.

"Rest," she said. "Wash. Try not to jump off anything. We'll survive dinner, and then…" A small, crooked smile. "Then we see what kind of game our Empress truly wants to play."

He nodded, still looking at the city that wasn't his and the sky that no longer belonged to his dead stars.

"Traveler from far away who has seen too much," he murmured.

"Grand Master. Advisor. Nuisance," Drabiretha added.

He huffed a breath that might have been a laugh.

"Add 'very tired' to the list," he said.

"Done," she replied. "I'll have Maera write it into the records."

Then she left him to the quiet, with the weight of a new title settling on his shoulders and the knowledge that, for better or worse, he now stood not just at Moonhold's table—but at the side of a dragon Empress who thought he was interesting.

Dinner suddenly felt like the least dangerous part of his day.

Chapter Eighteen — Dinner with a Dragon

Dinner with a dragon was never going to be simple.

It was, however, spectacular.

The Jade Palace's private dining hall wasn't the cavernous banquet chamber they'd passed earlier, but it was still big enough to swallow Moonhold's entire great hall twice over. Carved pillars, painted ceilings, silk screens with dragons and stars. A long table of dark wood, flanked by high-backed chairs.

Salkin had expected—based on Drabiretha's very thorough lectures—that Zion would sit at the head with Lunarchs and high officials in strict order of precedence…and that her harem, if present at all, would be behind screens or at a lower table. Seen, not heard. Beautiful furniture.

He was wrong.

The Empress sat near the center of the long edge, throne traded for a high, comfortable chair with dragonwork arms. To her right, the place of honor, was for Drabiretha. To her left, a space had been left conspicuously empty.

Further down, on both sides, were the courtiers who mattered.

And opposite Zion, mirroring her seat, another row of chairs was occupied by…them.

The harem.

To other eyes they might have seemed merely pretty: a line of men in fine silk and jade, collars gleaming, some with delicate jewelry at wrists and throat, a couple of women among them like bright

accents. Ages ranged from youthful to comfortably mature. They were beautiful in very different ways: one with scholar's grace, another with fighter's shoulders, one with a softness that spoke of temple upbringing.

But to Salkin's senses, one thing leapt out and would not be ignored.

Magic.

Almost every man at that table carried a concentrated knot of aether in his bones. Some flickered with Fire, others hummed with Earth or Air, a few braided all five elements in fine threads. Their signatures were messy, untrained by his standards—but undeniably there.

Mages. Nearly all of them.

And they were seated at the Empress's own table, not hidden, not arranged as decoration, but positioned where every eye in the room had to reckon with them.

Strange, he thought. For this world. For its rules about men.

"Come," Zion said, when Salkin hesitated on the threshold. "Sit. It is hard to talk to people who insist on orbiting me like anxious comets."

Drabiretha's hand brushed his elbow, nudging him toward a seat two down from Zion, on the same side as Drabiretha. Rhoena and Elenai took places further along. His six apprentices were at a side table with senior palace guards—close enough to see, far enough not to be overwhelmed.

Servants flowed in with dishes: fish glazed in something fragrant, spiced roots, delicate dumplings, rice, fruit. Wine that smelled far too expensive.

For a few minutes, formalities took over. Cups were poured, toasts made, the first bites taken with the required compliments to the kitchen. Salkin watched, listened, tried not to drown.

It was only after the second course that Zion leaned back and clapped her hands lightly.

“Enough,” she said. “We have eaten like polite strangers. It’s dull.” She gestured toward the line of men opposite. “Salkin, traveler-who-sees-too-much, meet my scandal.”

Several of the harem winced affectionately at the term.

“This,” Zion went on, nodding to the man directly across from Salkin, “is Lareth. He calls lightning better than half my court mages when he feels like showing off. That is Sen,” a nod to a broad-shouldered man with ink-stained fingers, “who writes my ward-schemes so the palace doesn’t explode when priests get ambitious. Hara,” a small smile for a woman with close-cropped hair and a scar down one cheek, “has been known to punch assassins, priests and Lunarchs when they annoy me. The rest will introduce themselves at their leisure.”

Eyes met his across the table. Curious. Assessing. A few wary, a few frankly fascinated.

According to everything Drabiretha had told him, this was a strange setup.

Harems in the Empire were political devices, pleasure-gardens, breeding pools. Consorts were displayed at festivals, paraded in temple processions, tucked away in luxurious cages.

They were not…this.

Not sitting at the Empress's side like a council.

One of the younger men—dark hair, air-focused aether humming around him—caught Salkin's gaze and, very slightly, winked.

Salkin's mouth twitched.

Zion watched the exchange with sharp amusement.

"You are wondering," she said, "why I put them here, instead of behind a lattice like good, obedient ornaments."

"Yes, Your Radiance," he said. "Among…other things."

A few courtiers stiffened at his bluntness. Zion ignored them.

She picked up her cup, turned it between her fingers, green eyes thoughtful.

"In theory," she said, "an Empress's harem is for three things: alliances, heirs, and keeping certain kinds of trouble where you can *see* it."

Soft laughter rustled along the table.

"In practice," she continued, "I realized about eighty years ago that if I let the clans keep all the male mages in their own houses, they would use them as little walking ledgers of power. Breed-chips. Collateral."

Her gaze slid along the line of men, something almost like protectiveness in it.

"So I changed the rules," she said. "Quietly. Slowly. I began to 'invite' promising male casters to serve *me* instead of their clans." A flash of fang. "It is difficult for a Lunarch to say no when the

Empress herself writes and says ‘I would like to admire your nephew’s talent up close.’”

Lareth ducked his head to hide a smile.

“Almost all of them,” Zion said, “were like you, once—caught between being weapons and property. Here, under my eyes, they are still useful. Very useful. To me, to the palace wards, to the stability of the Throne. But,” and her voice softened, “no one can sell them quietly in a back room. No one can ‘marry’ them off against their will without my claws on the contract.”

“And the collars?” Salkin asked, glancing along the table. Zion touched the jade seal at Lareth’s throat. “Safe passage,” she said. “My seal means they can go beyond the palace freely, even into lands where an unaccompanied man would be seized. Any magistrate can see whose protection they carry.”

Salkin felt something in his chest ease and tighten at the same time.

“Protection,” he said softly.

“And power,” she replied frankly. “Do not mistake this for pure charity, traveler. Their presence at my table reminds every clan head that I can call rain on their fields and lightning on their mansions without asking nicely. But yes.” A small shrug. “It began because I was…angry. And tired. At watching boys with too much fire behind their eyes get passed around like heirloom jewelry.”

Her gaze went distant for a heartbeat.

“You must think me very sentimental, for a dragon,” she murmured.

“No,” he said. “I think you are…practical. In a direction I approve of.”

That earned him another quick flash of teeth.

One of the consorts, the scarred woman Hara, spoke up then.

“He thinks we’re strange,” she said, amused, her voice low and rough. “He’s right. We’re not a harem. We’re a lightning rod.”

“Speak for yourself,” someone further down protested. “I am *very* decorative.”

Laughter rippled down the line.

Zion let it ride for a moment, then, without warning, cut it off with a tiny lift of her hand.

It wasn’t harsh. Just…final.

The room quieted.

“As for the other function of a harem,” she went on more quietly, “the one the poets like to whisper about…”

She trailed off, gaze flicking toward a carved panel of dragons entwined.

“I have not had someone to warm my bed in almost sixty years,” she said.

The admission dropped into the room like a stone.

Courtiers looked studiously at their plates. One of the younger harem-men shifted, expression aching for a heartbeat.

“The last of my heart-consorts,” Zion said, “died of old age. In that bed.” Her fingers tightened on her cup. “I liked him very much. I

did not like watching him break. Since then, I have preferred my nights quiet. Whatever the clans may gossip."

She let out a breath, something fragile and dangerous under the words.

"Now that I have satisfied your curiosity before you could work up the courage to ask," she added briskly, tone snapping back to something sharper, "we may move on."

Salkin's throat felt tight.

He hadn't planned to ask. He hadn't *wanted* to know that particular contour of her loneliness.

Now that he did, it was very hard not to see the great Jade Empress not just as a roiling storm of aether and political power—but as a woman who had chosen sixty years of cold sheets rather than risk seeing someone else she cared about erode under time while she did not.

He opened his mouth, closed it.

What could he say? *I understand*? He didn't. His lovers had died in war and Void, not in beds of age. *I'm sorry*? She would bat that away as pity.

So he stayed quiet.

Zion seemed to approve.

"Now," she said, putting her cup down with a soft click. Her eyes found his again, bright and intent. "Tell me everything. And be truthful."

The room held its breath.

Drabiretha's hand, under the table, brushed his knee—a tiny, grounding touch.

"You did not specify a topic, Your Radiance," Salkin said, buying a heartbeat.

"Start with what you are," she said. "Not what the registrars think. The *truth*. Then your world. Then what came out of the dark and ate it. Then why I should not kill you for being a hole in the Empress's nice, tidy law-ledgers."

Her smile took the sting out of the last sentence. Mostly.

He inhaled.

Nanites hummed in the back of his skull, ready to buffer his speech, smooth his heart-rate, file his words. He nudged them aside.

Truth, she'd said.

"All right," he said softly. "Truth, then."

He began with the Archive.

Not all the details—that would have turned dinner into a days-long lecture—but enough.

How he had been a soldier first. Human, baseline, one among many in an interstellar Concord. How, when the Void's incursions began, his people had panicked and done something desperate: poured the collected knowledge of their civilizations into adaptive substrates. Living Archives. How he had volunteered—or been volunteered; the line blurred with time—to become one of those carriers.

“I am,” he said, choosing each word like a step on thin ice, “an interface. Between dead data and living brain. Between ghost-memories and now. The ‘AI’ you have heard Drabiretha mention is not a god in my head. It is…a tool. A machine-mind. Very clever. Very limited, in its own way. It whispers statistics. Corrections. Warnings.”

He tapped his temple lightly.

“It is not my master,” he added. “But it is also not entirely under my command. We are…old comrades chained together.”

Zion’s eyes narrowed, intrigued.

“You could, in theory,” she said, “teach someone here to build more of these.”

“In theory,” he said carefully. “In practice, there are…ethical cliffs…you have not even named yet. My people paid dearly for those lessons. I will not hand your Empire the knives we cut our own throats with.”

A ripple ran around the table. Someone at the far end muttered, “He said that to her face—”

Zion lifted a hand.

“He is not wrong,” she said. “Go on.”

He spoke of his universe as it had been before the Void—sketching the Concord in broader strokes than he had with Drabiretha, but hitting the same points: the scale, the cooperative species, the long, messy march away from eating each other.

He did not linger there too long. It wasn’t the story she’d asked for.

He told them about the first anomalies. About worlds going quiet. About physics bending in ways that made scientists wake up sweating. About the first time they realized something from *outside* their reality had found a way in and liked the taste.

He described a Void Lord carefully, trying not to let his voice shake.

“A presence,” he said. “Not a shape. An…assertion. It arrives and the world begins to…unravel. Probability malfunctions. Distance means nothing. It does not hate you. It does not even *see* you, at first. You are collateral in its attempt to overwrite the rules of where it stands.”

He spoke of the battle that had given him the nightmares Drabiretha had already held him through. Of standing in front of something that did not notice him and throwing himself at it anyway, to buy a few more seconds.

He moved on quickly.

“Gate Project,” he said. “Last gamble. We thought, if we can’t win, perhaps we can…send something through. Knowledge. People. Seeds. A way out.”

He glanced, without meaning to, at one of the harem-men whose aether smelled like open portals.

“We had built Gates before,” he said. “Between points in *our* reality. This was…different. An attempt to step *sideways*. Into another bubble, if you like.” He smiled wryly at Drabiretha. “Your Lunarch will tell you I talk about reality as spheres. It is not just metaphor.”

He told them about Alexia, in outline. About the lab. About the last stand at the Gate. Of her shoving him through with an I love you and a smile and detonating a world behind him.

He did not dwell on that either.

“And then,” he said. “Black shore. Your sea. Your Lunarch.”

Silence held the table.

Zion had not interrupted once. Even the courtiers who usually could not bear to shut up for more than a minute were caught in the gravity of it.

Salkin took a sip of wine because his throat suddenly hurt.

“You want the truth,” he said quietly. “That is it. I am not a god. I am not a demon. I am a man with more ghosts in his head than any human is meant to carry, from a universe that is no longer standing. I am dangerous because I know how to ask your aether to behave in new ways. I am *more* dangerous because I know how very quickly a world can die.”

He met Zion’s eyes.

“And if you kill me,” he said, not as a challenge, just a fact, “you remove a variable. You also erase the last coherent copy of certain kinds of knowledge in existence. That may be a good trade, from your view. Or not.”

The words fell between them like a coin.

Drabiretha’s knuckles were white where her hand gripped her cup.

One of the harem-men—Sen, the ward-scribe—was staring at Salkin as if his entire worldview had just been set on fire.

Zion sat very still.

The storm around her had tightened, gone inward. To Salkin's senses, she was less a bonfire and more a neutron star now: dense, contained, unguessable.

Then, slowly, she let out a breath.

"I did ask," she said. "Didn't I."

"You did, Your Radiance," he said.

"And you answered," she went on. "Without flattering me. Without making yourself bigger or smaller than you are."

She drummed clawed fingers once on the arm of her chair.

"Drabri," she said, not looking away from Salkin, "you were right. Again. It is very annoying."

"I live to irritate you, Your Radiance," Drabiretha murmured, voice a shade rough.

Zion's mouth twitched.

"To the matter at hand," she said. "I will not kill you tonight, Salkin-of-the-Dead-Concord."

A faint, strained laugh rippled around the table.

"Nor tomorrow," she added. "Possibly later, if you do something truly stupid. But for now…" She lifted her cup in a small, precise gesture.

"You will sit at my left," she said. "You will watch. You will listen. You will lean over my map-table and say 'this burned us once.' And you will, gods help us all, occasionally tell me when I am being an idiot."

Her eyes flashed.

“And in exchange,” she said, “I will make sure no registrar, no clan, no dragon, no idiot with too much jade and not enough sense puts a collar on you or drags you off this Throne’s ground without my permission. Do we understand one another?”

He swallowed.

“Yes, Your Radiance,” he said. “We do.”

“Good,” she said. “Eat. Talk to my lightning rods. Try not to teach them anything that will bring the palace down in the next week.”

The tension shattered, just a little. Conversation resumed in low, buzzing strands. Rhoena finally breathed again. Tala was already half out of her chair, eyes locked on the palace mages like a predator who’d just seen new prey—in a friendly way.

Drabiretha leaned in, very slightly, her shoulder almost but not quite touching his.

“You did well,” she said under her breath.

“I told the truth,” he murmured back.

“In a room,” she said, “where that is the rarest magic of all.”

Across from him, Lareth lifted his cup with a crooked grin.

“To travelers who have seen too much,” the consort said.

Salkin lifted his own.

“To dragons,” he replied, glancing briefly at Zion, “who are willing to listen to them anyway.”

Zion’s laugh rang like a bell.

For the first time since he'd stepped into the palace, Salkin let himself believe that this might be survivable.

Not safe.

Never safe.

But survivable.

And, just maybe, the start of the kind of legacy Alexia would have approved of: not monuments or temples, but conversations at a dragon's table, where one dead universe whispered its hard-earned lessons into the ear of one that still had a chance.

Chapter Nineteen — A Dragon's Apology

Drabiretha was in the middle of a sentence about Crescent politics when the door simply…opened.

No knock. No herald. Just the soft whisper of silk and the faint chime of jade bangles.

All three of them turned.

Zion stepped into the room as if it belonged to her—which, technically, it did.

She wore only a white robe.

Calling it a robe was generous. The fabric was fine enough that the lamplight slid through it, turning it half to mist, hinting at the lines of her body more than it hid them. It clung in places it had no business clinging. For a heartbeat, Salkin's brain threw up a dozen warning flags at once.

He jerked his gaze up to her face so hard his neck twinged.

"Your Radiance," Drabiretha said, instantly on her feet, bow halfway started.

Zion flicked two fingers; the gesture was lazy, but the air snapped with it.

"Sit, Drabri," she said. "If you hit the floor every time I open a door I'll have to redecorate the palace with cushions."

Drabiretha froze mid-bow, then straightened, eyes sharp and wary now. Salkin could feel her weighing the room in an instant: no

obvious guards, no scribes, no audience. Just them and a dragon in something that barely counted as clothing.

“Should I—” Drabiretha began.

“Yes,” Zion said. “Leave.”

The word was gentle. It was still a command.

For half a heartbeat, the Lunarch of Crystal Moon looked like she might argue. Then her jaw tightened; she bowed—properly this time—and put a hand on Salkin’s shoulder as she passed.

“I will be nearby,” she murmured in his ear.

He nodded, unable to trust his voice.

The door closed behind her with a soft *click*.

Zion looked around the room once, taking in the chairs, the low table, the balcony. Her eyes lingered on the scattered notes Drabiretha had left on the desk, then came back to Salkin.

He realized, belatedly, that he was still standing, hands at his sides like a soldier waiting for orders.

“Sit,” she said.

He found himself obeying before he’d consciously decided to. One of the low sofas near the center of the room took him; the cushions were softer than they had any right to be.

He opened his mouth—Your Radiance, this is highly irregular, Your Radiance, is this safe, Your Radiance, you are very undressed—but nothing sensible came out.

Zion crossed the space between them in four unhurried steps.

Up close, the robe was even worse.

It was barely there at all where it crossed her shoulders, loose enough at the chest that the fabric shifted with every breath, more suggestion than covering. The scent of her hit him—ozone and cold stone and something green, like crushed leaves after rain.

Every rational part of his mind screamed at him to back up.

The rest of him stayed very, very still.

She reached him. Before he could decide whether to stand again or slide sideways along the couch, she turned, gathered the robe under her with one hand, and sat down.

On his lap.

Not next to him.

On. His. Lap.

His body went rigid on pure reflex, every muscle from his jaw to his toes locking.

The robe pooled across his thighs like spilled moonlight. She weighed less than he expected—dense with power, yes, but physically light, almost delicate. One of her hands came to rest lightly on his shoulder to steady herself.

From this distance, her jade-fire eyes were all he could see. That, and the sharp white flash of fangs when she smiled faintly at his expression.

“I could say,” she murmured, “that I came because I enjoyed hearing you call me beautiful.” A small tilt of her head. “I *did* enjoy it, you know.”

His heart was trying to beat its way out through his ribs.

Elevated heart rate. Pupil dilation. Hormonal—

Override, he snapped inwardly. *Now. Soft dump. Don't knock me out, just…calm.*

A wash of cool moved through his veins as the nanites obligingly blunted the worst of the reaction. His breath, which had been edging toward a pant, settled a fraction. His face was still hot enough to fry eggs on.

"I—Your Radiance, this is—" He flailed for a word that wasn't *a lot*.

"Improper?" she suggested, amused. "Scandalous? Politically unwise?"

"All of the above," he muttered.

She laughed softly and, to his immense relief, shifted just enough that her weight rested more on his knees and less…anywhere else. The robe still did absolutely nothing it should, but at least he could think again.

"I wish," she said, and the humor leaked out of her voice, "that I was only here for my vanity."

Her hand tightened very slightly on his shoulder.

"I am not."

He swallowed.

"If you wish me to leave—" he started, because some corner of him still clung desperately to protocols.

"If I wished you to leave, you would not be under me," she said dryly. "Be still, traveler. This is talking, not seduction. I am not nearly drunk enough for seduction."

"That is a…horrifying metric," he said before he could stop himself.

She huffed a real laugh at that, then sobered.

“I came,” she said quietly, “because I owe you an apology.”

That…was not one of the things he’d prepared for.

“Your Radiance,” he began, caught off-balance, “if this is about tonight’s dinner, I assure you—”

“It is not about dinner,” she said. “It is about…dragons.”

He blinked.

That was not better.

She studied his face for a heartbeat, then looked past him, as if through the wall, through the palace, through this entire reality.

“Every reality,” Zion said softly, “has a dragon at its root.”

Her voice had changed. Less Empress, more…something older.

“A guardian,” she went on. “A spine. Call it what you like. Your Lunarch’s pretty myths about thirteen great beasts circling the First Dawn are not *entirely* wrong, just…crude. Where there is a bubble of real, there is a dragon woven through its bones.”

Salkin’s skin prickled.

“In *this* world,” she said, “that dragon wears my name, my face, my teeth. I am not the first. I will not be the last. The dragon is older than the girl. But we are…braided, for now.” Barely-there humor. “Convenient, for thrones and priests.”

His mouth was dry.

“In *your* world,” Zion said, eyes coming back to his, “there was a dragon once.”

“Once,” he repeated, throat tight.

“There had to be,” she said simply. “Or the bubble would never have formed at all.”

He thought of stars and gates and neat equations. Of how sure his people had been that the universe ran on numbers alone.

“We never knew it,” he whispered. “We had no…stories. No shrines. No scales in our temples.”

“You had other words,” Zion said. “‘Fundamental constants.’ ‘Vacuum stability.’ ‘Baseline reality.’ Mathematics is only another way of naming the bones of the dragon. But it was there. Wound through your cosmos. Sleeping, perhaps. Or awake in a way you never learned to see.”

She lifted her free hand, fingers curling, as if she held a very small, very precious sphere between them.

“Something killed it,” she said. “Or broke it. Or bound it. I do not know. I only know this: the Void does not eat whole realities easily. It gnaws at the edges. It tests. It whispers. A living dragon bites back.”

Her gaze searched his face.

“Yours did not,” she said quietly. “Or could not. For that, Salkin, traveler-who-saw-it-fall, I am…sorry.”

He hadn’t realized, until that moment, how deeply he’d buried the question.

Why didn’t *something* stop it.

Not in the narrow, human sense—why didn’t the Concord’s admirals do more, why didn’t the Archive see it coming sooner. Deeper. A child’s question in an adult skull.

Why didn't the universe itself say no.

"Maybe," he said, fighting past the lump in his throat, "we killed it ourselves. With equations. With arrogance. With…gate-projects that poked holes somewhere we shouldn't have."

"Maybe," she allowed. "Dragons are not infallible. Some make bad bargains. Some sleep when they ought to wake. Some…grow tired." A shadow crossed her face, gone almost before he could see it. "But whatever the cause, you paid the price. You and yours. That is not a thing I can fix. But I can say: it should not have happened. Not like that. And I am sorry it did."

He stared at her.

At the girl-woman-dragon sitting in his lap in a robe that made a mockery of modesty, apologizing for cosmic dereliction of duty.

"Why," he asked hoarsely, "do you *care*? You did not know us. We are…gone. Ash under a Void's teeth."

"I care," she said, "because I carry a dragon, and I have spent a very long time making sure *my* people never see what you saw. Because your story is a warning I would be a fool to ignore. Because…" She frowned, as if annoyed at herself. "Because I saw your face when you talked about your dead stars at dinner. And because every now and then, it is good for even an Empress to remember that her teeth are not the only ones in the dark."

Silence stretched.

Her hand on his shoulder was very warm.

"I am also sorry," she added more quietly, "for what *you* had to endure. Beyond dragons. Beyond duty. No one should have that many ghosts in their head. I put mages in my harem to save them

from lesser hands than mine. Your people put a universe in your skull and threw you at a gate. That is…" She bared her teeth, not in a smile. "I do not have a polite word for it."

He laughed, a short, broken sound.

"We were…cornered," he said. "We did what we thought we had to."

"So do I," she said. "Most days. It does not make all of it…right."

His eyes burned.

He hadn't asked for this. For her apology. For…recognition.

He also hadn't realized how much some stupid, hurt part of him had wanted *someone* to say *it was not supposed to happen that way*.

Not a priest. Not a therapist. A dragon.

He looked away, blinking hard.

"If you cry on me," Zion said dryly, "I will be forced to either hug you or bite you, and I am not sure which would confuse the court more."

A wet snort escaped him.

"I will…avoid weeping on the Empress," he said, voice rough.

"Good," she said. "Palace laundry has enough to do."

They sat like that for a moment: him trying to get his breathing under control, her a quiet weight on his knees, the storm of her aether oddly…gentle against his senses. Still wild, still too much, but banked.

When he could trust his voice again, he cleared his throat.

“You said you owe me an apology,” he said. “You have…given it. Did you also come here to break every rule Drabiretha ever taught me about proper distance to the Throne?”

“Oh, that,” Zion said lightly. “Two things can be true. I am very fond of breaking my own rules when it suits me.”

He felt some of the tension seep out of his shoulders.

“Take your time,” she said, tone shifting again, businesslike. “Learn my court. Listen more than you speak, at first. Watch which way the knives point. I will not summon you for a few days unless the roof catches fire.” A pause. “Possibly not even then; it would be entertaining to see how they handle it without us.”

“Your Radiance—” he began, half-alarmed, half-amused.

She waved a hand.

“Treat this palace as your home,” she said. “Within reason. Wander the gardens. Haunt the libraries. Speak to my lightning rods”—a nod toward where her consorts would be, several walls away—“and my priests and my guards. Let them decide what to make of you without my eyes on their necks.”

“That seems…dangerous,” he said.

“For them, perhaps,” she replied. “For you…less so, while you still smell of new and interesting. Court is putty for a few weeks when I bring in a fresh toy.”

He made a face.

“I am not a toy,” he said.

“No,” she said. “That is why I like you.”

Her weight shifted; before he could fully register the loss, she was standing, the robe whispering back into place around her like fog.

She looked down at him, head tilted.

“You are…very controlled,” she observed. “Most men I sit on react more.”

“I had help,” he said before he could stop himself, tapping his temple.

“Ah,” she said, amused. “Your little machine. Tell it I am flattered it had to work so hard.”

He was absolutely not going to do that.

She turned toward the door, then paused.

“One more thing, Salkin,” she said without looking back.

“Yes, Your Radiance?” he said.

“If, in the coming weeks, you find something in my court that makes you say ‘we tried this in my world and it ended badly’…” She glanced over her shoulder, jade eyes serious now. “Tell me. Even if you think I will not like it. *Especially* then.”

He held her gaze.

“I will,” he said. “I cannot promise you will enjoy hearing it.”

“Enjoyment is overrated,” she said. “Usefulness is better.”

She opened the door.

The hall outside was empty except for a single guard who snapped to attention so fast Salkin was amazed he didn’t dislocate something.

“Sleep, traveler,” Zion said, stepping through. “Tomorrow, you begin the most tedious war of all: surviving my court without dying of boredom or assassination.”

“The Void was simpler,” he muttered.

“Oh, certainly,” she said. “It was honest about wanting to eat you.”

The door shut behind her with a soft thud.

For a long moment, Salkin just sat there, staring at nothing, feeling the phantom weight of a dragon-Empress on his lap and the echo of her words in his chest.

Every reality has a dragon.

Yours failed you.

I am sorry.

He let his head fall back against the sofa, closed his eyes, and finally—*finally*—let himself breathe.

The palace hummed around him.

For the first time since he’d arrived, it felt a little less like a gilded cage and a little more like what she’d said:

A place he might, very carefully, learn to call a kind of home.

By the next evening, the palace had stopped feeling like a dream and started feeling like a maze that might eat him.

So of course that was when the door slid open and a stranger strolled in without knocking.

Tall, lean, with hair like dark ink pulled back in a loose tie and a collar of jade that somehow looked more like jewelry than a chain, the man flashed him an easy grin.

“Hi,” he said. “I’m here to be your tour guide. I’m also here to ask the most important question in the palace.”

Salkin blinked. “…Which is?”

“I hear the Empress visited your chambers last night,” the man said cheerfully. “So: how long until you join the rest of us in the harem?”

Salkin made a noise that might have been a choke.

“That is—” he began, horrified.

“Relax,” the man laughed, waving a hand. “If she’d wanted you in the bed-circle, she wouldn’t have started with a *talk*. You’d know. Trust me.”

“That is not reassuring,” Salkin muttered. “At all.”

“Good,” the stranger said. “Keeps you on your toes. Lareth,” he added, tapping his own chest. “Lightning-flinger, ward-tester, professional bad influence. Her Radiance told me to show you the palace before it swallows you. Come on.”

He turned like he assumed Salkin would follow.

Annoyingly, Salkin did.

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The tour started pleasantly enough.

Lareth moved through the corridors like he’d been born in them—which, Salkin learned quickly, he more or less had. He pointed out the obvious things with a showman’s flair:

“That hall is for full court.”

“Those doors lead to the outer audience chambers—where the shouting happens.”

“Temple wing that way, unless you like priests, in which case I misjudged you badly.”

He peppered it with gossip:

“See that screen? Behind it is where High Priestess Marethi fainted when Zion told her to stop treating male mages like lost puppies.”

“That balcony? Great for watching storms. Terrible for private conversations; the stone remembers.”

But the real value wasn’t the landmarks.

It was the quiet, running commentary.

They turned down a corridor lined with carved dragons; Lareth casually steered Salkin to the left side.

“Never hug the right wall here,” he said.

“Why?” Salkin asked.

“Ward-line,” Lareth said. “Old one. Sensitive. If you brush it with too much aether, the palace thinks you’re an intruder and calls the guards. Or drops the ceiling. Depends on its mood.”

“Your palace drops ceilings,” Salkin said.

“Only on people it doesn’t like,” Lareth replied. “You’re new. It’s still making up its mind.”

Useful.

They passed under an arch painted with stars. Salkin felt a prickling on his skin, like static.

“What’s this one?” he asked.

“Eavesdropper’s Regret,” Lareth said. “Every sound here carries better than it should. Think twice before you whisper in this stretch. Or do it here when you *want* someone to overhear.”

He paused, eyebrows up. “You *are* going to tell me if you start naming the wards yourself, yes? Zion will be insufferable if she finds out she’s acquired an off-world colleague.”

“We’ll negotiate,” Salkin said dryly.

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They crossed bridges between towers, each with its own personality.

“This,” Lareth said, tapping a low parapet, “is Lovers’ Walk. Safe enough, unless you’re important. Then half the court will assume you’re plotting every time you set foot on it with someone.”

“Libel,” Salkin said.

“Survival,” Lareth corrected. “If you come out here with Drabiretha, do it at night. In the rain. Then everyone assumes you’re just weird, not scheming.”

“I *am* weird,” Salkin pointed out.

“Palace already knows that,” Lareth said. “It just hasn’t decided if it’s the fun kind or the dangerous kind.”

Inside again: painted corridors, incense-thick shrines, a library that made Salkin’s chest hurt with the weight of knowledge.

Lareth lingered just long enough to point.

“Third stack on the left is Imperial Histories,” he said. “Half of it is lies. The other half is boring. The really interesting stuff is in the

restricted stacks below, so don't let the Archivist trick you into thinking this is all there is."

"And how does one get into the restricted stacks?" Salkin asked.

"Very carefully," Lareth said. "Or by being on the very short list of 'people Zion lets break things if they find something alarming.' You're probably on that list now. Congratulations, I guess."

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They wove through servant corridors ("Fast, safe, but never block the lanes."), past the small shrines staff favored ("This one's for safe births and safe gossip. Don't mix the offerings up."), and skirted the outer edge of the inner sanctum.

"If you see those two dragons carved together," Lareth said, nodding at a particular pattern over a door, "you don't go in. That's *hers*."

"Even if she tells me to treat the palace as home?" Salkin asked.

Lareth gave him a look that was half amused, half pitying.

"Home has rooms you don't walk into uninvited," he said. "She'll be clear when she wants you there. Zion is a lot of things. Subtle about that is not one of them."

Fair.

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The training yard hit him like a physical force.

They stepped out into a high-walled space open to the sky, the hum of aether thick in the air. Sand. Dummies. Weapon racks. Rings marked out in white paint.

And people.

Palace guards drilling in formation, bare arms flashing. Mage-duelists sparring in pairs, flinging carefully contained Fire and Water at each other under a watchful old instructor's eye. A trio of harem-consorts in lighter gear running through a paired staff form that braided Air and Earth in a way that made Salkin's fingers twitch with the urge to correct.

The yard's wards thrummed under his skin: layered, old, reinforced over and over by different hands. Containment. Safety. A hint of something more…experimental in one corner.

He stopped dead.

Lareth followed his line of sight and blew out a breath.

"Yeah," he said. "I thought this might be where I'd lose you."

Salkin didn't answer.

He watched a palace guard mis-time a Lightning-laced thrust and winced when the bolt snapped sideways into the sand, kicking up a burst of glassy shards.

"Too much," he muttered, under his breath. "She's overloading her tendons—"

Lareth's head tilted.

"You see that," he said. Not a question.

"Yes," Salkin said. "We've been…working on something similar in Moonhold."

"I heard," Lareth said. "Drabri's little storm-fist school."

Pride, not envy, in his tone. Interesting.

A mage-duelist in the far corner misjudged a Water shield, letting Fire splash too close to his own wrist. Salkin almost stepped forward before the old instructor snapped a sigil and snuffed it.

“Why does it feel like your teeth itch?” Lareth asked lazily.

“Because this yard is…a symphony,” Salkin said, frustrated. “Tuned badly in places. And I want to…fix it.”

Lareth watched him for a heartbeat, then shook his head in mock sorrow.

“You’re one of *those*,” he said. “The ones who can’t walk past a crooked ward without wanting to straighten it.”

“Do you not?” Salkin asked.

“Oh, I do,” Lareth said. “I just also like living. Which means I pick my battles. And my wards. Come on.” He clapped Salkin lightly on the shoulder. “If I let you sit here, we’ll be here until someone drags us out for dinner.”

Salkin’s feet did not want to move.

Some deep, trained part of him wanted to step into the yard, bark corrections, ask to see their forms, to feel how their aether moved through strikes and kicks. To *test*.

Only Lareth’s hand and the memory of Drabiretha’s warning—Don’t start a school in the Empress’s backyard without talking to me first—kept him walking.

He glanced back once as they passed through the arch.

The old instructor had noticed him. Their gazes met for a second. There was no hostility there. Just interest. And a flicker of recognition that said: *You and I speak a similar language. Later.*

Later, then.

◇ ◇ ◇

By the time the tour wound back toward the guest wing, Salkin's head throbbed with new information.

Secret stairs. Shortcuts between towers. Which gardens were for quiet thought and which were for being seen. Which courtiers were landmines. Which shrines doubled as unofficial gambling dens.

Lareth delivered it all with a kind of ruthless cheer.

He was easy to like.

Not because he was harmless—he wasn't. Salkin could feel the raw power coiled under his skin, Lightning braided through his nerves like a second skeleton. Lareth moved with the casual confidence of someone who knew he could kill most people in the room *and* rewrite their wards afterwards.

But he didn't pretend otherwise.

He didn't play at helpless consort or meek court mage. He was born into this—into collars and politics and a palace that used people like pieces—but he had clearly decided a long time ago that if he had to live in a cage, he'd learn every bar, every hinge, every weak point.

"So," Lareth said finally, leaning against a pillar outside Salkin's door when they arrived back. "Initial impressions?"

"On you or on the palace?" Salkin asked.

"Both," Lareth said, unabashed.

“The palace is…a weapon pretending to be a house,” Salkin said. “And you are…annoying.”

Lareth grinned. “You’ll fit in fine.”

Salkin hesitated.

“I expected…” he gestured vaguely at Lareth’s collar “…more resentment.”

“Oh, it’s there,” Lareth said easily. “I just learned early that sulking makes bad wards. Zion didn’t put me here as window-dressing. She put me here because I can light up half the palace if someone tries something stupid.” He shrugged. “If I have to wear jade to keep that power in my hands and not, say, my uncle’s, I’ll take the trade.”

“Practical,” Salkin said softly.

“Also,” Lareth added, wicked glint in his eye, “her bath is magnificent and the food is better than anything outside these walls. I am shallow as well as principled.”

Salkin snorted.

“I think I like you,” he admitted.

“Good,” Lareth said. “You’re going to need at least one friend who knows where all the bodies are buried. Metaphorically.” A pause. “Mostly metaphorically.”

“That is not comforting,” Salkin said.

“Court isn’t,” Lareth replied. “But it can be…fun. Between the knives.”

He pushed off the pillar.

“Rest,” he said. “Tomorrow I introduce you to the library’s ugly side and the priest who thinks you’re an omen. Try not to let Zion sit on you again before then; it’ll give the rumor-mill too much to work with.”

Salkin’s ears went hot.

“She *talked*,” he said defensively.

“I’m sure she did,” Lareth drawled. “In a robe like that, no one hears a word.”

He dodged the half-hearted swat Salkin aimed at him and sauntered away, humming.

Salkin watched him go, a reluctant smile tugging at his mouth.

Born into this, yes. But not quietly resigned to it.

Powerful, and utterly unashamed of it.

If Zion was a storm in a box and Drabiretha a carefully honed blade, Lareth was lightning that had taught itself to enjoy the clouds it lived in.

Salkin decided he liked that. A lot.

The summons came when he was half-asleep.

A polite knock, then a servant’s voice through the panel: “Honored Salkin? Her Radiance requests your presence in the inner baths.”

The *inner* baths.

His brain fuzz cleared very fast.

“She…requests?” he asked, just in case the universe had decided to become merciful.

“Yes,” the servant said. “Personally.”

Of course.

◇ ◇ ◇

The palace corridors were quiet at this hour. Lamps burned lower; the usual bustle of servants had thinned to a skeleton crew. Salkin padded along in soft trousers and the light wrap Drabiretha had bullied him into wearing as “something between your world’s modesty and ours.”

The inner bath doors steamed gently.

Two guards outside straightened when he approached, then—after a quick, assessing glance—opened the doors without a word.

Heat hit him like a wall.

The chamber was all pale stone and soft light. Steam coiled up from a pool large enough to drown a company in, the surface broken by carved dragon-spouts pouring in constant, murmuring streams.

Drabiretha and Zion were already in.

Up to their shoulders, backs to the far curve of the pool. Horns and dark hair and moss-green hair, two sets of eyes—amber-gold and jade-fire—turning toward him as the door whispered shut behind his back.

He almost stopped.

He did not stare.

He absolutely did not stare at the line where water met skin, or the way lamplight played over wet shoulders. He fixed his gaze very firmly somewhere above their heads.

Heart rate spike. Hormonal profile indicates—

Override. Calm-measures level three. Now.

Cool washed through his veins. Muscles unclenched a fraction. The nanites obligingly kicked a damp blanket over the worst of the physical reaction.

It still took everything he had not to turn around and walk straight back out.

“Storm-gift,” Drabiretha said, amused. “Get in before you overheat and fall in.”

Zion’s mouth curved. “Yes,” she said. “Do obey your Lunarch. I’d hate to have to explain to the registrar that my new advisor died of modesty.”

He made a noise halfway between a cough and a laugh, set his jaw, and stripped down to the level the wrap allowed before stepping carefully into the water.

Heat swallowed him. Muscles sighed despite themselves.

He crossed the pool and sank down opposite them, keeping a perfectly respectable amount of distance. The water reached his chest; steam blurred the far wall.

Zion watched him with open amusement.

“Sorry about the summons,” she said, as if she’d called him to a card game instead of a naked dragon soak. “I *did* say I wouldn’t drag you anywhere for a few days.”

“You did, Your Radiance,” he said carefully.

“But,” she went on blithely, “Drabiretha told me so many interesting things about you today that I simply had to look at those pretty eyes again.”

Heat that had nothing to do with the bath crept up his neck.

“I am beginning,” he said, “to suspect your ‘no summons’ promises come with very small print.”

“I am an Empress,” she said. “All my promises come with small print.”

Drabiretha snorted, not bothering to hide it.

Zion’s gaze softened, mischief dimming just enough to let something more genuine through.

“Relax, traveler,” she said. “No dragon confessions tonight. No new titles. I only want to talk somewhere I don’t have to wear ten kilos of jade and listen to courtiers breathing.”

“And,” Drabiretha added dryly, “where she can watch you flail and make excellent faces.”

“I am not flailing,” Salkin lied.

Both of them looked at him.

He sighed and let himself sink another inch.

◇ ◇ ◇

“So,” Zion said after a moment, resting her arms along the pool’s edge. “You have had a day to wander my den. What do you think of my palace?”

He thought she wanted flattery.

He remembered dinner.

No. She’d asked for truth.

He met her eyes.

“It is…” He searched for the right word. “Honest.”

Drabiretha’s brow arched faintly.

“Explain,” Zion said, intrigued.

“You do not pretend it is only a house,” Salkin went on. “The wards hum like a weapon. The layout…shapes behavior. Funnels gossip. Controls who can fall over which balcony with ‘regrettable’ timing.” A small shrug. “I have seen fortresses pretending to be palaces. This is a fortress that makes no apology for being what it is.”

Her smile thinned, satisfied.

“And the people in it?” she asked.

“Afraid,” he said. “Ambitious. Tired. Some of them very loyal. Some of them very…flexible. The harem is not a harem, not as your laws pretend—more a lightning rod and a threat display. The mages are better than they think they are. The priests are more frightened of you than of their own gods, which is…useful, I suppose.”

Drabiretha huffed a quiet laugh.

“Concise,” Zion said. “Brutal. Not entirely inaccurate.”

“You did ask,” he said.

“I did,” she agreed. “And you remembered you don’t have to sweeten it. Good.”

He hesitated, then added, “And if I might say something from the… gossip side of things, Your Radiance?”

“Oh, do,” she said, instantly more amused. “Court gossip is my favorite bloodsport.”

He gestured weakly between the three of them, submerged to the shoulders in a private inner bath.

“This,” he said. “Will give the rumor mill a great deal to work with.”

Drabiretha actually choked.

Zion threw her head back and laughed, the sound bouncing off stone.

“Oh, let them,” she said. “Half the court already thinks I’m seducing you. The other half thinks I’m planning to feed you to a dragon. It will do them good to be wrong on both counts for a while.”

“A while,” Salkin echoed warily.

She waved a dripping hand.

“They will talk no matter what you do,” she said. “Better they talk about baths and potential scandals than start inventing theories about you being a secret demon sent to unmake the Empire. Besides…” Her eyes glinted. “A little fear that you might be in my favor makes you harder to *touch*.”

Drabiretha nodded once, grudging approval.

“Court is less likely to take stupid risks with someone they think might end up in her bed,” she said. “Even if that someone spends most of his time in the library instead.”

“I am beginning to feel very…used,” Salkin said dryly.

“Welcome to politics,” they said together.

He snorted.

Some of the knot in his chest unwound. The water did its work; the nanites eased the last of the fight-or-flight edge.

He let his head tip back, eyes on the painted ceiling where dragons rolled through stars.

Between one breath and the next, it struck him:

Months ago he'd been on a black shore, sure he would die alone.

Tonight he was in a dragon's private bath, trading dry jokes about rumor mills with an Empress and a Lunarch, his legs slowly going numb from too-hot water and too-many complications.

It was insane.

A man could go mad from less.

He closed his eyes and chose, very carefully, not to.

Chapter Twenty — Among the Consorts

It had been months since the black shore.

Long enough that routine had sunk into his bones, long enough that Moonhold felt almost like “normal” and the palace felt like a very pretty, very dangerous fever dream.

Day two of Lareth’s “don’t die in Jade Crown” tour began with the door slamming open.

“Traveler!” Lareth sang out, already half in the room. “Up, up, the gods of gossip demand your presence.”

Salkin, who had been trying to decide whether he could get away with reading in bed until breakfast, sat up slowly.

“You are loud,” he said.

“You bathed with *both* the Empress and the Lunarch and you’re worried about *me* being loud?” Lareth leaned against the doorframe, eyes bright. “So. You enjoyed the beauty of both the Empress and the Advisor at the same time. Not many have managed that and lived.”

Salkin’s ears went hot.

“We talked,” he said stiffly. “In hot water. That is all.”

“Mm,” Lareth said, unconvinced. “I’m sure that’s *exactly* what the rumor mill is saying. Come on, Grand Bath Survivor. Today: temples.”

“Joy,” Salkin muttered, reaching for his robe.

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The temple district sat like a jeweled collar around one of the inner hills—domes and spires and staircases, each shrine in a different style, all vying for attention like very pious street hawkers.

From the outside, it was beautiful. From inside Salkin's head, it was noise. The aether here was…busy. Prayers had a flavor, apparently, and centuries of them layered on top of one another had left the stone humming with expectation.

Lareth clearly hated it.

"You do not like this place," Salkin observed as they climbed yet another flight of painted stairs.

"I like my gods quiet and very far away," Lareth said. "These ones are neither."

He pointed with his chin as they passed a broad set of stairs lined with kneeling figures and candlelight.

"Dragonheart Basilica," he said. "High priestess thinks she runs the Empire as long as Zion lets her keep thinking it. Do *not* let her catch you alone unless you want to be declared an omen."

"I thought you said a priest already thinks that," Salkin said.

"Oh, that's a different one," Lareth replied. "Old man, tiny shrine. I'll introduce you later; he's entertaining. This one—" he nodded at the basilica "—is dangerous."

"Define dangerous," Salkin said.

"The kind who will smile and call you 'beloved child of the Dragon' while writing your name into a prophecy that justifies something awful," Lareth said. "Keep interactions short. Be vague. Never promise anything."

“Useful rules,” Salkin said.

“Generalizable,” Lareth agreed.

They moved on, a breeze of palace jade in a crowd of temple whites and pilgrimage colors. A few acolytes glanced at Lareth’s collar with a flicker of recognition and stayed prudently out of their path.

He pointed out the smaller shrines with less malice.

“That one is for sisters who need help ‘forgetting’ inconvenient lovers,” he said. “That one’s for safe births. The little one there? Scribes’ shrine. If you leave paper there, it will *never* get lost in the archives.”

“That sounds like a miracle,” Salkin said.

“It’s just a very organized goddess,” Lareth said. “You’d like her.”

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From temples they cut across into more familiar territory: the barracks.

Palace stone turned plainer here. Less jade, more scuffed thresholds. The air smelled of oiled leather, sweat, steel. Salkin breathed easier as soon as they stepped under the arch.

“This,” Lareth said, “is where the people who keep the palace from falling apart live. You’ve seen the fancy training yard; this is where they hide the sore muscles and the dice games.”

Salkin’s own six were easy to find.

The apprentices had carved a little corner for themselves in one of the smaller yards off the main barracks. Tala was at the center, dripping sweat, demonstrating a careful Lightning-threaded palm-

strike into a padded target while two palace guards watched with a mix of awe and terror.

Hestra spotted him first.

“Storm-gift!” she called, straightening. Then, seeing who was at his shoulder: “Oh. And…Lightningsong.”

“Lightningsong?” Salkin murmured.

“Old nickname,” Lareth muttered back, making a face.

The six scrambled up, suddenly self-conscious under the dual gaze of their teacher and the Empress’s consort.

“Lareth,” Salkin said, “my students. Hestra, Tala, Jorin, Mira, Phelyn, Sarai. The beginnings of the…elemental blades.”

All six straightened unconsciously at the phrase.

“Elemental blades, hm?” Lareth said, looking them over. “That what they’re calling you lot?”

“Among other things,” Hestra said, a bit too brightly. Then slapped a hand over her own mouth.

Lareth’s eyes narrowed with predatory interest.

“Other things like…what?” he asked.

The apprentices traded panicked glances. No one volunteered.

Tala cracked first.

“They…call him…Grand Master,” she blurted, jerking a thumb at Salkin. “Grand Master of the Elemental Blades. Sir.”

Silence.

Lareth turned very slowly to Salkin, an expression of awe and absolute delight spreading across his face.

“Grand. Master,” he repeated.

“It was not my idea,” Salkin said, already resigned.

“Oh, I *know* it wasn’t,” Lareth said. “That’s what makes it perfect. Does Zion know?”

“Yes,” Salkin said wearily. “She thinks it’s funny.”

Drabiretha thought it was secretly wonderful, but that was not information he was going to hand a palace gossip vector.

Lareth folded his arms, looking unreasonably pleased.

“Well,” he said. “This complicates my day in the best way. The Empress brings home a dragon-bitten archivist from another universe and Moonhold’s soldiers decide he needs a martial arts title. Court is going to choke on this.”

“Please do not choke the court with my existence,” Salkin said.

“No promises,” Lareth replied cheerfully.

He turned back to the apprentices, expression sharpening.

“So,” he said. “Show me.”

They looked to Salkin.

He hesitated, then nodded. “Basic drill,” he said. “Form three. No more than a trickle of element. We are guests; we do not set anyone on fire.”

Groans, but they obeyed.

They moved through the sequence he’d hammered into them: step, block, strike, pivot, kick, guard. Threads of Air along their feet, of

Fire in their knuckles, of Earth anchoring stances. Rough still, but recognizably *theirs*.

Lareth watched, arms folded, lightning-sense tuned.

“Not bad,” he said, when they’d finished and stood panting. “I’ve seen Palace Blademasters with less control.” His gaze flicked to Salkin. “You built this out of nothing?”

“Out of habits,” Salkin said quietly. “And need.”

Lareth nodded once, something like respect sliding into place.

“Keep at it,” he told the six. “And if any palace instructor gives you trouble, tell them Lightningsong said they can come argue with *me* about whether your training’s worth the bruises.”

“Yes, sir!” they chorused, half-dazed.

As he and Salkin walked away, Salkin shot him a sideways look.

“You are encouraging them,” he said.

“Well, yes,” Lareth said. “Someone has to. Besides, if you get yourself killed or promoted sideways into dragon politics, someone has to keep your style alive. I am very selfish that way.”

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The second half of the day’s tour was less about stone and more about people.

When they reached a relatively quiet gallery overlooking one of the inner gardens, Lareth stopped abruptly.

“All right,” he said. “You’ve met me. You’ve met Zion. You’ve met courtiers, guards, priests, Drabiretha’s terrifying eyebrows. Time to meet…them.”

“The rest of the harem,” Salkin guessed.

“Very good,” Lareth said. “Ten points to Dead Universe. Come on.”

Salkin stayed where he was.

“Is that…necessary?” he asked carefully.

Lareth looked back at him, all the humor draining out of his face for a moment.

“Yes,” he said simply.

Salkin frowned.

“Because,” Lareth went on, “if you keep taking baths and late-night visits and private jokes with the Empress *and* the Lunarch, and you *don’t* know how the den you’re circling actually works, you’ll stumble over someone’s feelings or politics without meaning to, and then we all get to deal with the fallout.” His mouth twitched. “And because, frankly, if you continue like this you’ll end up amongst us in a fortnight, and it’d be nice if you knew our names.”

“Half-joke,” Salkin said.

“Half,” Lareth agreed. “Come on. Better you hear what you’re walking into from us than from some bored courtier who thinks we’re decorative pets.”

He turned and this time waited until Salkin made himself move.

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The harem’s common hall was…not what Salkin had expected.

He’d pictured silk cushions, fountains, maybe a musician or two weeping quietly in a corner.

Instead, it felt like a very comfortable, very secure shared apartment for extremely dangerous people.

Low couches, yes, and cushions. Also tables strewn with papers, half-finished ward-diagrams, a go board mid-game. Open screens onto a private garden where someone had hung laundry next to exotic climbing vines. A pile of practice staves in one corner.

A few people looked up as they came in; a few did not, too engrossed in whatever they were working on.

“Herd,” Lareth announced. “This is Salkin. Storm-gift. Grand Master of the Elemental Blades. Dead-universe-import. Zion’s new advisor. Moonhold’s problem. Try not to scare him too much on the first day.”

Several heads snapped up at once.

“Grand Master?” someone echoed with indecent glee.

Salkin considered walking back out.

“Come in,” a familiar voice drawled.

Hara—the scarred woman from dinner—was sprawled on a couch with a cup of tea, bare feet up on the low table. She jerked her chin at an empty chair.

“Sit. If you stand there looking like you’re about to bolt, half of them will start trying to collect you like a rare bird.”

“That’s not—” one of the younger men began.

Hara arched a brow. “You were literally taking bets this morning on how long until Zion drags him in here.”

The boy shut his mouth, flushing.

Salkin sat.

Names came in a wave.

Sen, the ward-scribe, ink already smudged on his fingers today. Hara, "punches problems." Dalen, the Air-touched youth who'd winked at him across the dinner table. Two women who weren't technically consorts but lived here anyway: a healer specializing in aether-burns, and a scholar tasked with recording "things Zion thinks are interesting."

They were…normal.

Or as normal as people could be while being collared mages and warriors living in the dragon's shadow.

They bickered. They gossiped. They talked shop.

"So you're the one teaching Drabri's pups to punch with Fire," Hara said, eyeing him. "About time someone weaponized their stubbornness properly."

"And you really *see* the Empress like that?" Dalen leaned forward, eyes wide. "Elemental chaos, all tied up in a girl-shape?"

"Yes," Salkin said. "Loudly."

"Explains a lot," Sen muttered. "Her field has always made my teeth hurt."

"Welcome to the club," Salkin said.

They laughed.

Questions came, but not the ones he'd braced for.

Not *what did your world look like*—they'd heard the broad strokes at dinner.

More: *How do your nanites feel when our aether presses? Does your close-combat style work if someone changes the gravity? How do*

you keep your head straight with that many ghost-memories riding you?

He answered what he could, lied gently where he had to (no, the AI cannot control me; yes, it can be irritating), and listened.

Listened to how they talked about Zion when she wasn't in the room: not as a distant goddess, not as an employer, but as a force of nature they'd collectively chosen to tie themselves to.

Listened to how they spoke of collars: with bitterness, jokes, and occasionally, very quiet gratitude that *if* they had to wear one, at least this one came with teeth pointed outward.

At some point, someone shoved a cup of tea into his hand without asking.

"You're quieter than I expected," Hara observed, watching him over the rim of her cup.

"I have been…overstimulated," he said. "Recently."

"Get used to it," she said. "This place doesn't slow down. It just changes flavor."

Lareth slouched into a chair sideways, long legs dangling over one arm.

"Anyway," he said, "consider this your orientation session. Rule one: if someone in silk from outside this hall starts talking about you like an object, you come *tell* us. We get territorial."

"That is…comforting," Salkin said.

"Rule two," Dalen added, grinning, "if you start thinking Zion is a god, remember that we have seen her stub her toe on the bath-

step and swear like a dock-worker. Helps put things in perspective."

"Rule three," Sen put in. "If any of us warn you that a particular courtier is radioactive, believe us. We've survived this long by smelling poison early."

"And rule four," Hara said. "If you *do* end up officially 'one of us,' you don't get to pretend you're above the rest of us because you came from another universe. We all bleed the same color when she pushes us too hard."

Salkin met her gaze.

"I have no desire to be…above…anyone," he said. "I have done that before. It did not end well."

Hara held his eyes for a moment, then nodded once, accepting that.

"Good," she said. "Then you might actually survive this."

Lareth clinked his cup lightly against Salkin's.

"To surviving," he said. "And to confusing the hells out of the court by existing."

Salkin snorted, but touched his cup back.

"To existing," he said. "One bewildering day at a time."

Around him, the Empress's so-called harem argued about ward-geometry, complained about priests, traded stories about Zion's latest fits of boredom, and made space—almost without noticing—for a man from a dead universe to sit among them and learn where, exactly, he had landed.

Chapter Twenty-One — Lessons in the Palace Yard

He brought it up over breakfast, which in retrospect was probably cowardice disguised as efficiency.

Drabiretha was going through a sheaf of reports, spearing bits of fruit with the same focus she gave to troop movements. The light from the balcony made the lines at the corners of her eyes softer.

“Drabiretha,” Salkin said.

“Mhm?” She didn’t look up yet. That was how he knew he still had time to change his mind.

“I want,” he said, “your permission to…interfere.”

That got her attention.

Her head lifted, amber eyes narrowing. “Be more specific before my heart stops.”

“With the palace guard,” he said. “Not to start teaching them the elemental blade form. Not yet. Only…to guide. To correct obvious mistakes before they hurt themselves. Or someone else.”

Her gaze sharpened. “You’re already teaching Moonhold. Now you want to start on the Crown?”

“They are…bad at certain things,” he said, choosing his words. “Not *terrible*. But they rely too much on steel and wards. Not enough on…how to stand. How to move. If I am to stay here, it will irritate me to watch them waste so much potential.”

A corner of her mouth twitched.

“And irritated Salkin makes *my* life worse,” she said. “So this is partly self-defense.”

“Mostly,” he admitted.

She sat back, weighing, tail tip drawing a slow pattern on the floor.

“I don’t object,” she said finally. “In principle. Better trained guards mean fewer corpses in my hallways. But this is *her* house. Her guard. If you start rearranging them without her consent, half the court will call it overreach and the other half will call it a coup.”

He grimaced. “So I need—”

“Her permission,” Drabiretha finished. “In public, where everyone can see it.”

He exhaled.

“Of course,” he said.

She smiled, small and a little wicked.

“And one more thing,” she added. “If she says yes, you are not allowed to complain when they start calling you Grand Master in *this* yard too.”

He dropped his head briefly to the table.

“I regret everything,” he muttered.

“No, you don’t,” she said. “You’d be bored otherwise.”

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Getting in to see the Empress was easier and harder when she was “busy.”

Her chamberlain met him outside the council room, eyes flicking to the jade token Drabiretha had pressed into his hand.

“Honored Advisor,” the woman said. “Her Radiance is in session. She has instructed that you be admitted…as spice.”

“Spice,” he echoed.

“She grows bored,” the chamberlain translated, with the air of someone long resigned. “Please try not to make any Lunarchs cry.”

The council room was already humming when he slipped in behind her.

A long table, maps and ledgers spread across it. Lunarchs in their colors. High Crescents. Priests. Zion at the head, in full dragon-Empress mode: jade coronet, formal robes, tails of her chair carved into coiled dragons.

Every head turned as the chamberlain announced:

“Her Radiance’s Advisor, Salkin.”

He walked in on the Dragon’s Spine of polished stone, aware of too many eyes. Collars gleamed around men’s throats here and there. No one else stood unadorned.

Zion’s gaze found him and—quite openly—ran from head to toe and back up again, as if she were assessing a weapon she’d ordered and was pleased to find properly made.

“Traveler,” she said. “You interrupt us. This had better be interesting.”

It was said lightly. It was not a joke.

He bowed, enough to be respectful, not enough to grovel.

“Your Radiance,” he said. “I will be brief.”

He laid it out as cleanly as he could.

“I request permission to assist your palace guard,” he said. “Not to change their command. Only to correct form where I see it. To keep them from injuring themselves when they play with Lightning and steel at the same time.”

A buzz went around the table.

“You want to train my guards,” Zion said. “In *front* of Lunarchs who would very much like a piece of you for themselves.”

“I want fewer broken bones in your yard,” he said. “And soldiers who do not accidentally shatter their own knees when they stomp wrong. If that offends anyone’s sense of pride, they are free to continue limping.”

There was a strangled noise from down the table. Drabiretha’s eyes flashed with barely contained amusement.

One of the older Lunarchs—a severe woman in Vermilion colors—leaned forward.

“With respect, Your Radiance,” she said, “it is…unusual…to give an uncollared man such direct access to the palace guard’s training.”

“Unusual,” Salkin agreed mildly. “So are Void incursions. One adapts.”

He felt, rather than saw, Lareth’s smirk from his seat along the wall.

Zion tapped a claw against the table, once. The sound cut through the murmur like a knife.

“Tell me this, Salkin,” she said. “Do you intend to turn my guard into a private army loyal only to you?”

“No,” he said, without hesitation. “I prefer not to be stabbed in my sleep.”

Soft laughter scattered around the room.

“And do you intend to train them in these…elemental blades… you’ve been teaching Moonhold?” she asked, eyes glinting.

“Not without further discussion, Your Radiance,” he said carefully. “I ask only to…nudge. Correct. Safety first. Philosophy later.”

She studied him for a heartbeat.

Then she smiled, slow and sharp.

“Done,” she said. “You have my consent to rearrange my soldiers’ feet so they stop offending your sensibilities. Publicly stated, so no one can pretend they didn’t hear.”

Several nobles looked like they’d bitten lemons.

“Thank you, Your Radiance,” he said, bowing again.

“Come here,” she said suddenly.

He obeyed, unsure—stopping at the corner of the table near her chair.

She reached up.

For one surreal, frozen second he thought she might take his chin in her hand, or ruffle his hair like a pet.

Instead she leaned in and brushed a quick, unmistakable kiss against his cheek.

Heat flared under his skin.

The room *gasped*.

Zion sat back, expression as innocent as a cat in a creamery.

“Now go,” she said. “Before I decide to cause more trouble. Drabri, please explain to our dear colleagues why this is not the beginning of open rebellion.”

“Gladly, Your Radiance,” Drabiretha said, dry as sand.

Salkin backed away on not entirely steady legs, acutely aware of every stare pinning itself to the spot where the Empress’s mouth had just been.

Out in the corridor, he exhaled like he’d been underwater.

More than keeping the court on its toes, a treacherous thought whispered.

He bared his teeth at himself.

“That’s what you get,” he muttered, “for calling a woman beautiful in her own throne room.”

A passing servant pretended very hard not to have heard that.

◇ ◇ ◇

The training yard that evening was full.

Word had moved ahead of him, the way it always did here. Palace guards filled the rings and the benches, curiosity and skepticism thick in the air.

He stepped onto the sand with Lareth lounging in the shade and two of his own apprentices lurking at the edge, clearly dying to watch.

Salkin drew a breath, let his gaze travel over the assembled faces.

“First,” he said, loud enough to carry, “I am not here to replace your instructors. I am not here to humiliate you. I am here because your Empress is tired of paying healers to fix the same preventable mistakes.”

A ripple of rueful laughter.

“Second,” he continued, “I am *very* good at seeing those mistakes. You will not like what I say. But if you listen, your knees will thank you when you are old.”

That broke the last of the stiffness.

He started simple.

“Captain,” he called to a woman he’d seen drilling squads before, “show me your basic Lightning thrust.”

She did: solid form, good speed, too much weight forward.

He watched, then stepped in, tapping her ankle with his toe.

“Here,” he said. “You over-commit. It works on dummies. On real ground, wet ground, uphill, you slip, you die. Shift.”

He nudged her heel an inch. Had her repeat the thrust. Again. Again. Each time, he corrected a fraction, explaining *why*.

Within fifteen minutes, she was hitting just as hard, with half the strain on her joints.

“Feels…wrong,” she muttered.

“Good,” he said. “Wrong is how new lives feel, at first.”

He moved through the ranks.

A young guard with too much Fire burning in her punches—he showed her how to let Earth bear some of the load. An older one

who locked his hips when he kicked—he made him practice with Water riding his movement, flowing instead of jarring.

He didn't show off.

No whirlwind of elemental light, no storm-dances. Just small, precise corrections, and the occasional dry remark that made them laugh instead of bristle.

By the time the lamps were being lit, half the yard was moving differently.

Shoulders lower. Feet surer. Less wasted motion.

Salkin's muscles ached from demonstrating, his throat was rough from explaining the same concepts three different ways—but something in him hummed with the bone-deep satisfaction of *usefulness*.

Lareth sauntered over as the last of the guards broke off into smaller drills.

"Not bad for your first day terrifying the Imperial Guard," he said. "No one even burst into flames."

"That is tomorrow," Salkin said. "Today was just…triage."

Lareth grinned.

"Careful," he said. "If you keep this up, they'll start calling you Grand Master here too."

"They already do," one of the younger guards called, overhearing, cheeks flushed from practice. "Behind your back. Sir."

Salkin closed his eyes briefly.

"I regret *everything*," he said again.

But under the exasperation, under the political tension and the weight of Zion's kiss still ghosting his skin, there was something else:

He'd seen a dozen stances shift from "good enough" to "will save your life in a bad alley."

For a man from a dead universe, that was as good a day's work as any.

Chapter Twenty-Two — The Empress's Chosen

The summons this time was not to a bath, or a quiet council room.

It was to the yard.

"Her Radiance requests a demonstration," the chamberlain said, expression carefully neutral. "In front of the court."

Salkin didn't bother pretending he didn't know what that meant.

"She wants them to see what I can do," he said.

"And what you might do," Drabiretha added, walking beside him toward the training ground. "And what they absolutely do *not* want to try to steal."

"Comforting," he muttered.

"She also wants to see your limits," Drabiretha said quietly. "Don't lie to her. Not with your body, either."

"Honesty has been working so far," he said. "I'll give her everything I can without breaking your Empress's floor."

"Appreciated," she said. "The repair paperwork is awful."

◇ ◇ ◇

The palace yard had been transformed.

Usually it was a working space—guards, consorts, occasional apprentices, the old instructor grumbling. Today, a temporary gallery had been set up along the walls: chairs under awnings, silk draped over stone. Lunarchs in their colors. High Crescents. Priests. The harem, in more formal robes, clustered to one side.

And at the center of the long edge, in a raised seat beneath a carved dragon's head, Zion.

She wore less jade than in full court—travel leathers shaped into something more ceremonial, no crown, hair braided back—but even like this, she bent the space around her.

The yard itself had been cleared.

Sixty training dummies stood in neat circles where Salkin had indicated—inner ring, middle, outer. His six pupils and a handful of palace guards had helped set them up, shooting him the occasional wide-eyed glance.

Lareth lounged near the harem contingent, visibly vibrating with anticipation.

Salkin stepped onto the sand, sword at his hip.

It was *his* sword—latest iteration from the Moonhold forge. Steel and aether, tempered to drink Fire and Lightning without cracking, tuned to his grip and balance. He rested a hand on the hilt, grounding.

"Court of Jade," Zion's voice rolled out over the yard, lazy and carrying. "You have all read reports. Heard rumors. Some of you have written me very tedious letters about 'security concerns' and 'unregistered assets.'"

A ripple of nervous laughter.

"Today," she went on, "you will see for yourselves. What my Lunarch of Crystal Moon has been hiding on her shoreline. What my new advisor can do to sixty very unfortunate wooden men."

Her eyes flicked to him, bright.

“Salkin,” she said. “Show them.”

He bowed, short and sharp.

“As you wish, Your Radiance.”

◇ ◇ ◇

The sword came first.

He walked to the center of the circles, feeling the ward-lines under his bare feet. The palace had reinforced them for this—he could sense the extra layers of containment sighing under the sand.

“Core,” he murmured inwardly. “Combat profile. Full external augmentation. Prioritize control over spectacle.”

Confirm: limit collateral damage to arena boundary. Neural acceleration 250%. Musculoskeletal reinforcement active.

He drew the sword.

To the watching court, there was no fanfare. Just steel whispering from sheath, a man taking a stance.

He let his awareness narrow.

Dummies behind, before, to the side. Distances. Angles. The tolerances of his blade. The way this world’s aether pooled around wood and straw.

He breathed in once.

And moved.

He didn’t give them the truly invisible version. Zion had asked for a *show*, and he’d promised himself honesty—about his power, and about how utterly outmatched most of this yard would be if he ever turned it on them.

So he pulled back. A little.

Fast enough that his body blurred at the edge, slow enough that trained eyes could follow pieces.

To him, it was a familiar dance: step-pivot-cut, the blade humming with a slim thread of Air-mode along its edge, Fire and Lightning braided just under the skin of the steel to bite deeper without shattering.

To them, it was…a storm.

He moved from dummy to dummy in a tight spiral, no wasted motion, every stroke economical and final. No repeated blows. No hacking. One cut per target, sometimes two where the geometry demanded.

Heads came off as if they'd been unscrewed. Torsos split diagonally with obscene neatness. Limbs flicked away in showers of straw.

He used the circles the way he'd designed them: outer ring to build momentum, middle to cut across angles, inner to stop dead and reverse.

It took…seconds.

Not the impossible, single-heartbeat blur he'd once given Rhoena. But still: heartbeats, not minutes.

He found himself back in the center, sword in guard position, breath only slightly elevated.

Behind him, sixty dummies gave up their structural integrity in a staggered series of collapses. First one, then five, then the rest—a ripple of cracking wood and falling straw.

Silence.

Then, somewhere in the tiers, someone swallowed audibly.

He turned, saluted the Empress with the blade, then slid it back into its sheath with deliberate care.

“Your sword,” Zion said, voice deceptively mild, “appears to work.”

Nervous laughter died quickly.

“Again,” she said. “This time, with nothing but your hands.”

◇ ◇ ◇

Thirty fresh dummies were dragged in, set up in a tighter pattern —two rings this time, more space between each.

He stepped back into the center, rolling his shoulders.

“Core,” he thought. “Internal channeling only. Elements on my cue. No aids.”

Confirm: deactivating exoskeletal augmentation. Elemental routing to limbs active. Recommend caution at current output levels.

He flexed his fingers.

Fire in the blood. Lightning in the nerves. Air at the edges of motion. Earth in the soles. Water in the shifting weight.

He looked up at the watching faces.

They wanted a reason to be afraid.

He would give them one.

He moved.

No sword now to focus attention. Just a man—bare hands, bare feet—attacking straw and wood.

The first punch landed with a crack like a small thunderclap. Lightning rode his arm, flaring blue-white at the knuckles exactly as they struck. The dummy's chest caved in, the post behind it snapping backward.

He didn't stop.

A spinning kick whispered past the head of another dummy—the actual contact a thin line of compressed Air that sliced the neck clean through. The head dropped, rolled, came to rest against the foot of a courtier's chair.

A ripple ran through the onlookers.

He slammed a heel down near the base of three in a row, Earth-mode driven into the ground. The sand shuddered, a low shockwave rolling outward. All three posts cracked at their anchors, falling in different directions like felled trees.

Every movement was calculated: no wild flailing, no wasteful flares of power. Just devastating, precise applications.

A backfist here with a spark of Fire to char and weaken wood before a follow-up elbow shattered it. A low sweep where Water let his weight flow under a dummy's center of mass, tipping it onto a waiting stomp that exploded the torso.

He let them *see* the elements.

Let Fire flash visibly along his arm, but only at the point of impact. Let Air ripple off his foot in a visible shimmer. Let a tracing of golden-brown Earth creep up his calves when he rooted hard enough to stop on a dime.

He wanted them not just to fear his speed, or his strength, but to understand that he was not casting spells the way their mages did.

He was *wearing* the elements.

Within a minute—less, really—only splinters remained.

The last dummy he took apart slowly.

He planted his feet, drew in breath, and let Lightning lace both hands. A flurry of blows, each landing in a blur, each accompanied by a small crack, each denting wood in a pattern that—when he stepped back—resolved into a delicately latticed ruin.

The dummy stood for one improbable second longer.

Then crumbled into a neat pile.

He exhaled.

The yard smelled of scorched straw, ozone, and faint, charred wood.

He bowed, hands at his sides, breathing just a little harder now.

For a heartbeat, no one moved.

Then the sound came—not applause, not here—but a sort of collective shifting. Chairs creaked. Someone muttered a prayer. A priestess's beads clicked too fast against her fingers.

On the dais, Zion sat forward, eyes bright and very, very *pleased*.

Beside her, Drabiretha's posture was ramrod straight, jaw tense, eyes warm with something that made his chest ache.

Pride. And something that looked, very faintly, like *mine*.

He did not look too closely at that.

“Court of Jade,” Zion said at last, her voice cutting cleanly through the noise. “Now you understand why he sits at my left. And why any hand that reaches for his collar will find its wrist thrown back to them in a bag.”

Uneasy laughter. It didn’t erase the image of thirty dummies turned to wreckage without a drop of blood spilled.

She turned her head, met his gaze.

“Well done,” she said.

Her smile was edged. Proud. Possessive.

Drabiretha’s, when he glanced at her, was no softer.

For a moment, twin dragon gazes pinned him—one crowned, one not, both radiating the same silent statement:

Ours.

It lit something in him.

A hot, dangerous spark of…belonging? Recognition? The old, half-forgotten thrill of being valued for what he could *do*, not just what he carried in his head.

A fire he was not at all comfortable examining here, under a hundred watching eyes and the weight of two women who could, between them, break nations.

He bowed once more, deep enough to buy himself the excuse of looking at the sand.

“Your Radiance,” he said. “Lunarch.”

“Dismissed,” Zion said, satisfaction thick in the word. “Go cool down before my courtiers forget how to breathe.”

He turned, walking off the sand on steady legs that did not feel steady.

Behind him, the palace yard buzzed with newly recalibrated fear.

Ahead of him, the path narrowed: between Dragons who smiled at him like a prize and the knowledge that in showing them his teeth, he'd also bared his throat.

Honesty has worked so far, he reminded himself.

Now he had to hope that the two women whose pride burned so hot at his display were as committed as they claimed to using his power to hold the Void—or this world's own worst habits—at bay.

And not to turn him into exactly the kind of weapon his dead universe had already paid for, once.

He was starting to suspect the Jade Palace was trying to kill him by *relaxation*.

The massage room was quieter than the baths—no echo, no steam, just muted light and the soft sound of hands working oil into skin. Three low tables, three sets of attendants. He lay face-down on one, head turned just enough to see Drabiretha on the next table and, beyond her, Zion.

All three of them half-covered in thin towels.

The masseuse's hands found knots in his back he hadn't known he had. The nanites hummed approval.

Muscular micro-tears identified. Circulation increased. Recommend compliance.

"For once," he thought back, "we agree."

“Your shoulders are a disaster,” Drabiretha observed lazily from the next table over. “You fight the entire palace in your sleep?”

“Only the paperwork,” he mumbled into the headrest.

Zion chuckled.

“You should see him when he’s *awake*,” she said. “He corrects my guards like they’re misbehaving schoolchildren. It’s adorable.”

“It is effective,” Drabiretha said. “Their knees already hate him less.”

“Fear and gratitude make excellent glue,” Zion agreed.

Her attendant shifted to her shoulders. Salkin did *not* look. He stared at the floor, counting the pattern in the tiles.

“So,” Zion said after a luxuriant pause. “We should discuss household management.”

Salkin’s stomach did an entirely unreasonable little flip.

Drabiretha made a faint sound that was either warning or long-suffering amusement.

“In particular,” Zion went on, “the concept of sister-wives.”

The masseuse’s hands paused in the middle of Salkin’s spine.

He lifted his head a fraction. “Your Radiance?”

“Oh, you don’t have this where you’re from?” Zion sounded delighted. “How sad. You have missed so many entertaining arguments.”

“Zion,” Drabiretha said, a thread of warning in her voice.

“What?” Zion said, all innocence. “He needs to understand us. This is *education*.”

Salkin lowered his head again, resigned.

“Explain,” he said, because ignorance was worse.

“In our Empire,” Zion said, “it is not uncommon—especially among sisters—for them to share the same man.” A little shrug. “Or men. Depends on appetite. Sister-wives. Sister-consorts. It keeps alliances tidy and evenings interesting.”

One of the attendants actually snorted before smothering it.

“It is also,” Drabiretha added dryly, “a source of endless drama. Territory disputes. Whose turn it is to hog the pillows. That sort of thing.”

“But at least,” Zion said, “when your sister is the one sharing, you know she’s less likely to sell *her* half of the bed out from under you.” She paused. “Usually.”

Salkin tried, very hard, to picture any of this through the lens of Jade law and not through the part of him that was acutely aware he was lying mostly naked two arm-lengths from the Empress and the Lunarch while they casually discussed *sharing men*.

The nanites helpfully nudged his hormone profile down again.

“So,” he said carefully, “sisters…sharing…is common.”

“Common enough that no one faints when it happens,” Zion said. “Especially among powerful houses. Why fight over which clan gets the favorite toy when you can both sign the same contract?”

Drabiretha made a face. “Please stop calling men toys.”

“Fine,” Zion said. “Assets. Lovers. Weapons. Advisors. Take your pick.”

“I am right here,” Salkin muttered.

“Yes,” Zion said sweetly. “We’ve noticed.”

The masseuse pressed into a knot near his shoulder blade that made him groan despite himself.

“Breathe,” she murmured. “You are turning to stone.”

“If only,” he said.

Zion let the teasing hang for a moment, then her tone shifted—lighter on the surface, edged underneath.

“In any case,” she said, “before I take you into my bed”—and the room *tightened* around that word—“or deeper into my council chambers, you need to learn more about us. And this nation. And how not to accidentally trigger three wars by quoting one of your dead philosophers in the wrong hall.”

“I…agree,” he said, very carefully not reacting to the bed part.

“I suspected you might,” she said. “Which is why I am sending you to the Academy.”

He blinked, hard enough the face-rest creaked.

“The…Academy,” he repeated.

“Yes,” Zion said. “The Imperial Academy of Law and Aether. Where we send bright young Lunarch-brats to knock the stupid edges off them, and occasionally the odd promising mage. You will learn history, law, etiquette, and why half the rituals you’ve been side-eying exist at all.”

“And,” Drabiretha added, “you’ll be somewhere structured. Fewer knives per square yard. We can both breathe while you absorb more context.”

“Also,” Zion said, smug now, “I am very curious how fast someone like you chews through their curriculum. My money is on ‘alarmingly.’”

The idea of going back to something like…school…made a strange mix of dread and relief coil in his gut.

Books. Structure. Rules. Fewer random throne-room tests.

“Alone?” he asked.

Zion snorted. “You? Alone? No. I’m not *stupid*.” A rustle of cloth as she shifted. “You’ll go with an attendant from Moonhold. Someone who already knows how you panic.”

“Rhoena,” Drabiretha said.

It was not a suggestion.

Salkin let his head drop back down.

Of course.

Zion stretched, sending little ripples through the water he wasn’t looking at.

“In any case,” she said, voice going lazy again, “this will be good for everyone. You learn us. The court gets used to seeing you as something other than a walking disaster. The Academy shakes itself awake. My cousin who runs it will either thank me or send me very colorful letters.”

“And when I’m done?” he asked quietly.

“Then,” Zion said, “we see whether you belong more at my map-table, my war-room, or my bed. Or all three.” A smile in her voice. “Don’t worry, traveler. We have time.”

That *did not* make him less worried.

But the decision, as always, had already been made.

◇ ◇ ◇

Two weeks later he stood at the gates of the Imperial Academy with Rhoena at his side and the mask of the Empress's Chosen over his face.

The mask was light, cool against his skin. White lacquer, edged in jade, shaped like a stylized dragon's face. It covered the upper half of his features: eyes, brow, the bridge of his nose. The mouth was left free.

To the casual observer, it said *property of the Throne*.

To those who could read its subtle sigils, it said more: untouchable by local law. Off-limits to recruiters. Empress's experiment.

Rhoena looked deeply unimpressed by all of it.

"Feels like painting a target on you," she muttered, hand resting on the hilt of her sword.

"I thought the idea was the opposite," he said. His voice sounded strange behind the mask, slightly hollow.

"Oh, it'll keep people from *grabbing* you," she said. "It won't keep them from *thinking*. Or from trying to cozy up. Or from sending their daughters to sit next to you in lectures."

He grimaced. "The Empress did mention…sister-wives."

Rhoena made a face like she'd bitten into something sour.

"Of course she did," she said. "Try not to let them adopt you into any households without telling me first."

"That can happen?" he asked, appalled.

“With you?” she said. “Yes.”

The Academy loomed over them: a sprawling complex of courtyards and towers, banners in imperial green and neutral cream, the air humming with the subdued chaos of too many young minds in one place. Students and initiates flowed through the gate in waves—robes, practice leathers, the occasional nervous-looking noble in brand-new finery.

Conversations faltered as they saw the mask.

Whispers flicked ahead of them like birds.

“Empress’s chosen…”

“Is that him?”

“No collar…”

“Moonhold colors…”

Rhoena’s presence at his shoulder—Moonhold crest bright on her cloak, stance pure threat—kept the more reckless at bay. For now.

Salkin stood there a moment longer, taking it in.

New patterns. New wards. New knives, this time mostly metaphorical.

“Ready?” Rhoena asked, softer than he’d expected.

“No,” he said honestly. “But I will walk anyway.”

She grunted, something like approval.

“Good,” she said. “You learn fast. Let’s go teach an Academy full of children that the Empress’s latest bad idea has sharper teeth than they thought.”

He huffed a laugh despite himself.

Together, under a hundred curious eyes and the weight of a mask that made him both more and less visible, they stepped through the gates.

Into class. Into politics of a different flavor. Into, somehow, the next phase of whatever the Jade Empire meant to make of a man from a dead universe with dragons at his back.

Salkin stood before the gates, watching the students move through them.

He had been many things. A soldier. A guardian. A survivor. The last witness to a civilization that had conquered the very foundations of reality.

And now, apparently, he was going to be a student.

Alexia would have laughed herself silly.

The thought hurt. It always would.

But this time, alongside the pain, there was something else.

Core?

Yes, Salkin?

How much do we have left to learn?

There was a pause, so brief that only he would have noticed.

Insufficient data to calculate.

For the first time in months, the answer made him smile.

Good.

Rhoena glanced at him. “Something amusing, Grand Master?”

“Yes,” he answered, stepping toward the gates. “I think there might be.”

And together they entered.

END OF BOOK ONE

